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The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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Happening today

● **WHILE ENGLAND** has gained a 2-0 lead in the five-match series, India are set to face them for the 4th T20I in Bristol after a 125-run defeat in the 3rd match. Under captain Shreyas Iyer, the team is yet to win a T20 international.

● **VICE PRESIDENT** C P Radhakrishnan will begin his official visit to Bhubaneswar, during which he will also release the 'Odisha Deep Sea Fishing Mission Document', a roadmap designed to elevate local fishing capabilities while preserving marine ecosystems.

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INSIDE PAGES 5,8



MODI, SUBIANTO LAUNCH PROJECT TO CONSERVE PRAMBANAN TEMPLE

CHURCH BEING BUILT IN BENGAL VANDALISED, FIR REGISTERED

NATION PAGE 6

WHY WAYANAD TUNNEL TRAGEDY IS A 'MAN-MADE DISASTER'



The spot where the accused was killed in a 'police encounter' in West Bengal's Baruipur Tuesday night. EXPRESS/RELATED REPORT, P8

Accused in minor girl's rape and murder killed in Bengal police 'encounter'

Ravik Bhattacharya & Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 8

PRABHASH MONDOL, the main accused in the gangrape and murder of an 11-year-old in West Bengal's Baruipur, was shot dead in an encounter late Tuesday night.

According to the police, Mondol had been taken to the crime scene to reconstruct the crime as part of the investigation. Police alleged that he snatched a policeman's fire-

arm, fired once at the police party, and tried to escape. Police claimed they opened fire in retaliation, injuring Mondol. He was rushed to a hospital, where he was declared dead.

The encounter spot is barely 100 metres from where the girl's body was found inside a pond. According to officials, Mondol was taken there around 12.45 am. They said it had rained and the area was dark, and Mondol allegedly snatched the service weapon of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

assaulted, submitted their resignation letters, and have not returned to work since. "We don't want to work in a place where there's no assurance of security and no respect for us. People think government doctors have power or high salaries. I was working for only Rs 35,000 (per month). We work overtime every day," he told *The Indian Express*. The doctor, who said he did not want to be identified as he feared for his safety, added that he chose not to tell his mother about the assault. "My mother is a school teacher. She is a



Officers conduct a raid in southern California as part of 'Operation Hardball'. REUTERS

E. EXPLAINED

Long-term effect

Canada's statement on the Nijjar killing removes a major irritant in bilateral ties with India. The joint US-Canada-Europe operation also signals deepening international cooperation against Indian-origin gang networks spanning continents and entangling members of the Indian diaspora.

RELATED REPORT P 6

CANADIAN SCRUTINY TO FBI'S OP: HOW NET TIGHTENED AROUND LAWRENCE BISHNOI

EXPRESS special

From Tihar to Rohini prisons: To decongest, Delhi Govt looks for land in 48 urban villages

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, July 8

THE DELHI government has commissioned a survey of the 48 recently-declared 'urban villages' to identify land for the relocation and expansion of the capital's prison infrastructure, *The Indian Express* has learned. Sources said the office of the Director General (Prisons) has issued an order constituting five committees, each comprising four members, to carry out the survey. "The purpose is to identify land for the decongestion of Delhi's prisons as well as for setting up a training institute," a government source said. The three prison complexes in Delhi are bursting at the seams — according to official figures, their 14 prisons together house 19,500 prisoners, almost double the sanctioned capacity of 10,026.



Tihar is one of the largest prisons in the world. EXPRESS FILE

Tihar is already one of the largest prisons in the world. The Rohini Central Jail was established in Badli, northwest Delhi, in 2004 as an extension of Tihar. A third jail complex with six prisons and a capacity of 3,776 inmates opened in Mandoli in northeast Delhi in 2016. The five committees have been assigned four specific

tasks, officials said. "First, they will conduct a survey of available land. Second, they will identify suitable land parcels for the relocation and expansion of Delhi's prisons. Third, they will coordinate with the agencies concerned to collect and verify land-related information.

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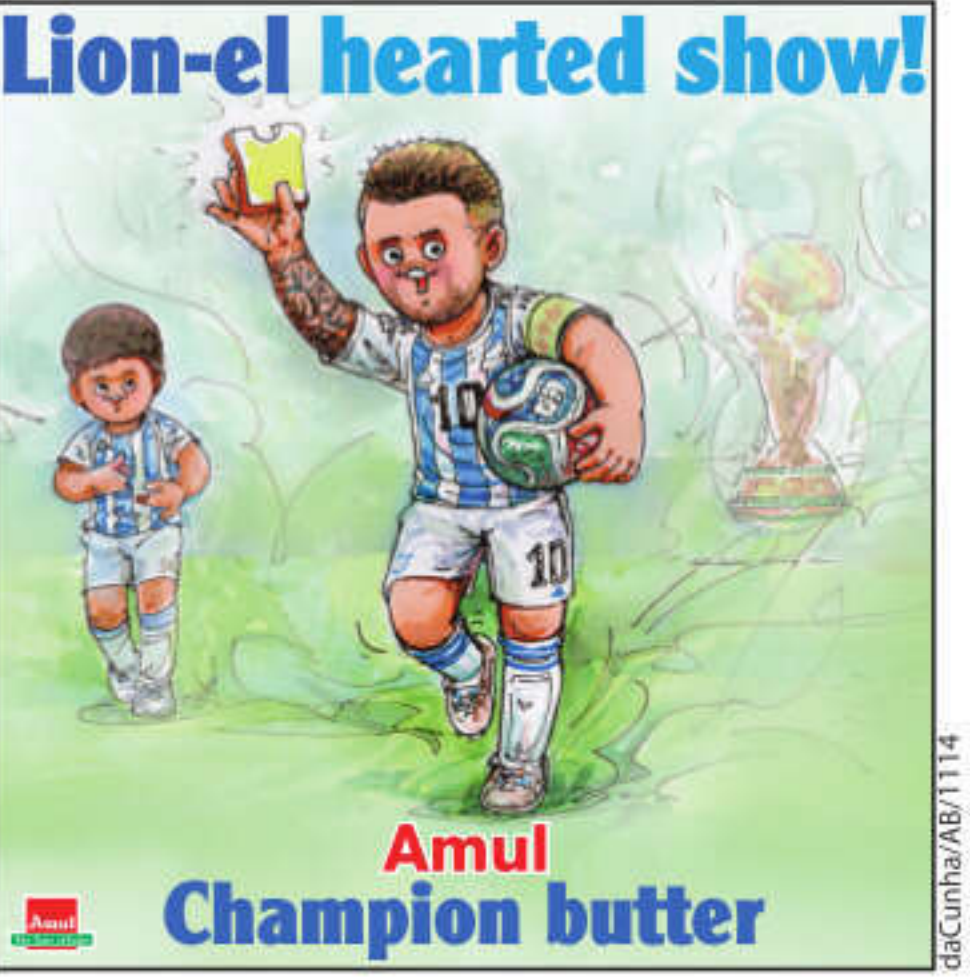
Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



Not 'gudda-guddi ka khel': Baghel rules out leadership change in Punjab Cong

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, July 8

A WEEK ago, the Congress high command would have thought it had the factionalism in its Punjab unit under control. Facing a push from a section of leaders to replace the state party president, it had managed to strike a delicate balance. But on Wednesday, it appeared to be falling apart, and at the centre of this — like in a similar crisis five years ago — is



'New Zealand, working with India, needs to remake case for a rules-based system'

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 8

NEW ZEALAND Prime Minister Christopher Luxon says he is confident of the strength and potential of ties between his country and India, as Narendra Modi arrives in Auckland Friday for the first visit by an Indian Prime Minister to New Zealand in four decades.

In an exclusive interview with *The Indian Express*, outlining economic, defence, security, and people-to-people ties as the three pillars of India and New Zealand ties, Luxon set this against the "inflection point" in global geopolitics where the world has moved from "a rules-based system to a power-based system, a multilateral system to a multipolar system". "We see an America that is talking America first with a fix-

ation on the Western Hemisphere. We see China wanting to have influence in our Indo-Pacific region. We also see Russia illegally invading a sovereign nation in Ukraine and wanting to dominate in Europe, and so it's natural that there is a real inflection point," Luxon said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

THE WORLD

PAGE 12



ACCORD TO END IRAN WAR IS 'OVER', WILL LAUNCH NEW STRIKES: TRUMP

● 'I don't want to deal with them... They're scum,' said Trump when asked if the MoJ was over.
● Brent crude futures leapt more than 5%, the most in a day since late May, to \$78.48 a barrel.



Former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi. FILE

former CM Charanjit Singh Channi. In a snub to Channi who

wants to be the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee president going into the elections, and the group backing his claim, All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary Bhupesh Baghel on Wednesday reiterated there would be no leadership change, saying such things were not a "gudda-guddi ka khel (child's play)". Baghel, who held a series of meetings for the third straight day at the Congress headquarters in Chandigarh, ruled

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● SHIV SENA CORPORATOR ARRESTED FOR ASSAULT AT THANE HOSPITAL

'I was the only male doctor, so I became their punching bag... fear for my safety'

Purnima Sah
Mumbai, July 8

FOR TWO days after he was assaulted inside Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation's (KDMC) Shastrinagar Hospital by Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre, the 26-year-old resident medical officer (RMO) says he lived in fear, constantly changing locations after allegedly receiving threatening phone calls and messages, and being followed by unknown persons. On Tuesday, he, and four other staff members who were

PAGE 1 anchor



single parent, and I am her only child. I don't have the courage to tell her what happened. I cannot imagine what she will go through if she knows. Right

now, I am just trying to survive," he said. Hours after Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre surrendered before the police on



Shastrinagar Hospital in Dombivli, Thane; (above) Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre. RELATED REPORT, PAGE 8

Wednesday evening and was arrested along with his aides, the doctor said he felt a sense of relief but rejected Mhatre's claim that he had not assaulted

a woman doctor. "He has tried to shift the focus by highlighting this, knowing that it is a sensitive issue. But that does not justify the assault on a male doctor. No camera angle can hide the truth of what actually happened." "I feel relieved... I am grateful to everyone who stood by me and brought the truth to light. I hope this sends a strong message — that no politician, or anyone else, will dare to assault doctors and any medical staff in the future," he said. According to the FIR registered at Vishnunagar police station, the doctor has been work-

ing as an RMO at the hospital for nearly five months. On Monday, he was on evening duty, from 3 pm to 10 pm, along with another woman doctor, two nurses and a hospital attendant. According to the doctor, the trouble began around 6 pm, when the relatives of a woman asked for a bed in the neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) before delivery. He said the woman's ultrasound had shown the umbilical cord was wrapped around the foetus, prompting the gynaecologist to advise an emergency caesarean section. As the baby was anticipated to require intensive neo-

natal care after birth, the family insisted on a bed in the NICU. "Shastrinagar Hospital has only one emergency NICU bed, which was already occupied by another critically ill newborn suffering from respiratory distress. The family wanted us to give them that bed, and discharge the baby who had already been admitted. We explained that was medically impossible. We assured that we would arrange treatment at another KDMC hospital with NICU facilities, but they insisted on Shastrinagar Hospital," he recalled.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Chhattisgarh HC rejects petition against ‘Gayatri Mantra’ in schools

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, July 8

THE CHHATTISGARH High Court rejected a petition seeking an order to stop the government from enforcing the recitation of Hindu hymns in state-funded schools, stating that the government order is not mandatory and that constitutional provisions do not ban moral instruction "dissociated from any denominational doctrines".

This comes after the state education department made the 'Gayatri Mantra' and other Hindu prayers mandatory at morning assemblies—a move the Opposition termed as a move to enforce religious instruction in educational institutions.

A petition challenging the order in the HC argued that the direction violates Articles 14 (Right to Equality), 21 (Protection of Life and Personal Liberty), 25 (Freedom of Religion), 28(1) (which prohibits religious instruction in educational institutions wholly maintained out of State funds), 29 (protecting the cultural and educational interests of minorities and citizens) and 30 (empowering religious and linguistic minorities to establish and administer their own educational institutions) of the Constitution. Filed on June 12, 2026, the petition said the order "creates an impermissible situation wherein students from minority communities may feel compelled to participate in and recite religious practices that do not belong to their faith" and "amounts to imparting religious instructions and promoting a particular religion in Government Schools, which is constitutionally barred".

Counsel for the state opposed the petition, calling it "politically motivated". The state counsel said the order "involves neither religious instruction nor conversion" and is "in perfect alignment with National Education Policy, 2020, which mandates the integration of the Indian Knowledge Systems to foster cultural awareness."

"The terms 'compulsory' and 'ensure' in the Government Order... relate strictly to school administration and discipline and do not entail any form of religious coercion," the state said. "The order prescribes no negative consequences... against any student who chooses not to recite these verses."

The traditional verses are ancient Indian philosophies promoting universal well-being, ecological balance and gratitude the state argued, describing the Gayatri Mantra as an "invocation for sharp intellect and wisdom", a "scientifically and pedagogically backed cognitive exercise", and "none of these invocations contain any religious dogma, denominational propaganda or sectarian rituals."

The judge said the petitioners had failed to place any material on record to show violation of any fundamental right or any individual or direct injury.

On the religious aspect, the judge said, "the expression 'religious instruction' used in Article 28(1) has a restricted meaning. It signifies that the teaching of religious customs, rituals, practices and modes of worship is strictly prohibited in educational institutions wholly maintained out of State funds."

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Nijjar

Canada and Europe led to the arrest of 24 people connected to three Indian crime syndicates, now charged with a series of crimes including Nijjar's assassination, the DoJ said Wednesday.

Members of the three gangs have been charged with targeted killings, shootings, extortion and narcotics trafficking across borders, offences carrying up to life imprisonment, the DoJ said.

In Ottawa, RCMP Deputy Commissioner Lisa Moreland told CBC News: "There is no evidence to suggest that through this organised crime syndicate investigation and the charges laid forward that Indian government officials would be charged or involved in this... nothing has come out to link the Indian government."

Nijjar, a Canadian citizen, was shot dead outside a gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia, on June 18, 2023 -- a killing that ruptured ties between New Delhi and Ottawa after Trudeau's allegations. India's Ministry of External Affairs rejected the allegations as "absurd and motivated" and "baseless".

The fallout saw diplomats withdrawn, visa restrictions imposed and consulates shut for nearly two years. After Mark

Carney became Canada's Prime Minister last May, both sides worked to insulate bilateral ties from the Nijjar investigation, reinstating envoys, lifting visa curbs and setting a new trade target.

A separate US indictment

had earlier linked Nijjar's killing to the attempted murder of Khalistani separatist Gurbat Singh Pannun in New York, through intercepted communications and shared targets. In February, Indian national Nikhil Gupta pleaded guilty in US federal court to murder-for-hire and conspiracy charges in the Pannun plot.

The US indictment on Tuesday said Bishnoi ordered the killing of 45-year-old Nijjar, referred to as "HSN" in court documents. While Bishnoi is lodged in Sabarmati Central Jail, the FBI has announced a \$50,000 reward for information leading to the arrest of Satinder Singh alias Goldy Brar and is likely to seek Bishnoi's extradition.

In all, 37 people were charged in the indictment. Those arrested in the US -- 11 in California, one each in Indiana and Georgia -- were expected to make initial court appearances later Wednesday. Ten fugitives are being sought, including seven in the US, two in India, one in Europe.

The DoJ noted an indictment is merely an allegation: "All defendants are presumed innocent until proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt in a court of law." If convicted, many of the 37 face a mandatory minimum of 10 years, up to life imprisonment.

The action follows a years-long investigation into Indian crime syndicates engaged in racketeering, targeted killings, extortion and narcotics trafficking whose impact is felt especially in the Indian diaspora, the DoJ said.

"Transnational criminal gangs who spread fear, drugs, and violence will face the full

force of justice and the weight of the federal government," said First Assistant US Attorney Bill Essayli. "Working together, law enforcement in the US, Canada, Europe, and Asia are determined to target and dismantle these criminal organisations wherever they operate. There is no safe harbour for these thugs," he said.

It is believed that law enforcement agencies in India also collaborated with the investigators on the case.

According to the US DoJ, Bishnoi had delegated control to trusted lieutenants: Brar as North American leader; Rohit Godara (37), of Rajasthan as European leader; and, Sukhraj Singh Kang (58) of Punjab. They extorted victims via WhatsApp and other encrypted apps by threatening violence against them or their families, the DoJ said. Canada designated the Bishnoi enterprise a terrorist entity in September 2025.

The RCMP said in a statement: "Today, together with the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) Los Angeles, we announced several arrests and charges against the leaders of three global organised crime networks: Lawrence Bishnoi, Ravinder Dhandra and Jaggu Bhagwanpuria. These groups have been engaged in extortions, drug trafficking, kidnapping and widespread violence -- namely the killing of Hardeep Singh Nijjar -- in Canada and the United States."

The statement said that the RCMP "played a pivotal role in today's outcomes", calling it "a big moment" for the force "and for public safety in Canada, the

United States and around the world". The arrests and search warrants worldwide were the result of "combined efforts of Canadian and American law enforcement over the past two years," the RCMP said.

While most of the arrests occurred in the US, three individuals from British Columbia were taken into custody on Provisional Arrest Warrants, with extradition to follow even as three search warrants were executed in West Vancouver, White Rock and Surrey.

"Tuesday's coordinated operation strikes at the heart of three brutal transnational organisations that have terrorised families, exploited communities, and stolen lives through ruthless acts of violence in the US and abroad," said Patrick Grandy, FBI Los Angeles Assistant Director-in-Charge.

The second gang, run by Bhagwanpuria, had 17 members charged with murder-for-hire, drug and weapons trafficking, kidnapping and extortion in the US and Canada.

This group corrupted law enforcement officers in India and partnered with corrupt government officials, including to assist in extortion schemes, the DoJ said while referring to the case of Punjab Police officer Gurinderjit Singh, who allegedly engaged in extortion activities on behalf of the gang.

The indictment charged the gang run by Dhandra of Vancouver, and 10 others, with running a drug distribution network smuggling bulk cocaine and methamphetamine to trafficking organisations in the US, Canada and Mexico.

Indian agencies

agencies, through the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), also shared a list of gangsters based in the US and other foreign countries, along with evidence. The meetings gained pace over the last one-and-a-half months, before the coordinated crackdown by law enforcement agencies in the US, Canada and Europe.

"After the deportation of gangster Anmol Bishnoi from the US (in November last year), who is wanted as the main plotter in the murder of NCP leader Baba Siddique, coordination between India's central agencies and US law enforcement agencies improved significantly," said sources.

In their recent meetings, the central agencies are learnt to have shared and verified with US officials a list of associates of Lawrence Bishnoi and Goldy Brar, along with details of their possible hideouts.

"In the last five years, several of their associates have been arrested here, and, during questioning, many of them disclosed details about Lawrence Bishnoi, his associates and their activities abroad. On the basis of their disclosures and technical surveillance, evidence was gathered against them," said sources.

Last year, US officials also visited the NIA headquarters in Delhi, where they shared their concerns about alleged links between Indian-origin gangsters and US drug cartels. They also shared a list of names and

sought assistance in taking action against them.

Besides the killings of Siddique and singer Sidhu Moosewala, Lawrence Bishnoi has also been linked to multiple threats against actor Salman Khan. Arrested in 2014, he is now lodged in a jail in Gujarat.

Jaggu Bhagwanpuria has also been arrested and is lodged in a jail in Assam since March 24 last year.

Both Goldy Brar and Rohit Godara are absconding. According to agencies, Goldy Brar, an aide of Lawrence Bishnoi, is suspected to be working with Azerbaijan-based Rohit Godara. Lawrence Bishnoi is now associated with Canada-based Noni Rana and US-based Harry Boxer.

A central agency official said investigations in multiple cases had revealed that most of these US-based gangsters were in touch with Pakistan-based smugglers for bringing huge quantities of narcotics into India, and for targeted killings.

"Apart from using drones to smuggle narcotics consignments, large consignments brought into India by gangster-smugglers are mostly routed through the sea. They are currently using VPNs to mask their locations and encrypt communication, making it difficult to trace them. They also use encrypted messaging apps for secure communication, and it is difficult to track their channels," said sources.

‘Became punching bag’

Around 7.30 pm, the patient's brother telephoned the RMO asking that a bed be arranged. "Shortly afterwards, I started receiving repeated phone calls from KDMC corporator Ramesh Mhatre, who insisted that we have to arrange a bed by any means. When I explained to him that no bed was available, he started abusing and threatening me... There was no way to create a new NICU bed. We cannot discharge another critically ill newborn," he said.

He said that around 8 pm, four-five men, including the corporator, and a woman barged into the labour ward, where he, a woman doctor, two nurses and a hospital attendant were on duty. "The group abused the medical staff, damaged hospital property, including the oxygen storage area, and physically assaulted us. They struck me on the head with a hospital register and knocked my mobile phone out of my hand as I attempted to contact senior hospital officials," he said.

"I was the only male doctor there, so I became their punching bag. They repeatedly punched me on my face, head, chest and abdomen. The female doctor, both nurses and the attendant were also assaulted. They didn't spare anyone," he said. Despite the assault, he said,

the pregnant woman was shifted to KDMC's Vasant Valley Hospital, where NICU facilities were available.

"This is the first time something like this has happened to me, but not the first attack in this hospital. Another male doctor was assaulted twice, a female doctor was assaulted around six months ago. Senior officials suppressed those incidents. This FIR happened only because the video became viral as there was a CCTV camera," he alleged.

'We just wanted treatment'

Sadhana Karande, the pregnant woman's mother, said her daughter was rushed to the Shastrinagar Hospital after being told she needed urgent medical attention.

Karande said the hospital informed them that no NICU bed was available, and advised them to shift her elsewhere.

"With no other option left, I called Ramesh Mhatre dada for help. He asked me to hand the phone to the hospital staff on duty, and I did. I agree that the medical staff should not have been assaulted, but he was only trying to help us. As a mother, I will think only about my daughter's well-being, won't I? Because of him, my daughter got a bed in another hospital, where she eventually delivered her baby," she said.



AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

MAHANAGAR SEVA SADAN

(S.W.M. Engineering Department)

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed that, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MOEF&CC), New Delhi has granted prior Environmental Clearance (EC) for Establishment of Secured Municipal Solid Waste Landfill Site (Inert waste only) (Phase-II) of capacity 500 TPD including construction, operation and Management at Survey No. 337/P, Shahwadi Ekatra, Gvaspur Ahmedabad, Gujarat by M/s Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation, vide EC Identification No. EC25A3402GJ-5971258N, dated: 25/11/2025. A copy of the approval letter can also be seen on the website of PARIVESH Portal, New Delhi, i.e. <https://parivesh.nic.in>.

MUNICIPAL COMMISSIONER

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(A Statutory body under aegis of Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Govt. of India)

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DEANAC-25012/1/2023-DEAN ACADEMIC/5843 Dated: 4th July, 2026

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PRESIDENT
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Baghel

out replacing Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the state Congress president. In a sharp riposte, the Channi camp said Baghel's remarks were of no consequence as no leader of worth in the state had met him. They also accused the former Chhattisgarh CM of putting up a show for the high command by holding "inconsequential meetings and dinners".

"When the high command has taken a decision, that has not changed. Ko'i gudda guddi ka khel hai kya ke baar baar nirnay badla jayega (Is this child's play that the decision will be changed over and over again)?" said Baghel, flanked by Warring. He added that he would soon meet Channi.

"I spoke to him (Channi). The meeting will take place. (Sukhjinder Singh) Randhawa will also come and meet," Baghel said, adding that he told the

two leaders that if needed, he would visit them at their homes. "I have met other leaders too at their homes, and I can meet them too," he said.

However, the remarks did not go down well with the pro-Channi group. "Charanjit Singh Channi himself is sitting at his home either in Kharar or in Morinda. He is not out of town or anything. Why does Baghel not go and meet him? Tripat Rajinder Singh Bajwa (Fatehgarh Churian MLA) is in town, Gurkirat Kotli (former minister) is in town. Why are they not being visited by Baghel? The fact is that senior leaders do not want to meet him. Partap Singh Bajwa (the Leader of the Opposition in the state) has now gone to Qadian after meeting him and did not attend the dinner at Rana K P Singh's house. Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa is also in Gurdaspur," said a leader close to the Jalandhar MP.

Another leader claimed that Baghel and Warring were trying to portray that they had

everything under control. "The fact is that 90% of former Congress ministers have not met Baghel in the three days that he has been here. He has not called a meeting of the sitting MLAs because he knows that the bulk of them will not attend. He is only meeting coordinators and assorted tier-three leadership because the top rung has given him short shrift," he said.

The Channi faction said it would rather meet Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi once he returns from abroad. "What does Baghel know about Punjab or the leadership of Punjab Congress? Today, he could not even name all three working presidents of the party. He is the one who has pushed for Raja Warring's retention as the PCC president and we do not want to waste time meeting him and giving him credence. In any case, all his focus is on Chhattisgarh and not Punjab," said a leader.

Another leader said they

New Zealand PM

"The benefit for a country like New Zealand," he added, "is that as a free trader, as a small country, since World War II, we have been a huge beneficiary of the rules-based system, because small countries are treated the same as large countries, and big ones don't bully little ones."

This is where the relationship with Delhi comes in, Luxon said. "New Zealand, working with India and other like-minded friends, needs to remake the case for a rules-based system." He also backed the demand for reform in this, agreeing with the Indian view. "In many cases, the Global South countries of India and

Brazil haven't really been part of that system that was created after World War II, and so we need to remake that case," Luxon said.

About the bilateral ties between India and New Zealand, he said: "We've been friends for over 100 years, we actually are at different ends of the Indo-Pacific region and haven't really had a lot that actually binds us together to drive a future agenda. Prime Minister Modi and I have talked about these two countries that actually have a very similar view and a very similar set of values and actually should be doing more together and should have a much broader and deeper

relationship."

On immigration opportunities for Indians in New Zealand, especially given the changed environment in the US, Luxon said: "We see it as a huge opportunity. All around the world you're seeing countries and democracies in the West react with an anti-immigrant bias and sentiments. That creates opportunity for New Zealand because it means that talented folk who may have headed to the US can now reappraise our educational institutions. We are an English-speaking country, we have an advanced economy, we are a very safe country, and importantly, we have very good educational institutions. We have been very welcoming of Indians to New Zealand on a number of levels."

Inspector

When contacted, Gurinderjit said he had not received any official notice. He said he did not know why he had been named in the case.

According to the US press statement, in April this year, Gurlal Singh, a 22-year-old illegal immigrant from India living in Stockton, California, and an alleged member of the Jaggu Bhagwanpuria gang, provided the name and details of a US-based person (identified in court papers as "Victim 2") to Gurinderjit. The police officer then allegedly contacted the person's father and threatened to implicate the family in a January 2026 murder of a man identified as "B.S."

According to FBI, on April 13, Gurinderjit told the father of "Victim 2" that charges would be filed against him for the murder. On April 16, he allegedly demanded payment of US\$ \$400,000, threatening to name all three family members as accused.

The murder occurred in

Miani, in Hoshiarpur district of Punjab, on January 14 this year. According to police, three youths arrived on a motorcycle, and two of them opened fire on a shop owner, Balwinder Singh, and his friend, Lakhwinder Singh, discharging a total of seven rounds. While Balwinder Singh was shot in the chest and died on the spot, Lakhwinder Singh was injured in the attack.

Shortly after the incident, gangsters Gurlal Dadiana and Gurdev Jassal, in a social media post, claimed responsibility for the killing. As per the US indictment, in May this year, following a press conference in Punjab where the authorities named the family in the murder, Gurinderjit allegedly continued putting pressure on them, referencing instructions from Gurlal Singh and saying that "they didn't pay... the whole amount that was agreed upon". The indictment states members of Bhagwanpuria group "corrupted law enforcement officers in India and partnered with corrupt government officials" to assist in extortion schemes and to file baseless cases against rivals.

Prisons

Fourth, they will submit a detailed report along with their recommendations within the stipulated timeframe," said a top source. *The Indian Express* had reported in May that the Standing Committee, the highest decision-making body of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, had taken the decision to declare the last remaining 48 villages in Delhi as 'urban villages'.

Once a village is declared as 'urban', it ceases to be governed by the agricultural land-use norms of the Delhi Land Reforms Act, 1954 (DLR Act), which prohibits landowners from using agricultural land for housing, commercial, and industrial activity.

Also, the village comes under the purview of the DMC Act and the DDA Act, and Gram Sabha land is transferred to the DDA under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

Rural groups had long demanded changes in the DLR Act, arguing that farming was no

longer a viable economic activity in the capital. With the restrictions having been lifted, landowners in these 48 urban villages now have greater flexibility to use or sell their land for a range of development projects.

Delhi has both the largest number of central jails in the country as well as the highest occupancy rate of 194.6% as of December 31, 2024, according to the Prison Statistics India 2024 report of the NCRB.

Delhi also has the highest number of undertrial prisoners (3,979, or 11.3% of the total) after Haryana (4,358, or 12.4%), the NCRB data show.

In April 2025, the Delhi Prisons Department had written to DDA asking the Authority to identify and allot 400 acres of land for a new prison complex. The proposal had come after CM Rekha Gupta announced in the 2025-26 Budget that the government intended to shift Tihar Jail out of its current location.

Prison officials have said the large population of inmates puts great pressure on water supply, sewerage, and waste management systems.

Bengal

an officer identified as Rony Sarkar. Speaking to *The Indian Express* on Wednesday, his mother, Sandhya, said she had told the police that she did not want to see his body. "I grieve as a mother, but I am at peace that he got the punishment for his crime," she said. "I don't want to see him. No one will go. He did not listen to us," she said, calling him an "addict". Later in the day, however, she and Mondol's wife went to the hospital where his body was kept.

Baruipur in West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district has been on edge after the body of a minor girl was found dumped in a pond on Sunday. An autopsy confirmed sexual assault, and police registered a case under charges of murder and gang-rape and under the POCSO Act. Four people have been arrested, and a six-member SIT is probing the incident.

Mondol, Ananda Sardar and Dibakar Sardar were among the first to be arrested. Another accused, Kabir Mollah, was arrested in Basirhat, North 24 Parganas, on Tuesday night. In the days following the incident, a man suspected of being involved in the crime was lynched in Baruipur. CM Suwendu Adhikari said the man was innocent.

According to police sources, CCTV footage from near the crime scene had led to the breakthrough. The footage showed

the girl shortly before she went missing on Saturday. It also showed Mondol accompanying her. Police have so far arrested 20 people in connection with the violence during the protests. An FIR has been filed against CPM's central committee member Sujan Chakraborty and the party's youth leader Layek Ali.

He also responded to allegations that the police delayed the search for the girl. "We filed a missing person complaint at the Baruipur police station around 9 pm on Saturday. Had the police started a search operation then and gone through the CCTV footage, my daughter could have been found alive," the minor's mother had told *The Indian Express* earlier. The CM said he has asked the DGP to submit a report within 72 hours. "If there is any negligence regarding the time taken after the complaint was lodged, action will be taken," he told reporters.

TMC MP Mahua Moitra, meanwhile, said on X, "What is going on West Bengal Police? Bengalis, please welcome new Bengal - Uttar Pradesh 2.0. BJP Bengal is no government. This is jungle law." Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya said the party had made a promise to the people of Bengal ahead of polls -- "bhoi (fear) out, bhorsha (faith) in". "This was the PM's message. We are doing what we said in our manifesto. Suwendu Adhikari is the CM, and the state government has taken the steps it should have. No criminal or rapist will be spared," he said.

Waterlogging, traffic snarls persist as rain ravages Gurgaon for second day in a row

Nirbhay Thakur & Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 8

IN JUST three hours — from 12 pm to 3 pm on Wednesday — Gurgaon received 33 mm of rain, bringing the city to a grinding halt for the second consecutive day.

As a result, commuters found themselves battling traffic snarls while also wading through murky, ankle-deep water, as several parts of the city witnessed waterlogging.

The brunt of the rainfall was felt across four main stretches. Vehicles struggled to move through a heavily flooded Atul Kataria Chowk, while two-wheeler riders struggled to make their way through a waterlogged stretch near the Rapid Metro in Sikanderpur.

Similar scenes of chaos prevailed outside the Rajiv Chowk petrol pump, where traffic came to a standstill in the wake of heavy downpour. Pedestrians and motorists alike had to contend with flooded lanes near Sheela Mata Road.

Meanwhile, a small portion near the Gurudwara side of Medanta Road witnessed temporary water accumulation, as cleaning and restoration work on the adjoining surface drain was underway.

Officials at the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA), however, claimed that most of the 42 identified waterlogging-prone locations across sectors 1 to 80 remained free from prolonged water accumulation.

GMDA Chief Executive Of-



A flooded Atul Kataria Chowk in Gurgaon on Wednesday.

ficer (CEO) PC Meena said that the authority had identified 42 vulnerable locations that had witnessed recurring waterlogging during previous monsoon seasons. “To address these issues, the Engineering Wing carried out extensive drainage strengthening works... to enhance the capacity of the city’s stormwater drainage network. At majority of these locations, no significant waterlogging was reported. At a few locations where water accumulated temporarily due to the intensity of rain, it receded within around two hours, ensuring that traffic movement remained largely uninterrupted and public inconvenience was kept to a minimum,” he said.

According to Meena, among the locations where the interventions proved particularly effective were AIT Chowk, St. Xavier’s School Junction, Tulip Chowk, Medanta Road, Artemis Hospital Road, Rezang La Chowk, Sector 22/23, and Sector 45/46 Road.

He further claimed that no waterlogging was reported anywhere along the Southern Peripheral Road, including the Golf Course Extension Road corridor.

The Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) said in a statement that its pre-monsoon dewatering efforts successfully increased pond storage capacity in key waterlogging-prone areas over the last two days.

“Ponds in Palra, Dhanwapur, Darbaripur, Tulip Chowk, and Khedki Majra successfully accumulated 10-12 feet of rainwater, aiding groundwater recharge and reducing drainage pressure. Permanent drainage improvements yielded significant relief in previously flood-prone areas, including Rajendra Park, Surat Nagar, Sector 17, and wards 30 and 32. Despite 87 mm of rainfall in some areas, effective storm-water management and active field teams...ensured smooth water discharge,” it stated.



At Kartavya Path in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL

Delhi, Noida breathe cleanest air in 10 months; temperature dips in NCR

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 8

SUCCESSIVE SPELLS of rain in the NCR over the past two days led to a sharp improvement in the air quality in Delhi and Noida, with both recording its cleanest air since September last year.

At 59, Delhi’s Air Quality Index (AQI) was in the ‘Satisfactory’ category on Wednesday — the lowest since September 4, 2025, when it stood at 58 (‘Satisfactory’).

Noida also breathed its cleanest air in 10 months as the AQI Wednesday improved to 42 (‘Good’) from 118 (‘Moderate’) a day before — the last low of 40 being recorded on September 2, last year. The AQI in Gurgaon improved from 208 (‘Poor’) on Tuesday to 128 (‘Moderate’) Wednesday.

So far in July, Delhi has recorded ‘Satisfactory’ air quality (AQI 51-100) on three days, while it was ‘Moderate’ (AQI 101-200) on the rest of the days. June had three days with ‘Satisfactory’ AQI, with the monthly average AQI standing at 141.

Above-normal rain

The Ridge weather station in Delhi recorded 54.3 mm of rainfall during the past 24 hours, taking July’s figure so far to 79.1 mm — about 154 per cent above normal for the period. Ayanagar recorded 51 mm of rainfall so far this month, around 45 per cent above its long-period normal of 35.1 mm. Gurgaon, meanwhile, recorded 83 mm of rainfall till Wednesday morning.

Delhi’s base station at Saf-

● Skywatch

Forecast: July 9, 2026

Generally cloudy sky. Light to moderate rain

MAX: 29-31

5.6°C above normal

MIN: 22-24

5.9°C below normal

● AQI Tracker

Bawana
Satisfactory
AQI: 100

Anand Vihar
Satisfactory
AQI: 95

Aya Nagar
Satisfactory
AQI: 56

Najafgarh
Satisfactory
AQI: 54

- Good (0-50)
- Satisfactory (51-100)
- Moderate (101-200)
- Poor (201-300)
- Very Poor (301-400)
- Severe (401-500)



Screengrab from a purported video of the incident.

Taxi driver seen wielding rod in viral clip of road rage on Delhi-Dwarka e-way

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 8

A HEATED road rage confrontation involving the drivers of three cars near the Dwarka Expressway Tunnel in Delhi, captured on video and widely shared online, is now under police investigation.

The purported video of the incident which took place on Tuesday evening shows a taxi driver holding a wooden rod, grabbing the driver of a Wagon R by the collar, and shouting at him on the Dwarka Expressway.

The driver of a Kia Seltos is seen stopping nearby and getting out of the vehicle before getting involved in an argument with both the men.

According to the police, they were informed about the incident through a PCR call, made around 7.44 pm on Tuesday.

“The caller alleged that following a minor collision between his WagonR and a white Maruti Ertiga taxi, the taxi driver attempted to assault him with a stick. In self-defence, the caller reportedly pushed the taxi driver, who fell against a parked Kia Seltos, causing minor damage to the vehicle.

A purported video of the heated confrontation was widely shared online. Police said they are examining CCTV footage to trace the taxi driver involved.

The owner of the Kia Seltos stopped the caller seeking compensation, while the taxi driver allegedly fled the scene,” a police officer said.

PCR personnel reached the spot, where the caller informed them that the taxi driver had already left.

The caller and the owner of the Kia Seltos subsequently resolved the matter, the officer also said.

The caller later told police that he had returned home, the matter had been settled mutually, and that he did not wish to pursue any legal action, the officer added.

Police also said that footage from CCTV cameras installed in the area are being examined to ascertain the identity of the taxi driver and verify the sequence of events.

Why Delhi-Gurgaon e-way caved in

Devansh Mittal & Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 8

TRAFFIC CRAWLED on the Delhi-Gurgaon Expressway on Wednesday, as repair work was undertaken on a section near Narsinghpur that caved in after heavy rain on Tuesday.

The cave-in, caused by pipeline work and the rain, disrupted one of the NCR’s busiest arterial roads. Authorities had to barricade two lanes on the Jai-pur-bound carriageway, triggering major traffic congestion.

On Wednesday evening, all three lanes of the expressway were opened for traffic.

“Two out of three lanes had to be shut for traffic yesterday. While one of them was opened... due to rain, welding work undertaken on the remaining lane was stopped. But vehicles are being allowed to pass after iron plates were installed on the lane on a trial basis. The remaining welding work will be resumed once the weather improves,” an NHAI official said.

“All the lanes near the cave-in were restored for traffic at 7.35 pm,” ACP Traffic (Highway and HQ) Satyapal Yadav told *The Indian Express*.

The collapse took place at a location where the Gurugram Metropolitan Development

Authority (GMDA) is laying a pipe beneath National Highway 48. The incident left a large crater on the expressway.

The NHAI, in a statement, had said that the cave-in occurred when GMDA was carrying out pipe culvert pushing works. A culvert is a pipe for water that goes under a road.

“The GMDA was pushing one of its pipes from left to right, and we did not expect such heavy rainfall. The water eventually seeped in from the pipe that was being pushed in and emerged on the other end, which led the area to settle and crater in,” said an NHAI official.

A GMDA engineering team official present at the site blamed the cave-in on the persistent rain. “We were putting in place two pipes to connect to the temporary drain that is in process of being concretised and was carrying runoff. Because of the heavy rain, water seeped through. If it had rained even two days later, the cave-in would not have happened.”

“Nearby industries also tend to release their drainage directly here despite our instructions,” he added.

The cave-in resulted in a traffic jam stretching for kilometres, with commuters reporting de-

lays ranging from an hour to a couple of hours.

Traffic Police had to create diversions through Dwarka Expressway and Southern Peripheral Road. It also issued an advisory requesting corporate employees to work from home for the next few days.

“Minimising non-essential vehicular movement will greatly assist our traffic management teams in maintaining the flow of traffic and ensuring emergency services remain unobstructed,” the police said in a statement.

The NHAI official said they have told all agencies involved in pipe-pushing to stop such work until the monsoon ends. GMDA officials said the cave-in was covered up by 9 pm on Tuesday, and the remaining pipe installation work will be completed depending on the spells of rain ahead.

a-IDEA
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ICAR-National Academy of Agricultural Research Management
Rajendranagar, Hyderabad-500030, Telangana, India.
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a-IDEA, Technology Business Incubator of ICAR-NAARM Hyderabad, is looking for **Chief Operating Officer** on contractual basis. The details of Job description can be obtained from websites <https://naarm.org.in/announcements/careers/> or <https://aidea.naarm.org.in/career>
Eligible candidates can send resumes to careers.aidea@naarm.in on or before 23rd July 2026.
Sd/- Chief Executive Officer

TO CURB STAMP DUTY EVASION

Tighter norms for property registrations through GPAs

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 8

TO PLUG stamp duty evasion and curb fraudulent property transactions, the Delhi government has tightened norms for registration process through General Power of Attorney (GPA) documents — mandating closer scrutiny by sub-registrars. This would lead to adjudication before registration in several cases.

As per directions issued by the Revenue department, every GPA presented for registration will now be examined to determine if it is, in effect, a disguised sale of property. Officials have been asked to check whether the document mentions monetary consideration, transfers possession of the property, is irrevocable in nature, or grants permanent authority to sell, gift, transfer or mortgage the property. The government has now directed that GPAs executed in favour of persons other than close blood relatives — parents, spouse, children, siblings — will no longer be registered directly by sub-registrars, but referred to the Collector of Stamps.

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Industry body seeks easing of transit-linked norms to allow bigger homes

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 8

PRIVATE DEVELOPERS have urged the Union government to relax some of the affordability norms under Delhi's new transit-oriented development (TOD) policy, including allowing the construction of larger houses and giving builders greater flexibility in planning commercial and neighbourhood amenities, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

TOD is an urban development strategy that aims to create the maximum possible number of houses, shops, offices and recreational spaces near public transport facilities.

In April, the Union government had notified a new TOD policy for Delhi after previous attempts had failed to generate interest from private developers. The policy had opened up around 207 sq km of land located near Metro corridors for development.

A key objective of the policy is to make smaller and therefore, more affordable houses available in Delhi.

Developers, who want to avail of the higher floor area ratio (FAR) offered under the policy, have to use at least 65% of the total permissible FAR to build residential units of less than 100 sq m of built-up area.

The Delhi chapter of real estate industry body, National Real Estate Development Council (NAREDCO), wrote to the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) in May seeking that the 100 sq m rule be applied on carpet area instead of the built-up area.

"It is respectfully submitted that the benchmark should continue to be interpreted and applied on RERA carpet area basis so that there is clarity, standardisation and consistency for all stakeholders. Also, as per the new RERA guidelines, carpet area is the only unit of measurement for apartments allowed," the letter said.

Carpet area refers to the usable floor space within an apartment, while built-up area includes the carpet area along with the thickness of walls and, typically, balconies or terraces. Built-up area is usually 30% larger than the carpet area.

The industry body also argued that builders should be allowed to build 2.5 BHK and 3 BHK houses within 100 sq m.

"In Delhi's context, an affordable family home should ideally permit planning for a practical 2.5 BHK or 3 BHK configuration within the 100 sq m RERA carpet area threshold," the letter said, adding that this would better align the policy with the housing needs of

DDA opens application process

THE DDA on Wednesday opened the application process for builders seeking to undertake projects under the TOD Policy through its Online Building Permit System (OBPS).

DEVELOPERS WILL first have to seek approval for TOD plots from the TOD Committee via the portal before submitting building plans seeking sanction. The DDA has also launched a dedicated microsite with policy details and guidelines.

A SINGLE TOD charge has been proposed — encompassing DJB's charges for water and sewerage; MCD's sanction charges, including for land use change and levy/additional levy/additional FAR; as well as DDA charges for conversion from lease hold to freehold.

THE TOD policy introduces a single-window clearance mechanism, with builders required to apply and pay charges only once, instead of obtaining separate approvals from multiple civic bodies.

Delhi's middle-income families.

Delhi-NCR suffers from a lack of affordable and mid-segment housing. Houses that cost below Rs 80 lakh used to make up 72% of the housing inventory in 2019. By 2024, it had fallen to 15%, according to data from real estate consultancy Anarock. The industry body also sought more flexibility in planning commercial and other neighbourhood amenities.

While the policy mandates that at least 10% of the permissible FAR be earmarked for neighbourhood commercial use, facilities and social amenities, it asked that this be changed to "up to 10%" — instead of the mandatory minimum 10% — so projects can better respond to site conditions, market demand and planning requirements.

Moreover, according to the policy, the remaining 25% of the permissible FAR is to be used to build larger houses of more than 100 sq m carpet area, office space, guest houses or studio apartments.

"It is respectfully suggested that this component should also be read as up to 25%, thereby allowing planning flexibility in the overall product mix," the letter said.

Queries sent to the DDA and the MoHUA remained unanswered.

MCD SAYS STRUCTURE WAS COMING UP ON TWO PLOTS LOCATED NEXT TO EACH OTHER

One dead and many feared trapped as structure comes crashing down in Rohini

Pragynesh
New Delhi, July 8

A FOUR-STORY structure, being constructed on two adjacent plots as per MCD, collapsed in Delhi's Rohini on Wednesday evening, killing one person. At least five people, including the owner of the building, are feared trapped under the debris, as rescue operations continued late into the night, police said.

Three persons were pulled out of the rubble, including Ram Kishore, the deceased, as police, Delhi Fire Service, NDRF, MCD, and other emergency agencies launched a massive rescue operation with the aid of local residents.

The structure collapsed at 4.20 pm near an MCD school in Sector 16, coinciding with heavy rainfall across Delhi. However, authorities are yet to confirm whether the weather contributed to the incident, with sources saying it might have happened due to plumbing work going on inside the building.

Two persons who were rescued alive are Ravi, who was passing by on Ram's bike when the building fell, and Saddam. They were taken to the BSA hospital. While Ravi escaped with an injured leg, Saddam sustained fractures to the pelvis and arm and is currently stable, hospital officials said.

Two police vehicles, parked near the building, were also damaged in the collapse.

Police fear at least five to seven people are still trapped under the debris, with rescue teams pushing oxygen cylinder pipes into the rubble to help the trapped victims breathe, said an officer.

The MCD said in a statement that two buildings collapsed simultaneously that were coming up on adjacent plots owned by relatives Ram Dua and Vinod in G 5 area of Rohini's Sector 16 — a middle-class housing colony clustered with buildings no higher than four floors on either side of 30-foot wide roads.

Dua, who was allegedly in the parking lot of the building when it fell, is feared trapped, said sources in the police and NDRF.

According to a source in the MCD, both buildings were compliant with all norms and had the requisite permission for undertaking construction.

During the inspection, it was observed that the buildings — G-4/152 and G-4/153 — had recently been constructed after obtaining building plan sanction under the SARAL Scheme dated April 10, 2025, and March 03, 2025, respectively. Each property has a plot area of around 26 sq m, the MCD said.

It added, "As per enquiries made from local residents and persons present at the site, plumbing work was reportedly being carried out. It has been stated that drilling and/or cutting of structural members such as columns and beams



Rescue operation in progress at the building collapse site in Rohini's Sector 16 on Wednesday.

GAJENDRA YADAV

might have been undertaken in connection with the plumbing work."

"The construction was almost completed about 8-9 months ago and checks were conducted. Recently, work resumed to install some pipes inside," said a source with MCD.

The MCD said that based on preliminary observations and information collected from the site, the collapse may have been caused by structural failure and/or differential settlement of the foundation.

However, it emphasised that the exact cause could not be conclusively determined at

this stage and would be established only after a detailed technical examination.

Soon after the collapse, residents rushed towards the site after hearing a loud crashing sound followed by cries for help from beneath the rubble.

Before specialised rescue teams arrived, they began removing bricks, broken concrete slabs and twisted iron rods with their bare hands in a desperate attempt to save those trapped.

Several people formed human chains to clear debris, while others brought shovels and construction tools from nearby houses and worksites.

Out to buy equipment, man dies as structure collapses while he was passing by on motorcycle

Pragynesh
New Delhi, July 8

STANDING AMID the rubble in G Block of Rohini's Sector 16 on Wednesday evening, Shyam Kishore recalled the last conversation he had with his twin brother, Ram, around an hour before an under-construction building collapsed and killed him while he was passing by it.

His shirt splashed with Ram's blood, Shyam said his brother, who worked as a bike mechanic, lived in the same lane with his associate Ravi. They were out to buy some equipment on Ram's bike when the building collapsed.

"He called me around 3 pm and asked if I had lunch. He said he was going out," said Shyam, who runs a tailoring shop from the same premises where Ram worked.

Around 4 pm, Shyam heard a huge thud. "It felt like an earthquake. I came out and saw that a building has collapsed and Ram's bike was stuck in the debris," he said, adding that local residents, along with his other brother Naveen and some friends, rushed to the building collapse site.

Ravi, who was riding pillion with Ram, narrowly missed the falling concrete and escaped with an injured leg.

Ram was not so lucky.

"He was hit on the head by a huge slab of stone. He was breathing heavily when he was brought out from under the debris. At the hospital, he was de-



At the site of the building collapse in Rohini on Wednesday; deceased Ram Kishore. GAJENDRA YADAV

clared dead," said Shyam.

One of whom who attempted to rescue Ram was Vikas (34), whose father was standing on his balcony when he saw the building — located about 300 m from his house — collapse and turn to dust.

"We took Ram to the hospital in my car. On the way, he took a huge breath and then suddenly froze," Vicky said.

According to residents, the under-construction building was owned by the family of Ram Dua and Vinod. Labourers were carrying out interior work when it collapsed, they said, ad-

ding that Dua is feared trapped under the debris.

Dua, residents added, used to own a tent business till about two years ago. The building was then a two-storey structure. "The plot adjacent to it was owned by Vinod and they decided to develop a new structure of four floors there," said a resident.

"They demolished the two-floor building and started the construction of this one. Though it looked almost finished, some work was still going on inside," Vikas said.

Ram is survived by his wife Renu and two boys — aged 8 and 12. As local residents gathered around Renu to offer condolences, she sat silently, her eyes fixed on the ground, seemingly unaware of the voices around her.

THE BIRD-WATCHING WALK AT THE NATIONAL ZOOLOGICAL PARK IS ATTRACTING HOBBYISTS, FAMILIES, AND THE SIMPLY CURIOUS

At Delhi Zoo, curated Sunday morning walks every week to watch birds in the trees

Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, July 8

THE MORNING was not too hot or humid yet, and about 25 people clustered together, some clutching binoculars or cameras with impressively long lenses. They all looked upwards, trying to find among the leaves the birds whose chirping filled the air.

This scene at the National Zoological Park (NZP) last Sunday has been recurring every week — for four Sundays now, a three-hour bird-watching walk has attracted hobbyists, photographers, and families to the Zoo. The walk starts at 6:30 am. It is free — all that you pay while registering is the Zoo's Rs 80 entry fee.

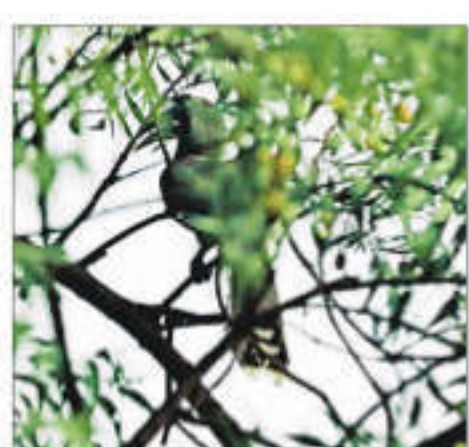
On July 5, when *The Indian Express* joined the walk, it was led by wildlife writer Surya Prakash — dressed for the part in

khaki pants, a military-green t-shirt printed with beige paw marks, and a camouflage-print hat. Biologist Aarti Chavda and curator Manoj Kumar accompanied the group.

Several species of birds were sighted — according to the NZP, the July 5 session recorded 41 species and more than 100 individual sightings.

Zoo director Sandeep Kumar said larger numbers of bird species are typically sighted in the winter season. Each Sunday, the walk explores a different trail around the Zoo. The idea is to watch free-ranging birds, but participants can visit the Zoo's captive birds and animals afterward.

Ashwin Sachdev, who was part of the July 5 group, said he was hooked on birding; it was almost like a drug now. "*Drugs ke*



nashe se bura nasha hai," he laughed. A trip to Jim Corbett National Park with his wife in 1995 had changed his life, and he had spent the last three decades touring wildlife parks around



(Anti-clockwise from above) During the bird-watching walk at the National Zoological Park; red-vented Bulbul; Indian Gray Hornbill. ABHINAV SAHA

the country, Sachdev said.

The Sachdevs' daughter Brinda (18), said: "Almost all our trips are planned around wildlife. It started with animals for

me, but then grew into an interest in birds too. I am now able to recognise many species."

Others in the group demonstrated their own connections

with specific bird species. So when a white-throated Kingfisher was seen perched on a branch, some raised their phones to take pictures; others

discussed the joys of a cold beer on a muggy day.

At a water body, the resident pelicans of the Zoo were yawning widely and flapping their wings. Rahul Sharma, who said he was a government official, recalled the picnics he had enjoyed with his family at this green patch years ago.

"It's nice to come back here," he said. A black-crowned night heron sat on one of the topmost branches of a tree.

Soon, the group spotted another individual of the species — but its feathers were brown, not white. That's a juvenile, Neeraj (43), a birder, informed the group.

Seven-year-old Zachory Lopez was the walk's youngest bird enthusiast.

His father Jason, who runs tourism camps, had spotted the announcement by the Zoo on Instagram and signed the family up. Zachory was thrilled to see a male peacock open its feathers. He was even more de-

lighted as other peacocks turned up along the path, displaying their spectacular tail fans.

As the call of a white-breasted waterhen rang out, Priyanshu, a Zoology Master's student who was volunteering at the Zoo, pointed out to walkers that bird names were revealing, and very descriptive of the appearance of the species. Someone spotted an Indian grey hornbill — and the binocs went up and the lenses zoomed in. Many in the group had read or seen reports about a female pied hornbill that has been helping feed a nesting female grey hornbill alongside her own mate at Lodhi Garden.

The walk ended with a talk by the expert and the Zoo director at the Zoo's Education Centre. They discussed the birds the group had encountered, and asked for suggestions and feedback. As the monsoon settles over the city, a Butterfly and Dragonfly Walk will begin at the Zoo on July 12.



Tradition Pitch

SPEAKING AT a Rashtriya Sevika Samiti event in Delhi to mark its Sankalp Diwas on Wednesday, BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj made a pitch for what she described as an indigenous approach to women's empowerment. Saying that Indian women do not need to "borrow" the ideas of feminism and equality from the West, Swaraj argued that India's own civilisational ethos provides the framework for women's empowerment. She said that women would shape the nation's future through "motherhood, creativity and leadership", adding that when people remain rooted in their identity and traditions, "no force can shake them". Her remarks came at the event celebrating 90 years of the Rashtriya Sevika Samiti, which is ideologically aligned with the RSS.

Write Time

COME POLL season, and there are a flurry of activities to catch the attention of top leaders. BJP leader Satyendra Tripathi has come out with a book in Hindi — 'Ekatma Yatra'. The book, according to the author, is a journey through ideas, values, and vision that shape leadership, governance, and civilisational ethos. It also talks about how the BJP governments at the Centre and in UP follow Deendayal Upadhyaya's 'ekatma manav darshan' (philosophy of integral humanism). Party insiders say such ideological endorsement could "favour" him in the UP elections.

INDONESIA VISIT CONCLUDES

Modi lands in Australia, to meet Albanese today

Strengthening Indo-Pacific ties, Quad on agenda

Shubhajt Roy
New Delhi, July 8

A DAY after he landed in Melbourne, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will meet Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese on Thursday for the third annual summit, where they are expected to discuss co-operation in the Indo-Pacific region, critical minerals and education partnership, among other areas.

Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, "PM Modi lands in Australia. PM @narendramodi arrived in Melbourne to a warm and special welcome." He said Modi will co-chair the summit with Albanese and engage with stakeholders to further deepen the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership across all sectors of mutual interest.

Modi posted on X, "Landed in Melbourne, Australia. This visit will add vigour to the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. I look forward to the talks with Prime Minister Albanese. I will also have the opportunity to interact with the Indian diaspora, which is an important pillar of our partnership."

This is the PM's third visit to Australia; he is visiting Melbourne after a gap of 12 years.

The geopolitically significant visit is expected to boost India's MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) and Indo-Pacific vision. "It will further cement ties between two QUAD partners who are playing greater roles in the Indo-Pacific, bringing new opportunities and prosperity for people and countries, especially the Small Island Developing States," officials said.



PM Narendra Modi and President Prabowo Subianto at Prambanan Temple in Indonesia, Wednesday. PTI

Modi, Prabowo launch project to conserve Indonesia temple

Divya A
New Delhi, July 8

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi, before concluding his Indonesia visit on Wednesday, visited the 9th-century Prambanan Temple complex in Yogyakarta along with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto to inaugurate a joint conservation project for the UNESCO World Heritage Site. The project will be led by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

Calling the initiative a "shining example of the enduring civilisational bonds" between India and Indonesia, the two leaders also unveiled a plaque at the temple, marking the commencement of the ASI's conservation and restoration project at the site.

"President Prabowo Subianto and I inaugurated the UNESCO World Heritage Prambanan Temple Compound Restoration and Conser-

vation Project," Modi posted on X after his visit. "The magnificent Prambanan Temple stands as a timeless symbol of our cultural and spiritual links. Preserving such heritage is about safeguarding the traditions that continue to inspire generations," he said, adding India is privileged to partner with Indonesia in this important endeavour.

The central focus of the project is the restoration of the Perwara temples — 224 subsidiary shrines arranged in four concentric rows within the middle zone of the compound, official sources told *The Indian Express*. Of these 224 temples, only six have been restored to date and the remaining 218 stand as extensive ruins.

The project, spanning 10 years, till 2036, with a total outlay of Rs 65 crore, will be executed by ASI in collaboration with the Indonesian Heritage Agency, sources added. The key activities of the project include LiDAR

(Light Detection and Ranging) sensor, and photogrammetric documentation of scattered stone members, archival research, structural, hydrological, and geotechnical studies.

"As nations with deep cultural connections, India and Indonesia will continue to work together to celebrate our shared past while building an even stronger future," Modi said.

"As we begin the conservation and restoration work at Prambanan Temple complex, I am very assured that Indian tourists will definitely visit this place," he added.

The Prambanan Temple Compound, inscribed a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1991, is among the most magnificent ensembles of Hindu temple architecture in the world. Built in the 9th century under the Mataram Kingdom in Central Java, the compound contains over 500 temples, including the soaring 47-metre Shiva temple.

ED freezes 3 TMC accounts: 'Used party funds to buy jet & chopper'

Express News Service
New Delhi, Kolkata, July 8

THE ENFORCEMENT Directorate said Wednesday it has frozen three bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress, holding deposits worth Rs 440.42 crore, under the PMLA, following searches in an alleged funds misappropriation case.

According to ED sources, the preliminary probe has found that the political party had invested its own corpus into a private aviation firm to acquire a business jet and a helicopter.

"The ED conducted search operations at five premises in and around Kolkata under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA),

2002. The premises belonged to the Carewell group of companies, which operates in the aviation sector. During the searches, balances amounting to Rs 440.42 crore lying in three HDFC Bank accounts of the TMC were frozen under Section 17(1-A) of the PMLA," an ED spokesperson said.

The searches were conducted in connection with a money laundering investigation based on an FIR lodged by the Cyber Police, Bidhannagar, in a case involving alleged dishonest financial dealings, unlawful collection of money, and routing of suspected funds through certain bank accounts of the TMC, the official said.

According to the ED, its

probe has revealed that around Rs 160 crore was transferred from TMC bank accounts to M/s Carewell Aviation India Pvt Ltd, and its related entity, mostly between April 2023 and June 2026.

It was further revealed that M/s Carewell Aviation India Pvt Ltd routed Rs 82.96 crore between 2023 and 2026 to another newly incorporated related entity for the purchase of an Embraer Legacy 600 aircraft and an Augusta 109 Grand New helicopter.

The TMC, led by Mamata Banerjee, had earlier moved the High Court seeking its immediate intervention after three of its party accounts, allegedly containing Rs 440 crore, were frozen by the West Bengal Police.

Church, missionary land to be probed in Maharashtra: Minister

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 8

THE MAHARASHTRA government has ordered a time-bound audit of land parcels owned by churches, Christian missionary organisations and related institutions across the state.

Announcing the decision in the Legislative Assembly on Wednesday, Revenue Minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule said the exercise would be completed within three months and action would be taken wherever violations are found.

"The objective is to identify illegal encroachments, disputed land titles and irregularities in ownership," Bawankule said, adding that the exercise is part of the government's broader policy to streamline land administration across the state.

He said all land held by Christian missionary organisations would come under scrutiny. "Those with legally valid land titles and transfers need not worry. But where there are violations of norms or illegalities, the government will re-

view the cases and take appropriate action," he said.

According to the minister, land held by missionary organisations since the British era, as well as properties transferred after Independence, will be examined to ascertain whether any laws were violated.

The verification will be carried out by a high-powered committee headed by the respective divisional commissioner. The panel will include senior officials from the Settlement Commissioner's office, the police, and Inspector General of Registration. Bawankule said the audit was intended to ensure transparency and verify the legality of land ownership.

He said in cases where the land has already been developed into residential colonies or allotted for public infrastructure projects, the government would seek the legal department's opinion before taking a final decision. He was replying to a calling attention motion raised by MLAs over alleged irregularities in land transfers and land title disputes.

DMK leader gets bail

Chennai: The Madras High Court on Wednesday granted anticipatory bail to DMK MLA V Senthil Balaji and his brother V Ashok Kumar, who apprehended arrest in a case involving an alleged Rs 35 crore bribe offer to destabilise the TVK government. Granting relief, Justice G K Ilanthiraiyan asked them to co-operate with the probe. PTI

NOTICE

It is hereby intimated that with effect from 08-10-2026 MFI Operations of Asirvad Micro Finance Limited BARODE MAKAN NO 1. GULJAR COLONY, BAROD KASBA, BARODE, SHAJAPUR, MADHYA PRADESH 465500. Will be shifted to Asirvad Micro Finance Limited, MAHIPUR 02 MA DURGA KRASHI SEVA KENDRA , ZARDA ROAD PIPLON KALAN DIST AGAR (M.P.) 465444 for the better convenience in infrastructure. Customers may kindly note that all efforts have been taken to avoid inconvenience to the customers and still any difficulties are faced, all are requested to contact in the following numbers for further guidance.

Branch Head No: 7509149702
Area Head No: 8965857515
HO: 9025401720

Asirvad Micro Finance Ltd.
(Subsidiary of Manappuram Finance Limited)
Registered Office: Ceebros Manjula, 3rd Floor, Office No-1, New No. 39, Old No. 45, Monthi Road, Egmore, Opp: Indian Red Cross Society, Chennai-600 002 Tamilnadu, India
Corporate Office: Building No-48B, 8, C & D, Chanthappadi, Valodur, Thiruv. Kerala, India-686057

Chouhan, Taliban minister discuss agricultural ties

New Delhi: Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Wednesday held a bilateral meeting with visiting Taliban-led Afghanistan government's agriculture minister Mawlawi Ataulah Omari to review the agricultural partnership between the two nations.

The meeting, held at the Pusa Campus here, saw discussions regarding extending the existing MoU between the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) and Afghan National Agricultural Science and Technology University beyond 2026, it is learnt. ENS

Metro Railway, Kolkata

Tender Notice for e-tendering is invited by Principal Chief Engineer, Metro Railway for the following work: Name of work: Through ERC renewal in UP & DN Line from KNAP (Incl) Km (-)02/11 to KCEN (Incl) Km 07/14 of Metro Railway, Kolkata. Approx Cost of Work: Rs. 26,31,813.92, Earnest Money: Rs. 52,600.00, Completion Period: 06 (Six) Months, Date and Time of Closing: 31.07.2026 at 12:00 Hrs. The Tender Document and other details can be obtained from the website www.irops.gov.in Abridged e-Tender Notice No.: Civil-2599-2026 (Open) Amendments/Corrigendum, if any, would be uploaded only on the website

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भारत सरकार
कार्पोरेट कार्य मंत्रालय
त्वरित कार्पोरेट समायोजन प्रसंस्करण केंद्र
(सी-पेस), आई.आई.सी.ए. बिल्डिंग,
7वीं मंजिल, प्लॉट P-6,7,8, से-5,
आई.एम.टी. मानेसर, गुर्गांव,
हरियाणा-122050.
Email: roc.cpace@mca.gov.in

Government of India
Ministry of Corporate Affairs
Centre for Processing
Accelerated Corporate Exit
(C-PACE) IICA Building, 7th
Floor, Plot P-6,7,8, Sector-5,
IMT Manesar, Gurgaon,
Haryana - 122050.

FORM No. STK-6
PUBLIC NOTICE

[Pursuant to sub-section (2) and sub-section (4) of section 248 of the Companies Act, 2013 and rule 7 of the Companies (Removal of Names of Companies from the Register of Companies) Rules, 2016]

Public : ROC/C-PACE/STK-2/248(2)/2026-27/678 Date: 01/07/2026

Reference:

In the matter of striking off or removal of names of (69) companies in the Delhi state under section 248 of the Companies Act, 2013 in respect of:

S. No.	Work Item	CIN	Company Name
1	AC3941335	U15490DL2020PTC360865	BR NUTS PRIVATE LIMITED
2	AC3942957	U70100DL2012PTC232914	BAKSHANHAAR ESTATE PRIVATE LIMITED
3	AC3937308	U45200DL2006PTC156896	REASONABLE PROPERTIES PRIVATE LIMITED
4	AC3931272	U77299DL2025PTC458573	TOTAAL RENTAL SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
5	AC3944914	U55101DL2001PTC113409	KARIM'S TAKE AWAY PRIVATE LIMITED
6	AC3931216	U45100DL2025PTC459398	JAIN EV SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
7	AC3942404	U52609DL2016PTC305852	VIDYUT JEWELLERY PRIVATE LIMITED
8	AC3890238	U24100DL2009PTC188870	ORION ORGOCHEM PRIVATE LIMITED
9	AC3866587	U72300DL2010PTC203779	DEGREE 360 SOFTWARES PRIVATE LIMITED
10	AC3879857	U55204DL2017PTC323226	SGMA FOODWORKS PRIVATE LIMITED
11	AC3859749	U74899DL1991PTC046262	SATYA CREDITS PRIVATE LIMITED
12	AC3841175	U93030DL2013PTC257807	REDSUN RISING INDUSTRIES PRIVATE LIMITED
13	AC3755862	U51909DL2012PTC237875	SHOP24X7ONLINE SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
14	AC3744282	U24304DL2017PLC311392	DR SMITHKLINE LABORATORIES (INDIA) LIMITED
15	AC3689125	U74900DL2015PTC286469	THINK APPS TECHNOLOGY PRIVATE LIMITED
16	AC4028060	U55101DL2025PTC447647	SUNDARA ARABIAN SEA PRIVATE LIMITED
17	AC3602703	U51311DL2004PTC129671	VIRTUAL ENTERPRISES PRIVATE LIMITED
18	AC3597411	U01400DL2014PTC271978	AACOR INTERNATIONAL PRIVATE LIMITED
19	AC3579075	U19100DL2021PTC381793	REECEE ACCESSORIES PRIVATE LIMITED
20	AC4076940	U36998DL2020PTC364664	3B ENTERPRISES PRIVATE LIMITED
21	AC4067440	U70104DL2016PTC299018	EXPRESSWAY EXPERT PRIVATE LIMITED
22	AC4005596	U62013DL2025OPC446483	DRAVIX TECH (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED
23	AC3991461	U93000DL2017PTC323538	CULINOS HOSPITALITY PRIVATE LIMITED
24	AC4056400	U74999DL2017PTC327517	VTEAM PLATFORM PRIVATE LIMITED
25	AC4111278	U56210DL2024PTC433416	SAKHA EVENT MANAGEMENT PRIVATE LIMITED
26	AC3967175	U70200DL2023PTC410494	SHINTEN TRADING INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
27	AC4114383	U52590DL2020PTC372790	CLIMAPRENEUR ECOMMERCE PRIVATE LIMITED
28	AC3954340	U74899DL1975PTC005349	FIXOPAN ENGINEERS PVT LTD
29	AC3922748	U63030DL2021PTC384952	SHINE HOTEL & HOLIDAYS PRIVATE LIMITED
30	AC3928295	U40300DL2020PTC371905	ALTIER SOLAR FUND ONE PRIVATE LIMITED
31	AC3897562	U80903DL2014OPC271891	FUTUREICONS LEARNING ACADEMY (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED
32	AC3881295	U72900DL2021PTC388626	YAB TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED
33	AC3888748	U64204DL2018PTC329922	FUTURE EXPRESS PRIVATE LIMITED
34	AC3880659	U72900DL2021PTC389493	YAB IT SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED
35	AC3880249	U74999DL2021PTC379862	COGNITION PROFESSIONALS PRIVATE LIMITED
36	AC3876104	U74140DL2012PTC239998	ELEVERA INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
37	AC3857246	U51909DL2004PTC124085	ASHRAM EXIM PRIVATE LIMITED.
38	AC3857188	U28999DL2018PLC331612	GLS METALLICS INDIA LIMITED

39	AC3859737	U37200DL2023PTC410247	21 CENTURY RECYCLING PRIVATE LIMITED
40	AC3852358	U28994DL2018PLC331625	GLS ENGINEERING INDIA LIMITED
41	AC3841732	U74950DL2003PTC122737	AMIDA PACKAGING PRIVATE LIMITED.
42	AC3830533	U85300DL2021PTC387422	PLASMIT HEALTH TECH PRIVATE LIMITED
43	AC3792938	U70101DL2008PTC177390	VRS ESTATES PRIVATE LIMITED
44	AC3794608	U52399DL2016PTC301656	SINGHAL RICE & PULSES PRIVATE LIMITED
45	AC3793858	U17120DL2014PTC266601	MODERNISTIC ATTIRE PRIVATE LIMITED
46	AC4083801	U85300DL2020PTC362519	VEDIC JOURNEYS PRIVATE LIMITED
47	AC3848633	U74899DL1994PTC056869	ADINATH TEDXYES PRIVATE LIMITED
48	AC3820360	U25209DL2007PTC169619	BLESS CHEM PRIVATE LIMITED
49	AC4053254	U74900DL2010PTC208155	STAR EMBEDDED SYSTEMS PRIVATE LIMITED
50	AC4049847	U74999DL2020PTC368397	SHARPEYE SECURITY AND MANPOWER SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
51	AC3784841	U21023DL2007PTC169699	JPL PACKAGING PRIVATE LIMITED
52	AC3673310	U74140DL2016PTC290935	ISTEN CONSULTANCY SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
53	AC3648833	U62099DL2023PTC411469	THOUGHTFUL MINDS ORG PRIVATE LIMITED
54	AC4054790	U72900DL2020PTC367904	PORAS INFOTECH PRIVATE LIMITED
55	AC4055076	U74999DL2016PTC300083	FOSTRIL INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
56	AC3639676	U62099DL2023PTC410586	KALP CONNECTION VENTURES PRIVATE LIMITED
57	AC4045909	U63030DL2022PTC396443	TRAVELER TAO PRIVATE LIMITED
58	AC3623126	U70200DL2023PTC422505	TOG SUSTAINABILITY PRIVATE LIMITED
59	AC4109421	U46205DL2025PTC435594	LEAF LOUNGE GREENEYR PRIVATE LIMITED
60	AC4112735	U72900DL2010PTC202310	ADVITYA TECHNOLOGIES & CONSULTANTS PRIVATE LIMITED
61	AC3520302	U74140DL1996PTC076045	R G MACRO PLANNERS PRIVATE LIMITED
62	AC4078958	U74999DL2022PTC393426	BIVETY ALLIED AND MANAGEMENT SERVICES PRIVATE LIMITED
63	AC3719937	U74899DL1986PTC024929	YAMUNA CHIT FUND PRIVATE LIMITED
64	AC4120105	U74999DL2022PTC395133	FLYME99 ACADEMY PRIVATE LIMITED
65	AC4116830	U16000DL2013PTC252261	NAV AK FOOD PRODUCTS PRIVATE LIMITED
66	AC4094764	U72500DL2022FTC394332	VERIFONE PAYMENTS INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
67	AC4094203	U15490DL2012PTC235907	FERIA INTERNATIONAL PRIVATE LIMITED
68	AC4057818	U74899DL1993PTC056529	SIDDHANT PROPERTIES PRIVATE LIMITED
69	AC4062788	U74999DL2017PTC326063	GREYHEAD DIGITAL MARKETING PRIVATE LIMITED

- Notice is hereby given that the Registrar of Companies had received applications from the above-mentioned companies under section 248(2) of the Companies Act, 2013 for removal of its/their name (s) from the register of companies either on the ground that they have failed to commence business within one year of their incorporation or on the ground that the company(ies) is/are not carrying on any business or operation for a period of two immediately preceding financial years and has/have not made any application (s) within such period for obtaining the status of a dormant company under section 455 of the Companies Act, 2013 or the company(ies) have obtained the status of dormant company/subscribe /subscribers to the memorandum have not paid the subscription which they had undertaken to pay at the time of incorporation of a company and a declaration to this effect has not been filed within one hundred and eighty days of its incorporation under subsection (1) of section 10A/ have not been carrying on any business or operations, as revealed after the physical verification carried out under sub-section (9) of section 12, but it/they do not wish to continue its/their registration as companies and have, therefore, requested for removal/strike off of its/their names from the register of companies.
- Accordingly, the Registrar of Companies proposes to remove or strike off the names of the above-mentioned companies from the Register of Companies.
- Any person objecting to the proposed removal or striking off name of the companies from the register of companies may send his or her objection to the office address mentioned here above within thirty days from the date of publication of this notice.

Raunak Agrawal
Deputy Registrar

CBC07123/11/0293/2627

Centre for Processing Accelerated Corporate Exit



An FBI Wanted poster for Brar, whose real name is Satinderjeet Singh, displayed at a news conference in Los Angeles, Tuesday. PTI

FBI announces \$50,000 reward on gangster Goldy Brar

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 8

THE FEDERAL Bureau of Investigation (FBI) on Wednesday announced a \$50,000 (Rs 477 lakh approx) reward for information leading to the arrest of gangster Goldy Brar, two years after the Indian government designated him a terrorist. The FBI wants him for his alleged involvement in the Lawrence Bishnoi organised crime group, which was targeted under the 'Operation Hard Ball'.

A native of Faridkot in Punjab, Brar, whose real name is Satinderjeet Singh, was earlier based in Canada, where he had gone on a student visa in 2017. In India, he is wanted in connection with several killings, including that of singer Sidhu Moosewala, for which he had claimed responsibility. The Punjabi singer was shot dead in Punjab's Mansa district on May 29, 2022.

Goldy Brar was a key member of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang before parting ways with the group.

According to the FBI, Brar has footprints in Sacramento and Fresno cities in California, as well as Canada, India, and Mexico. "He is wanted for his alleged involvement in the Lawrence Bishnoi organised crime

group, which is allegedly engaged in a variety of violent acts in Southern California and across the United States and Canada. These acts include assassinations of political and religious figures, shootings, murders, kidnappings, extortions, assaults, and the trafficking of narcotics and weapons," the FBI said.

The FBI has alleged that Goldy is based in the United States and is the alleged leader of the group in North America. "On July 1, 2026, a federal arrest warrant was issued against him by the United States District Court, Central District of California, Los Angeles, after he was charged with 'Racketeer Influenced and Corrupt Organizations' conspiracy... to interfere and attempted interference with commerce by extortion, and conspiracy to distribute and possess with intent to distribute controlled substances," the FBI added.

According to a criminal dossier on Goldy prepared by Indian central agencies, he is associated with Babbar Khalsa International, which is listed as a terrorist organisation. "Goldy, backed by a cross-border agency, was involved in multiple killings and professes a radical ideology..." the dossier said.

FROM CANADIAN SCRUTINY TO FBI'S OPERATION HARD BALL

How net steadily tightened around Lawrence Bishnoi

Manraj Grewal Sharma
Chandigarh, July 8

THE NET around jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi's alleged international crime network has tightened steadily over the past two years, with Canadian law enforcement agencies leading the way long before this week's FBI-led Operation Hard Ball.

From being publicly identified by the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP) in 2024 to being designated a terrorist entity by Canada and now facing sweeping US indictments, the Lawrence Bishnoi gang has come under mounting international scrutiny as investigators on both sides of the border closed in on its alleged operations in Canada. The latest indictments name Bishnoi and his close associate Satinderjeet Singh, alias Goldy Brar, for crimes allegedly committed on Canadian soil.

The Canadian authorities first referred to the Bishnoi gang on October 14, 2024. During a nationally televised RCMP press conference on alleged foreign interference and criminal activity in Canada, Assistant Commissioner Brigitte Gauvin identified the Bishnoi group, saying investigators believed it was being used to target pro-Khalistan activists in Canada.

Though then the remarks were connected to the June 18, 2023 killing of Khalistani separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar outside the Guru Nanak Sikh Gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia, an incident that had plunged India-Canada ties into a diplomatic crisis, it was the spate of extortion-related shootings that had prompted the RCMP to investigate the Bishnoi link.

One of the prominent cases involved Abjeet Kingra, 26, and Vikram Sharma, 24, who were



Seized evidence presented at a news conference at the Federal Building in Los Angeles on Tuesday. AP

accused in a Surrey extortion-linked shooting case that led investigators to the Bishnoi gang. Kingra was arrested in October 2024 and later pleaded guilty to arson and firearms offences committed, according to court records, "at the behest of the Bishnoi gang".

Investigators also linked Kingra to the September 2024 shooting at the Colwood, British Columbia, residence of Punjabi singer AP Dhillon. Authorities alleged that Kingra filmed the attack using body-camera style footage and uploaded it online so that the Bishnoi gang could claim responsibility. Investigators said the attack was allegedly carried out in retaliation for Dhillon featuring Bollywood actor Salman Khan in one of his music videos, and that Kingra was paid about 4,000 Canadian dollars for the job.

Sharma is believed to have fled Canada and is suspected to be in India. During deportation proceedings in June this year, Kingra claimed the gang had threatened him and his family in India because it believed he had cooperated with investigators. However, Canada's Immi-

gration and Refugee Board ordered his deportation after concluding that he was a member of a criminal organisation.

By mid-2025, the focus had shifted sharply to organised extortion targeting South Asian businesses, particularly in British Columbia. These incidents became frequent enough to attract political attention.

On June 17, 2025, British Columbia Premier David Eby announced that he would formally request the federal government to designate the Lawrence Bishnoi gang a terrorist organisation, saying repeated incidents of violence and intimidation were eroding public confidence in the justice system.

The demand gathered momentum after Abbotsford Police received a letter in August 2025 purportedly from the Bishnoi gang claiming it had "1,000 foot soldiers" ready to carry out shootings across Canada as part of its extortion operations. The letter later surfaced during proceedings before Canada's Immigration and Refugee Board, where an Edmonton police investigator cited it as evidence of the gang's reach and its at-

tempts to intimidate victims.

Canada's financial intelligence agency, FINTRAC, also flagged money laundering linked to extortion networks operating in the gang's name. It pointed to a pattern in which business owners in Greater Toronto and Metro Vancouver first received threats and were then asked to make large payments.

On September 29, 2025, Canada formally listed the Bishnoi Gang as a terrorist entity under the country's Criminal Code.

Announcing the decision, Public Safety Minister Gary Anandasangaree said the government had concluded that the organisation had "knowingly carried out, attempted to carry out, participated in or facilitated terrorist activity" through murders, shootings, arson, extortion and intimidation that had created "a climate of insecurity" within South Asian communities.

The RCMP investigations took a cross-border turn when a victim who moved to Canada after helping Indian law enforcement identify and arrest two suspected blackmailers began to receive death threats from a California resident identified as Jasmeet Singh. Later the US authorities charged him with making the threats on behalf of the Bishnoi gang.

In one documented case from the Sacramento FBI office (December 2023), Bishnoi himself allegedly contacted a victim whose vehicle was later fired upon outside his home.

In January this year, Global News reported details from a classified RCMP national security assessment describing the Bishnoi organisation as "a violent criminal organisation with an active, continually expanding presence" in Canada and several other countries.

• BRIEFLY



Search and rescue operations at the site where a waste mound fell on a building, leading to a collapse in Pune on Wednesday. ANI

MAHARASHTRA

Building collapses under waste mound amid heavy rain, 8 rescued

EIGHTEEN PEOPLE were trapped after a large portion of a building at the Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC)'s waste-to-energy facility in Moshi, Pune, collapsed on Wednesday. The structure gave way after a large mound of waste, which was situated adjacent to it, fell on the building following heavy rains. Eight persons were rescued and efforts are underway to rescue the remaining 10. "A joint task force of the Southern Command, comprising engineers and medical personnel, has been deployed to assist in the relief operations. The Army team is working in close coordination with the NDRF, police, fire services and other civil agencies to support the ongoing rescue efforts," said Ankush Chavan, PRO (Defence), Pune. ENS

Lashkar man killed in Kashmir gunfight

AN LeT terrorist was killed in a gunfight in south Kashmir's Shopian. Zakir Ahmad Ganaie's body was recovered three days after the gunfight that took place on Saturday when hiding terrorists attacked a joint force who were on a cordon and search operation. Police officials said that when the joint team of forces resumed the search operation for the terrorists on Wednesday morning, a few gunshots were heard, after which the body was recovered from a cowshed in the village. Zakir was one of only two local terrorists on police records. ENS

UAV crashes in Porbandar; no casualties

AN UNMANNED aerial vehicle (UAV) of the Indian Navy crashed into an open field near Porbandar city on Wednesday shortly after taking off from an air enclave, officials said. The cause of the crash is yet to be ascertained, District Collector S D Dhanani said. "...No one was killed or injured in the incident. Navy personnel reached the spot and started further investigation," Dhanani said. "Indian Navy confirms the crash of Uncrewed Aerial Vehicle Drishti-10, off Porbandar airfield during a training sortie this afternoon," the Navy said in a post on X. PTI

Ram Temple Trust appoints interim team for banking work

Maulshree Seth
Ayodhya, July 8

FOLLOWING THE resignations of former General Secretary Champat Rai and member Anil Mishra in the wake of the alleged Ram Temple donation scam, the Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra has constituted a three-member interim team that has taken over banking-related work, sources said.

The team comprises retired Indian Forest Service (IFoS) officer Krishna Mohan, who has been appointed interim General Secretary of the Trust; Jagdish Aphale, an IIT-Bombay alumnus and civil engineer who served as project manager during the temple construction; and chartered accountant Chandan Rai, sources said.

Sources said this team will look after banking-related activities for the Trust and the temple till a final decision is taken on the new team and their responsibilities in the July 22 meeting.

Aphale was among a team of four senior engineers who had played a major role in giving technical expertise for the temple construction: from laying the foundation to the plinth and other structures.

Meanwhile, early Wednesday morning, Trust Treasurer Govind Dev Giri met Rai for a two-hour meeting at the Trust office.

This came after Rai on Tuesday had written two letters, one to the public and one to the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged donation theft.

In the latter, Rai is said to have distanced himself from the revised Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for donation counting issued on February 6, 2025, during the Maha Kumbh. He reportedly blamed Trust members and banking officials for 'keeping him in the dark' about the revised SOP, which the SIT has alleged diluted security measures during the counting process and facilitated the alleged pilferage.

2 warnings, zero action: Why Wayanad tunnel tragedy is a 'man-made disaster'

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 8

BETWEEN JUNE 20 and 25, the Kerala government administration issued two warnings to the contractor of the Anakkampoyil-Kalladi-Meppadi tunnel project, Bhopal-based Dilip Buildcon, stating that soil piled up from tunnelling should be removed from the site.

First, the district collector of Wayanad Meghashree D R, on June 20, wrote a letter stating that work at the twin tunnel project near Meenakshi area of Kerala's Wayanad district should stop temporarily, until the soil is removed.

"The order was not considered, and the construction company went ahead with the tunnelling work," Kerala's environment minister Sunny Joseph had told The Indian Express hours after the tragedy, which killed three and left several others injured. Five people are missing. "This is a man-made disaster because the warning was ignored. We are seriously looking into the lapses that put lives in danger."

On June 25, a high-level del-



Officials carry out a search and rescue operation at the site of the landslide in Wayanad on Wednesday. PTI

egation led by the Public Works Department inspected the tunnel project site along with officials of the District Disaster Management Authority, the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority, and the Konkan Railway Corporation, which is the executing agency for the tunnel project. PWD told Konkan Railway Corporation (KRCL) to reduce the height of the pile on the same day, the minutes of the meeting released by the PWD after the disaster show.

The pile posed a risk of soil piping and slope instability, according to minutes of the meeting released by the PWD. The retaining wall and tarpaulin covering built by the contractor were not considered adequate protection against water seepage, the minutes reveal. Dilip Buildcon was asked to stop work at the site on June 27.

A PWD official told *The Indian Express*, "The district administration had identified land near the construction site for the soil to be moved there. There were two standing instructions in this regard." The project had generated one lakh cubic meters

of soil, the PWD had found. The soil was not removed because the corporation had not found "suitable land to keep it", sources close to KRCL claimed. The KRCL did not respond to requests from *The Indian Express* seeking a response.

Meanwhile, the contractor of the project, Dilip Buildcon, said what happened in Wayanad was a "natural calamity". "The incident occurred during an active monsoon spell, amid exceptionally heavy rainfall in Wayanad. The India Meteorological Department had issued warnings for heavy to very heavy rainfall across parts of Kerala, while preliminary data from the Kerala State Disaster Management Authority indicates that Wayanad received approximately 265 mm of rainfall in the preceding 24 hours—among the highest recorded in the district this monsoon season..." it said.

"Having said that, the project is being executed in strict compliance with all applicable protocols. Given its location in an ecologically sensitive region, the project is subject to multiple regulatory oversight and monitoring mechanism..." it said.

Two Air India planes come face-to-face at Mumbai airport

Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, July 8

TWO AIRCRAFT—an Air India plane and an Air India Express jet—came face-to-face on a runway at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport in Mumbai on Tuesday night.

The incident occurred around 10 pm when Delhi-bound Air India flight AI 816 was preparing to take off from a runway where an Air India Express aircraft was still parked.

Following Air Traffic Control's (ATC) prompt instructions, the crew discontinued the take-off run, preventing the two aircraft from coming into conflict.

Confirming the incident, an Air India spokesperson noted that a major mishap was averted due to the prompt intervention of the ATC. "The crew operating flight AI 816 from Mumbai to Delhi on July 7 discontinued the take-off run after receiving an instruction to do so from the Air Traffic Control and returned to the bay," the spokesperson said.

The airline said the aircraft would undergo mandatory inspections before being cleared for service.

"The aircraft will undergo necessary checks as per standard operating procedures. Meanwhile, alternative arrangements are being made to fly the passengers to their destination at the earliest. Air India regrets the inconvenience caused to passengers due to this unforeseen situation. At Air India, the safety and well-being of our passengers remain a top priority," the spokesperson added.

No injuries or damages were reported in the incident.

The authorities refrained from disclosing why the Air India aircraft was cleared for departure while the runway was still occupied by an Air India Express flight. It is unclear whether the incident led to any further delays in the scheduled landing or take-off of the other aircraft.

Andhra techie held for wife's murder in US

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, July 8

A BITTER-TASTING smoothie, a secret girlfriend and murder made to look like suicide—that's what police in Washington say they uncovered in a nine-month investigation into the death of a 27-year-old Hyderabad woman. They have now arrested her 30-year-old engineer husband for the killing.

On June 27, Secunderabad native N Avinash was arrested on charges of murdering his wife, Rajita Sabbineni, and produced in court there on July 1. Investigators claim Avinash strangled his wife on October 27, 2025, and tried to make it look like suicide. Police claim the investigation that followed showed that Avinash had been having an affair.

In text messages she sent her husband days before she died, Rajita complained that the smoothies he made for her tasted bitter. While her death was initially treated as a suicide, investigators came to believe she had been murdered, finding that only Avinash had access to the apartment.

Nurse killed Gulf-returned husband by injecting 'deadly mix' into IV drip: Cops

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, July 8

A NURSE allegedly pushed her Gulf-returned husband from the terrace of their house and injected a deadly concoction of powdered sleeping pills, toilet cleaner, and tile cleaner acid to kill him and hide her extra-marital affair, Nizamabad police said.

Police arrested D Sandhya on July 4 and eventually picked up her friends Venkat Sai and Anil. "The murder was planned over several months after she got to know that her husband was coming home," Suresh Kumar, Circle Inspector of Nizamabad Town South Rural Circle, told *The Indian Express*.

Prashant had married Sand-



Victim Prashant used to work as a domestic worker in Dubai.

hya three years ago. A year later, he went to Dubai to work as a domestic worker. Sandhya, meanwhile, met B Anil and had a relationship with him.

"When Prashant told her this January that he was returning home permanently because of the war-like situation in the Gulf,

she became upset," Kumar said. Police said over the next few months, Sandhya convinced Anil and another friend, Venkata Sai, to help kill her husband. "After Prashant arrived at the end of June, she held a homecoming party. Sai brought the liquor, and they asked Prashant to go to the terrace with them."

They allegedly pushed Prashant off the terrace and, when he didn't die, took him to a local government hospital.

"(Later) she got him home and talked him into taking, along with the prescribed medicines, an intravenous drip to regain strength. When he was asleep, she injected the deadly mix into the IV, causing his death," Kumar said.

‘All around the world, you see anti-immigrant bias. New Zealand has strong social licence for immigration. Indians are hugely respected’

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrives in New Zealand on July 10-11, New Zealand PM Christopher Luxon tells *The Indian Express* that the two countries share similar views and values, and should be expanding their relationship. In an exclusive interview, PM Luxon speaks about India-New Zealand bilateral ties, trade and defence, dealing with pro-Khalistan elements in the Indian diaspora, the challenge posed by China in the Indo-Pacific, and US President Donald Trump. Excerpts:

What are the major outcomes you are hoping for from this visit?

When you take a step back and think about the New Zealand-India relationship, we have been friends for over 100 years, are actually at different ends of the Indo-Pacific region, but we haven't really had a lot that binds us together to drive a future agenda. We have huge respect for the Indians here in New Zealand. The Indian diaspora is almost 7% of our total population and is hugely successful across all strata of life, as it is around the world, and so I'm really excited. As a young person who spent most of my career with Unilever – we had Hindustan Lever in India – I spent a lot of time in India, and just the progress of this great country has been phenomenal... Prime Minister Modi and I have talked about the two countries having very similar views and values, and how we should actually be doing more together and have a much broader and deeper relationship.

So there are three legs to it. One, how do we continue our economic relationship through the Free Trade Agreement (FTA), which is of mutual benefit, and lift the living standards of both our peoples. The second piece is how we can do more together in a security and defence setting as well. We started some of that work when I visited last time, with our navies working together, but there's a lot more that I'd like to see, with joint exercises, more interactions between our respective defence forces. The third thing is people-to-people connections...

During your visit to India last year and meeting with PM Modi, a decision was taken to start FTA negotiations, and the treaty was concluded in April this year. How was this accomplished in such a short time, and what can the people of India and New Zealand expect to gain from this FTA?

We were able to move so quickly because of high levels of trust. I have huge respect for PM Modi, we have a very strong relationship, and it's likewise for Trade Minister (Piyush) Goyal with my Trade Minister (Todd) McClay. The four of us were really determined to drive it (the FTA) and make sure our systems didn't get lost in bureaucracy and the process, but... to deliver an FTA that would lift the living standards of both peoples.

If you think about our economies, they are quite complementary. Take technology, the smart that exist within India are huge. New Zealand is the best agricultural country on earth, and is now the third biggest launcher of rockets into space. We are building a very good technology sector as well, and are big on renewables... There are lots of things that we can share about our experience in that space, as well as things we can learn from India...

Obviously dairy is something we don't have full access to. It's very important to the Indian economy, and I understand the sensitivity around it, but we have applied a huge amount of R&D to proteins within our dairy sector that are very specialised niche products that are not available in India... We have got massive opportunities with things like apples and lamb... Equally, I want to see growth in our services agreements. We've got some outstanding technology companies that have their bases in India. We'll see more investment into India from New Zealand companies, and expect vice-a-versa...

Everything in life comes back fundamentally to a relationship, and PM Modi and I have a strong relationship... We enjoy each other's company. We're very aligned about what we're here to do as leaders.

One of the coalition partners in your government, New Zealand First, led by your Foreign Minister Winston Peters, is opposed to the FTA. How do you assuage concerns about the durability of the deal on account of this?

I can reassure you about that. We have a mixed-member proportional system... think of it like the governments of Western Europe. There are six parties in our Parliament, with a centre-left and centre-right party the dominant ones. Even though on opposite sides, they are fully supportive of

Ahead of Narendra Modi's visit to New Zealand, the first by an Indian PM in four decades, Prime Minister CHRISTOPHER LUXON speaks to SHUBHAJIT ROY on the bilateral trade agreement, shifting geopolitics, China and the US, and the potential to shape the future of the India-New Zealand partnership



New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Hyderabad House in New Delhi during the former's official visit to India in March 2025. PM Luxon was accompanied by a high-level delegation, including ministers, senior officials and business leaders.

the FTA with India, as are many of the four minor parties. The party you are referencing is one of the four minor parties, and they have always opposed every FTA that New Zealand has ever done, right back to the China FTA in 2008.

So that's not a surprise for us... Rest assured this (the FTA with India) will clear Parliament... In New Zealand, trade between major parties is a bipartisan issue, it's not something that we politicise... It's a New Zealand thing, it's something that's in the interest of all of us to make it work.

One of India's major concerns is China's assertive, often aggressive, behaviour in the Indo-Pacific. How do you see this Chinese threat perception?

There's no doubt about it, we're at an inflection point in global geopolitics. We are moving from a rules-based system to a power-based system, a multilateral system to a multipolar system. We see an America that is talking America first with a fixation on the Western Hemisphere. We see China wanting to have influence in our Indo-Pacific region. We also see Russia illegally invading a sovereign nation in Ukraine and wanting to dominate in Europe... As a free trader, as a small country, since World War II, we have been a huge beneficiary of the rules-based system, (where) small countries are treated the same as large countries, and big ones don't bully little ones...

That's why New Zealand, working with India and other like-minded friends, needs to remake the case for a rules-based system. It definitely needs reform, because in many cases, the Global South countries such as India and Brazil haven't really been part of the system created after World War II... It's not fully determined yet that it has to be a power-based system versus a rules-based system, but we do need to remake the case for it and reform the rules-based system. That's where working with India is so important, and that's why I'm a big believer of having multi mini-lattice work of many lateral arrangements, whether that



be around trade or defence...

When I was in India, we had our frigate up there working with the Indian Navy, they were working on missions together. So there's more that we can do in that space. We need to work with our like-minded friends to build a lattice of relationships... As we've seen in the world, you cannot have prosperity without security, and vice-a-versa. An attack on Iran from the US and Israel has caused huge amounts of pain and suffering to people all around the world...

US President Donald Trump has brought in a fair amount of unpredictability in geopolitics and the global system. How do world leaders like you deal with this?

It's about understanding and appreciating history, because we were here in 1918 (towards the end of World War I), in 1945 (end of World War II), in 1989 and the collapse of the Cold War and the (Berlin) Wall, and since 2022, with Russia's invasion of Ukraine... We've been here in what has increasingly become a power-based system.

I think there are two things you do: you de-risk by working together with like-minded friends with similar values and interests, and you get very clear in your relationships, where you say I will cooperate where I can, I will differ where I must... We have a huge, longstanding, very successful relationship with the US, but we also have fundamental differences around tariffs. We are a free-trading country that has had zero tariffs since the late 80s, and we believe very strongly that tariffs are just not the right economic recipe for the world.

We've seen that movie, and we don't think it ends well.

Now, we can disagree with the Americans around that, we raise it with them, but we still find areas to collaborate and cooperate on... and then work with other like-minded (countries)... (We can) get the EU and CPTPP countries (Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership, including Australia, Brunei, Canada, Chile, Japan, Malaysia, Mexico, New Zealand, Peru, Singapore, the United Kingdom and Vietnam) working together because there's a huge amount of global trade in that. We brought the EU and ASEAN trade ministers together...

India has been concerned about the presence of Sikh separatist, pro-Khalistan elements in the Indian diaspora, including in New Zealand. How do you assuage those security concerns and balance them with the freedom of speech argument?

We fully acknowledge that the Khalistan issue has caused a huge loss of life and pain and suffering to people across India. We fully respect India's sovereign and territorial rights, and yes, we're a liberal democracy. But we have what we call rights and responsibilities, and so yes, you have the right to freedom of expression and freedom of speech, but accompanying that is a responsibility not to incite violence, intimidate others, denigrate others.

Our police make an assessment and are very alert, very alive, constantly monitoring to make sure that people are holding up both ends of that deal, because a liberal democracy only works if you appreciate rights and responsibilities... Also, as New Zealand and India deepen our relationship, we need to be able to sit down and talk about our assessment of terrorism across the region, and in a bilateral and multilateral way.

You are a partner in Five Eyes, the intelligence-sharing alliance that also comprises the US, the UK, Canada and Australia. What do you

think is the scope of collaboration between India and New Zealand when it comes to countering terrorist threats?

Those are areas where we can collaborate more on. It's how we work with many of our European, Southeast Asian and Pacific partners. We share a lot of intelligence with each other about risks and threats and extremism...

There is a lot of interest in India about education and job opportunities in New Zealand, particularly as US policies have put up barriers in the same. Do you see your immigration policies as geared towards welcoming Indians to New Zealand?

We see it as a huge opportunity. All around the world you're seeing countries and democracies in the West react with an anti-immigrant bias and sentiments. That creates opportunity for New Zealand because it means that talented folk who may have headed to the US can now reappraise our educational institutions. We are an English-speaking country, we have an advanced economy, we are a very safe country, and importantly, we have very good educational institutions. We have been very welcoming of Indians to New Zealand on a number of levels.

In fact, India is our second biggest source of visas already, and we've seen a huge growth in our international education market, up 11% in just the last 12 months. The trick, as I observe is, that first and foremost, New Zealand has legal immigration, not illegal. Secondly, we have smart, fair, and targeted principles by which we manage it, anchoring our immigration settings in our economic settings, where we have skill shortages, and in infrastructure. We have the capacity to make sure people are set up for success when they come to this country, that there is sufficient housing, schooling, roads, hospitals...

I think that's why New Zealand has a very strong social licence for immigration, because we have always anchored it, under successive governments. That's where other democracies have gone wrong...

The Indian community that has come to New Zealand has left everything behind for a better future. They work incredibly hard. They take two or three jobs to get a deposit for their house or their business. They get their kids to school and value education, and they never go on welfare. And they are hugely respected in New Zealand. Now they are highly successful in all strata of our life... So, it's an opportunity to make sure we bring the best and the brightest to New Zealand, share those people-to-people connections, form relationships, and (discuss) possibilities about what they can do together, whether it be in the research space, the business space, the community space...

First as a top business executive and then as PM, you have seen India from afar, as well as in close interactions. How do you see India's trajectory?

It's so exciting. I joined Unilever, and we had a very big business in India called Hindustan Lever, a top 10 company in India in its own right. So I started going to India in my 20s, and I remember going to what was a low-income country, I think, at the time, probably the 10th or 12th biggest economy in the world... I remember meeting people and workers that were paid in coins each day, put in their hands... Now you look at it and you see 450 million people in the middle class. By the end of this decade, you know what will be 750 million people living in the middle class. That's so exciting, because in the spirit of our relationship, when people have more money, they want higher quality diets and more protein, they want to have an educational experience and set their kids up for even more success. They want to travel because they can now afford to do so. They want to save some money for retirement and for their pensions, and so that needs to be invested.

And that's just a huge opportunity for both our countries. It's a country I admire tremendously. I'm a huge fan of what PM Modi has done. We think very similarly, we're very action outcomes-oriented leaders, and that's why it was very easy for us to move quickly through the FTA conversation, open up defence conversations and other things that we want to do together...

My wife Amanda and I have often talked about how eventually, when I retire from politics, to get onto your great railway service and travel the country from top to bottom and east to west for three to four months. It would be absolutely fantastic to get all of the dynamism, optimism, ambition, aspiration, positivity that exists in India. It's a great, great country! Yeah, fantastic country!

FIR after under-construction church is vandalised in Bengal

Ravik Bhattacharya
Sonarpur, July 8

THE SMALL community of Christian families in Buri Bot Tola in the Subhasgram area of West Bengal's Sonarpur, about 30 kilometres from Kolkata, is on edge.

On Sunday, a mob barged into an under-construction church here, threatened members of the congregation and vandalised the structure, including climbing onto the roof and damaging three crosses atop the building.

The small church, still under construction and with a tin roof, stands in the middle of the Subhasgram area under Sonarpur police station in South 24 Parganas. Two newly erected pillars lay on the ground.

"We have not faced such a situation before. It was around 3 pm on Sunday when about 100 people gathered near the church. Painting work was going on inside. They claimed we were converting people and started ransacking the church. We tried to protest, but there were so many of them," Barnali Bhiyan (44), a community member, alleged.

"They kicked in the wooden door, breaking its hinges. Then they went inside, brought out a ladder that the workers had been using and climbed onto the church," claimed Utpal Ghosh, another local resident and community member.

Community members alleged the vandals identified themselves as members of the Hindu Jagran Manch and raised slogans while damaging the church. "They asked us why we were wearing shakha-pola and sindur while calling ourselves Christians. I could not make them understand that we have worn these for generations. We have been living here since 2017... They alleged that we were converting people by luring



The under-construction church that was vandalised on Sunday in Sonarpur, South 24 Paragana district, in West Bengal. PARTHA PAUL

them with money. We are poor families; where will we get that kind of money?" said Champa Bhuuiyan (45).

The neighbourhood, which has a mixed population, is home to around 50 Christian families who used to pray in a rented room nearby. After purchasing land in the area, construction of the church began in March. The church belongs to the Presbyterian Church of India.

"There are about 50 families with 116 church members. We are a small community. Since the nearest church is in Sonarpur town, we wanted to build a small one here. If anyone had a problem, they should have approached the authorities long ago. Why attack the church now?" said Geeta Halder, a member of the congregation.

Locals later called the police, who intervened and detained three youths.

A complaint filed by Swapna Purkait, on the basis of which Sonarpur police station registered an FIR, states "the door, locks, two pillars and three crosses on top of the building were damaged". It invokes sections of criminal trespass, mischief causing loss or damage and criminal intimidation.

"An FIR has been lodged, and we have started an investigation.

Everything is peaceful now," said a senior officer of Baruipur police district.

"We have filed a police complaint, which was later turned into an FIR," said Reverend Stephen BC of the church.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Herod Mullick, Christian community leader and founder of Bangiya Christiya Parish (Bengal Christian Council), said, "We have sent a delegation to the spot. We will hold a protest rally on July 14 and submit a memorandum to the Governor."

Koushik Mukherjee, in-charge (Sanyojak) of Sonarpur Uttar and Sonarpur Dakshin Hindu Jagran Manch, told *The Indian Express*: "Local Hindus were complaining that the community was engaged in religious conversions. People were being offered money. An illegal church was being set up there. So we went and questioned them over the allegations. We asked them how they could wear Hindu symbols and claim to be Christians. Meanwhile, hundreds of local Hindus gathered, and there was a scuffle. Some of the locals damaged the church. Three local boys were detained by police. We went to the police station and they were released. We had written to police and the municipality regarding illegal church."

10 yrs after Burhan, how Kashmir's militancy landscape has changed

Numbers are indisputable: In 2016, the year after photos of Burhan and his group emerged on social media, 157 militants were killed in Kashmir. This number peaked at 266 in 2018. This year, it's down to 10

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 8

ON JULY 1, 2015, a picture of 11 young Kashmiri militants, dressed in camouflage, carrying Kalashnikov rifles and posing in a forest, appeared on Facebook. At the centre was Burhan-uddin Wani, who, shedding anonymity unlike militants before him, chose to broadcast himself and his group on social media and went on to operate in the Valley's urban areas, particularly south Kashmir.

The images would draw several educated, tech-savvy young men from well-to-do families to follow in Burhan's footsteps, opening a new chapter in Kashmir's fight against insurgency and leading to a crisis not seen since the 1990s.

The killing of Burhan in a gunfight on July 8, 2016, triggered protests that shut Kashmir for over three months. As young protesters took to the streets and clashed with police, 55 were killed and thousands injured, with the violence in turn fuelling more recruitments. Many announced they were joining militant ranks publicly, at funeral processions.

Exactly 10 years later, the landscape in the Valley stands decisively transformed, with every key militancy indicator, from the number of active militants to fresh local recruitments to militant attacks and killings, showing a sharp decline.

The numbers are indisputable: In 2016, the year after the social media photos first emerged, 157 militants were killed in Kashmir. This number peaked at 266 in 2018 and saw another uptick to 230 in 2020. So far this year, it stands at 10. The number of security forces and civilians killed is also down – from 94 and 88 in 2018, respectively, to just one each this year.

•Casualties in Numbers

YEAR	MILITANTS KILLED	SECURITY FORCES KILLED	CIVILIANS KILLED
2016	157	88	56
2017	217	83	54
2018	266	94	88
2019	160	78	42
2020	230	57	37
2021	192	45	36
2022	186	30	30
2023	85	32	11
2024	68	26	32
2025	46	17	28
2026	10	1	1

able: In 2016, the year after the social media photos first emerged, 157 militants were killed in Kashmir. This number peaked at 266 in 2018 and saw another uptick to 230 in 2020. So far this year, it stands at 10. The number of security forces and civilians killed is also down – from 94 and 88 in 2018, respectively, to just one each this year.

On Wednesday, the killing of Zakir Ahmad Ganaie, a Lashkar-e-Taiba terrorist, in a gunfight in south Kashmir's Shopian means that only one active local militant is now believed to be operating in Kashmir as per police records. The number of foreign operatives, security officials say, hovers around 30.

Top-ranking security officials emphasise the need for caution. "As a civilian, you see peace, the dividends of peace – the attacks have declined, killings have fallen, and the number of arrests and FIRs have come

down. But from the perspective of a security officer, the challenge remains," says a key anti-insurgency police officer.

The shift – online and offline

On ground, officials say, the insurgency landscape has shifted from towns and cities to dense, mountainous forests of the Valley. On social media, the focus is back on anonymity, with communication sparse and an emphasis on leaving little or no footprint. "Even though a large number of operations were always based on HUMINT (human intelligence), the TE-CHINT (technological intelligence) helped corroborate and pinpoint locations with more precision," says a senior police officer. "It also helped us understand the evolving dynamics of insurgency and how they operate, communicate and what they were up to."

Police resort to baton charge as BJP, TMC workers clash during protest over Baruipur rape case

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 8

WORKERS OF the BJP and Trinamool Congress (TMC) clashed in Kolkata on Wednesday during a protest march organised by the Mamata Banerjee-led party over the alleged rape and murder of an 11-year-old girl in Baruipur, prompting police to resort to a baton charge to disperse the two groups.

After the rally, Mamata was seen slapping a TMC worker outside her residence. A video circulating on social media purportedly shows a party worker attempting to manage the crowd and clear a path for Mamata before she slapped him. The video was shared on X by BJP MP Raju Bista. "Mamata Banerjee slapped a man during a TMC protest. The man was trying to control the crowd and make way for Mamata. But Mamata lost her cool and slapped her own party worker," Bista wrote.

The protest march was held after the Calcutta High Court on Tuesday set aside a Kolkata Police communication denying permission for the rally and allowed the TMC to organise it, subject to strict conditions.

The court changed the rally's endpoint from Lansdowne Market on Sarat Bose Road to Hazra Crossing to minimise public inconvenience. It also revised the timing to 2.30 pm to 4.30 pm instead of the proposed 3 pm to 6



Former CM Mamata Banerjee speaks during a rally from Ballygunge Phari to Hazra More, in Kolkata on Wednesday. PARTHA PAUL

pm slot, prohibited use of loudspeakers and directed organisers to use handheld microphones.

The rally, organised by the Trinamool Youth Congress, the party's youth wing, began from Ballygunge Phari in south Kolkata. According to the party, BJP workers repeatedly tried to obstruct the procession on Hazra Road by raising slogans of "chor, chor (thief)" and forming human barricades.

As tensions escalated, workers from both parties were seen exchanging blows before police intervened with a mild baton charge to bring the situation under control.

BJP workers alleged the TMC had "no right" to hold a protest over Baruipur incident, accusing the previous Mamata government of shielding those ac-

cused of crimes against women and trivialising such incidents.

While TMC leaders rejected the allegations, the party in a statement said that 41 of its workers, supporters and leaders were injured in the clashes and admitted to SSKM Hospital.

Addressing reporters after the rally, Mamata alleged that TMC workers were attacked by "BJP-backed anti-social elements" in the presence of police. "I am deeply saddened by the horrific incident that took place against our party workers... They were assaulted and beaten in front of the police," she said.

The former CM alleged BJP supporters had begun gathering near her residence since early morning and rode motorcycles through the area "in an intimidating manner".



Vigilance officials with the cash, gold and silver seized from the house of the retired transport officer Lalit Kumar. EXPRESS

Rs 1 crore cash, 13 kg gold: Raid at retired UP officer's Lucknow home uncovers assets worth Rs 35 crore

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, July 8

RS 1 crore in cash, 13 kg of gold, and documents linked to properties worth over Rs 13 crore: Assets valued at Rs 35 crore were seized from a retired UP transport officer facing a disproportionate assets case, said officials.

The Uttar Pradesh Vigilance Establishment led the raid at the officer's Lucknow home over two days. Officials said the Vigilance Establishment had registered an FIR against Lalit Kumar in 2024, when he was posted as Assistant Regional Transport Officer (ARTO) in Agra, under Sections 13(1)(b) and 13(2) of the Prevention of Corruption Act at its Anti-Corruption police station in Kanpur. The case was filed after a preliminary inquiry found that Kumar allegedly amassed assets disproportionate

to his known sources of income.

According to the DGP Headquarters, the Uttar Pradesh government directed the Vigilance Establishment, Lucknow Sector, to investigate the case against Kumar on the basis of the preliminary inquiry findings and the case. Officials said the Investigating Officer (IO) sought a warrant from the court to conduct a search at the residence of the accused in Chandralok Colony, Aliganj, Lucknow. The team carried out searches on Tuesday and Wednesday.

According to the agency, a huge quantity of cash, gold and silver biscuits, and gold, silver and diamond jewellery was recovered from Kumar's house. Officials also allegedly recovered Rs 1.62 crore in cash wrapped in packets and concealed in different places in the house.

Parallel donation ate into funds at MP temple, probe ordered

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 8

THE MADHYA Pradesh government has ordered a high-level inquiry into alleged financial irregularities in donations at the Maa Baglamukhi Temple in Nalkheda, Agar Malwa, following complaints from an unauthorised private committee had been collecting cash and valuables from devotees outside the official temple administration.

Tourism Minister Dharmendra Lodhi said the state would take strict action against those responsible. The Baglamukhi Temple case assumes added significance as it comes on the heels of the Ayodhya Ram Mandir donation controversy.

Maa Baglamukhi Temple at Nalkheda is one of MP's most prominent Shakti shrines and is administered by the state through an official management committee headed by the local Sub-Divisional Magistrate. .

"The matter has come to my notice, where some people who have no relation with the Baglamukhi Temple administration are illegally taking money by getting receipts printed in the name of the temple. We have ordered Collector to take action, and a committee has been constituted to probe the matter. Those found guilty will not be spared. Our government will take stringent action in the matter..." Lodhi said.

Assault on doctor triggers protests across Maharashtra

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 8

THE ALLEGED assault on doctors and nurses at a civic hospital in Dombivli snowballed into a statewide confrontation between the medical fraternity and the Maharashtra government, even as the main accused — Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre — surrendered before the Thane police following arrest of three of his associates Wednesday.

Later in the evening Mhatre complained of blood pressure and other health ailments following which he was admitted in Thane civil hospital.

Earlier, resident doctors and nurses announced protests across the state, while healthcare organisations warned of an indefinite strike if strict action is not taken against those responsible.

The Maharashtra State Association of Resident Doctors (Central MARD) welcomed Mhatre's arrest and said resident doctors in all government medical colleges and hospitals would wear black ribbons on Thursday while continuing medical services. It stressed the agitation is aimed at seeking long-term measures to curb rising incidents of violence against healthcare workers across the state.

The Maharashtra State Nurses Association said nurses across the state would begin a

three-day black-ribbon protest from July 10 and warned that it would intensify the agitation after July 13 if no concrete action was taken. The Maharashtra Senior Resident Doctors' Association and the BMC MARD also condemned the incident, sought Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis's intervention and demanded a zero-tolerance policy against violence in hospitals.

In separate memoranda to the chief minister, the doctors' and nurses' organisations described the alleged assault as an attack on the dignity of healthcare workers and the functioning of public hospitals. They demanded immediate arrests, strict action under the Maharashtra Medicare Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, stronger hospital security, and protection for doctors and nurses performing their duties.

Dr Manisha Shinde, president of Nurses Association, said: "People have no fear of law and order and think they can get away easily after assaulting doctors, nurses or any other medical staff deployed to treat them. There has to be strict action so that no one dares to repeat such acts... We want the CM to take this matter very seriously. Doctors and nurses are already treating an overwhelming number of patients despite being understaffed and overworked."



Karnataka High Court

The petitioners, who work as software engineers in Bengaluru, told the court that they have been together for more than seven years -- cohabiting

since 2019 with a jointly owned house in the city. The petition also states that they seek neither recognition nor presumption of marriage, nor any

declaration of marital status.

A line of decisions, dating back to a 1927 ruling by the Privy Council in *A Dinohamy v. Balahamy*, holds that if a man and woman are proved to have lived together as husband and wife for a prolonged period, the law will presume they are validly married, rather than partners lacking full legal rights and inheritance privileges. The plea by Kalia and Godi also cited Supreme Court rulings, as recent as 2023 in *Smt. Shiramabai v. OIC Records*, to argue for recognition of their relationship.

They argued that a heterosexual couple in the petitioners' circumstances would therefore qualify as "spouses", and hence

"relatives", under the tax exemption. The petitioners argued that they are denied the same benefit "solely on the basis of sex", in violation of Articles 14 and 15 of the Constitution, with consequent violations of Articles 19(1)(a) and 21, by taxing "an expression of love and affection".

In a landmark ruling in 2018, the Supreme Court had held that "sex" under Article 15 includes sexual orientation.

Justice B M Shyam Prasad, who briefly heard the matter in the Karnataka High Court, narrowed the case to a single issue: when the legislature has chosen not to define "spouse", can a court enlarge the term's

scope through judicial interpretation?

"We intend to hear only on this aspect. If the enactment says the receipt in the hand of these only would not be income from other sources, how do we say it is discriminatory? The moment we say it is discriminatory, a door is open," the court said in an oral observation.

The court also asked whether the definition's meaning or scope could be extended to relatives of any kind: "There could be foster sons or foster daughters."

A similar challenge to the provision, filed by Payio Ashiho and his partner Vivek Divan, is also pending before the Bombay High Court.



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• DEFENCE

The significance of Astra missiles, which Indonesia will purchase

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 8

INDIA AND Indonesia on Tuesday reached a significant milestone in their growing strategic cooperation by signing a deal for the supply of the Astra Mk1 ‘beyond-visual-range air-to-air missiles’ (BVRAAM).

Beyond-visual-range missiles are those capable of engaging beyond the range of 20 nautical miles, or 37 km. Air-to-air missiles are primarily fired from an airborne asset to destroy an airborne target.

The development is significant as it marks India’s first export of Astra missiles to another country. These missiles will arm Indonesia’s Su-30 fleet.

The missile and its variants

Developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation, Astra is a family of indigenous BVRAAMs that will be integrated with the Air Force and the Navy.

The first in the family, Astra Mk1, has a range of 80 to 110 km, an altitude of up to 20 km and a speed of Mach 4.5 (or 4.5 times the speed of sound).

The missile is being integrated with the IAF’s Sukhoi-30 MKI fleet and is also planned to be integrated with the indigenous Light Combat Aircraft Tejas Mk1A and the French Rafale jets in the future. DRDO and the IAF successfully conducted its flight test last year.

A more advanced version — the Astra Mk2 — has an enhanced range of 200 km, from the earlier decided range of around 160 km. This missile variant was granted the Acceptance of Necessity by the Defence Acquisition Council in December, indicating the government’s interest in starting the procurement process soon, even as it is still in various phases of testing. They will also be integrated into the latest fighter jets of the IAF once inducted.

The Astra Mk3 is still under development by the DRDO. Officially named Gandiva, it will be India’s most advanced BVRAAM. It will likely be powered by a Solid Fuel Ducted Ramjet (SFDR) engine, allowing it to maintain continuous thrust mid-flight rather than burning out like conventional rocket motors.

Earlier this year, the DRDO had conducted a flight test of its SFDR technology for the Astra Mk3, which could have a range of over 350 km.

Operation Sindoor, launched by India against Pakistan last year, demonstrated the criticality of longer-range BVRAAM missiles — and Astra is India’s indigenous answer to that. A key focus area of the IAF is now to procure more batches of modern BVRAAM missiles. The Astra programme will help India build greater self-reliance, instead of depending solely on other imported air-to-air missiles such as the Meteor and R-77.

A key part of the arsenal

The missile will be a counter to the long-range PL-15 in use by both Pakistan and China. The PL-15 is an advanced, very long-range, active radar-guided air-to-air missile developed by China.

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• EDUCATION

India’s engineering colleges are losing sheen in AI era: What a reset can look like



EXPERT EXPLAINS
RAJEEV KUMAR

FORMER COMPUTER SCIENCE PROFESSOR AT IITs KHARAGPUR & KANPUR, BITS PILANI, & JNU

INDIA’S AMBITION to become a global-tech powerhouse hinges on its ability to produce world-class engineers. From artificial intelligence (AI), semiconductors, and quantum technologies to advanced manufacturing, clean energy, and the digital economy, engineering talent will be the cornerstone of the country’s next phase of growth and global competitiveness. Yet, why is engineering education — the very pipeline expected to power the AI revolution — steadily losing its sheen?

While the IITs and a handful of premier

public and private institutions continue to attract India’s brightest students, a large segment of engineering colleges is witnessing decline. The trend is reflected in the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) placing 58 engineering colleges under “progressive closure” and discontinuing more than 950 engineering and technical courses during 2025-26. Progressive closure is typically invoked for persistently low admissions and failure to comply with quality norms.

The challenge is not that engineering has become less relevant; rather, the real crisis lies in the widening gap between the capabilities expected by a technology-driven economy and those delivered by a large section of India’s engineering education ecosystem. Unless this gap is bridged, India’s aspirations for global leadership could be constrained not by a shortage of opportunities but that of employable, high-quality engineering talent.

Shift in policy focus

Until the late 1990s, engineering education in India was largely confined to pub-

licly funded institutions such as the IITs, regional engineering colleges (now National Institutes of Technology, or NITs), a few state engineering colleges, and private institutions concentrated mainly in Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Tamil Nadu. Limited capacity made admissions highly competitive, leaving India with a persistent shortage of engineering graduates.

The global IT boom around the Y2K revolution saw surging worldwide demand for software professionals, triggering an unprecedented expansion of engineering education. Thousands of new colleges emerged across metropolitan, urban, and rural India.

At the same time, the Union government expanded the network of Institutes of National Importance (INIs) by establishing new IITs and Indian Institutes of Information Technology (IIITs) and upgrading the regional engineering colleges into NITs. Today, India has 79 INIs: 23 IITs, 31 NITs, and 25 IIITs.

As access widened, the policy focus shifted from expansion to excellence. While AICTE approval remained the statutory requirement for establishing and op-

erating engineering institutions and programs (except most INIs, which enjoy statutory autonomy), the National Board of Accreditation (NBA) introduced outcome-based accreditation to benchmark programme quality against global standards. Replacing the traditional input-based approach, the NBA’s criteria were based on measurable learning outcomes, graduate attributes, continuous improvement, and industry relevance. Accreditation soon became a key prerequisite for programme expansion.

Survival and sustainability

The AI revolution, which gathered momentum in the mid-2010s, has fundamentally reshaped engineering education. As industry demand shifted rapidly towards computer science, AI, data science and allied disciplines, student preferences followed suit. Traditional branches such as mechanical, electrical, and related engineering saw sustained declines in demand. The AICTE’s moratorium on new engineering institutions in 2020 (before its lifting in 2023) reflected this changing landscape.

The transition accelerated after the Covid-19 pandemic, when AICTE removed the requirement for NBA accreditation to increase student intake or introduce new programmes. Consequently, many reputed institutions expanded capacity in high-demand disciplines while rationalising seats in traditional branches. As admissions became concentrated in a relatively small number of institutions, hundreds of lower-tier colleges were left with severely depleted enrolments, eroding their financial viability.

India today has an approved undergraduate engineering intake of nearly 15 lakh seats, of which the IITs account for about 19,000, the NITs for about 25,000, and the IIITs for about 11,000. Yet, several thousand seats even in NITs and IIITs remain unfilled each year, while 20-40% of seats in many traditional programmes remain vacant.

The imbalance between student demand and institutional capacity has made survival increasingly difficult for a large segment of engineering institutions. For many, progressive closure is no longer merely a regulatory measure but an inevitable consequence.

The next phase of engineering education must shift to one driven by learning, innovation, and employability. Curricula should be continuously aligned with emerging technologies such as AI, data science and cybersecurity, while preserving strong foundations in mathematics, science and core engineering. A transition from rote learning to competency-based education through project-based learning, interdisciplinary problem-solving and stronger industry-academia collaboration is essential.

Institutional performance should be judged not merely by infrastructure and faculty strength, but by graduate employability, research, innovation, startups, patents and industry engagement.

Transforming engineering education is no longer an academic reform — it is a strategic imperative. India already has islands of excellence in its IITs and a few top institutions; the challenge is to replicate these strengths across the broader ecosystem while enabling the orderly exit of persistently non-performing institutions.

• GEOPOLITICS

Why US & Iran may keep trading blows amid talks



EXPERT EXPLAINS
BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH, DELHI

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said Wednesday that the interim ceasefire with Iran was “over” after a flare-up of hostilities between the two countries, although he added that he would allow negotiations to continue. He warned of targeting Iran again.

Iran targeted US military sites in Bahrain and Kuwait after US forces struck Iranian targets in response to attacks on tankers in the Strait of Hormuz.

The same pattern of attacks was also seen on June 26 and June 27 — Iran preventing transit through the Strait of Hormuz for commercial ships that did not coordinate with it, the US Central Command bombing Iranian targets and Iran hitting US bases in Bahrain and Kuwait.

This familiar cycle of escalation has threatened the shaky ceasefire between the two countries and jeopardised negotiations to turn the June 17 memorandum of understanding (MoU) into a lasting peace deal.

While Trump’s comments have increased this uncertainty, he left a window open by saying that US representatives can continue negotiations. But he added: “They can talk, but I think they’re wasting their time.” Although Trump has at times stepped back from threats he has made against Iran, oil prices surged and stocks fell after his latest remarks, *Reuters* reported.

These exchanges between the US and Iran are an immediate effect of the differences over the Strait of Hormuz’s future administration. But that’s hardly the only factor at play here.

The Strait of Hormuz question

Under Article 5 of the MoU — which Trump has now declared “over” — the long-term administration of the Strait of Hormuz is to be determined jointly by Oman and Iran, “in line with applicable international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states of the Strait”.

By June 23, Iran and Oman jointly declared the creation of a working group “to



reach agreement on the future administration of navigation in the Strait”. While this meets Iran’s objective to prevent the strait’s return to its pre-war status, Oman’s cooperation remains crucial for Tehran.

So far, Muscat’s rejection of flat tolls in the strait (prohibited by Article 26 of the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea) has resulted in an arrangement where ships pay coastal states for potential services rendered — which a liberal interpretation of UNCLOS Article 43 allows. While both states differ over whether such payments are to be voluntary or mandatory, it is evident that the structures for the strait’s long-term administration are already being built.

It is the short-term administration of the strait that is a recurring trigger for conflict.

Under the MoU, Iran was to allow unconditional passage to all commercial ships for 60 days. For Washington, this means a preclusion of any coordination with Iranian authorities. This interpretation was furthered through an International Maritime Organization-led plan that sought to create a temporary southern route through Omani waters and another northern route close to Iran’s Larak island in the strait for commercial passage and rescue of stranded vessels.

The main traffic separation scheme in the central channel remains shut, pending mine clearance. But Iran’s strikes on vessels transiting through the southern route prove it will not accept any new “arrangements from those currently being pursued” for the

Funeral prayers for Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Qom, Iran on Tuesday. AP

Widening gulf

Oman, Qatar and Saudi Arabia’s engagement with Iran has affected their ties with the US.

A recent *Wall Street Journal* report indicated a downturn in US-Saudi ties. This was due to Riyadh’s refusal to back Washington’s failed military effort in early May to re-open the Strait of Hormuz.

Strait of Hormuz. So, even as the long-term future of the strait is clear, the short-term is not. Iran’s sensitivities over any attempted new route (however temporary) draw from the Strait of Hormuz’s new value as its main instrument of leverage. This will have to be reconciled with Washington’s preference for unhindered passage during the 60-day negotiation period.

Iraq and Lebanon

While the short-term nature of this Hormuz-focused difference can theoretically ensure that US-Iran military clashes do not become a permanent feature, it is clear that a severe lack of trust with the US necessitates continual Iranian assertion to ensure that Washington does not deviate from MoU terms until negotiations for a final deal begin. Central to this is Washington’s need to shape regional developments enough in the short term to ensure that Iran’s long-term gains (beyond Hormuz) are curtailed. The volatility this creates is evident across regional states.

In Iraq, for instance, both the US withdrawal and Iran’s entrenched presence through the Popular Mobilization Forces creates fresh ground for long-term Iranian influence. Washington, however, can still leverage Baghdad’s need to sustain its ties with the US, as was witnessed during US Envoy Tom Barrack’s June 15 visit to Iraq where he pressed new Iraqi premier Ali al-Zaidi to act against Iran-linked armed

groups. By June 28, during Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi’s Iraq visit, Baghdad conducted unprecedented simultaneous midnight raids on at least 47 senior politicians and leaders, several of whom have close ties to Tehran and the PMF.

Similarly, in Lebanon, while Iran’s need to ensure Israeli adherence to the ceasefire remains, the June 26 Framework agreement ties Israeli withdrawal to Hezbollah’s disarmament — which the group continues to categorically reject, in light of Israel’s continued occupation of South Lebanon. The Lebanese government’s assent to the deal despite its lack of effective enforcement abilities leaves Lebanon in a volatile predicament where recurring Israeli strikes could further reduce trust in US-Iran technical talks, as has already occurred before.

What to make of the strikes

The recurring strikes are driving up the distrust between Tehran and Washington in the 60-day period, even though both appear committed to negotiating a final deal.

Gulf states themselves have already begun adapting to the new regional order.

Qatar, for instance, announced on June 18 that it was operationalising (and enhancing) a 2022 agreement that seeks to link Iran’s South Pars and Qatar’s North Field gas reservoirs. This can give Iran a transmission capacity of up to 1,000 megawatts from Qatar’s electrical grid.

And Saudi Arabia is reportedly preparing to host a “Gulf-Iran reconciliation summit”. This will expand the space for Iran’s reintegration with Gulf economies.

Oman, Qatar and Saudi Arabia — unlike Bahrain, Kuwait and UAE — are looking to contain the Iranian threat through engagement and reconciliation, a path reinforced by what is widely agreed to be a strategic defeat for the US and Israel in the war.

Iran feels that the US will respond to its increased regional heft by repeatedly attempting to undermine its gains. This, in turn, would be something that Tehran would necessarily have to counter. This dynamic could trigger both intermittent military skirmishes before any final deal is reached, as well as a return to full-scale war.

Hence, this period of uncertainty may continue to witness more rounds of limited strikes, hostile rhetoric, mutually destructive threats and seemingly categorical assertions related to the long-term US-Iran relationship. In effect, however, they are likely to be focused principally on weakening the short-term negotiating position of the other side.

• INFRASTRUCTURE

Indira Point: Inside the plan to protect lighthouse, develop tourism hub

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 8

THE UNION Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways has proposed protection and development works at Indira Point and the famous lighthouse at the site in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Through the Directorate of Lighthouses and Lightships, Sri Vijaya Puram (formerly Port Blair), an agency under the ministry, the Centre has sought coastal regulation zone clearance to carry out the proposed work.

Indira Point is India’s southernmost tip, located on the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) in the Union Territory (UT) of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. It is an important maritime landmark, and lies to the south of the Galathea Bay, where a transshipment port has been proposed under the GNI mega infrastructure project.

The government proposal

The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, through the Directorate Gen-

eral of Lighthouses and Lightships, wants to structurally repair and eventually develop tourism infrastructure and facilities around the lighthouse.

The Centre wants to strengthen the structure, the immediate site around it and along with it, it has proposed a string of development activities. After the visit of Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal in late November 2023, the project was approved by the Central Advisory Committee of Aids to Navigation to “preserve and protect the lighthouse for its functional requirement for safety of mariners, rich legacy of region, for historic and cultural significant for future generations”, as per the project’s environmental impact assessment study.

As per a detailed project report by IIT Madras for the proposed development works, structural reinforcements will include repair and strengthening of the lighthouse tower’s foundation, an all-weather approach road, shore protection works with break waters around the tower, power-

Maritime landmark

The lighthouse at Indira Point is an important landmark on the Singapore-Colombo international maritime route and is used as a navigational aid.

It also holds importance for safe navigation towards the Galathea Bay in the coming times, where a transshipment port has been proposed.

house, inspection and staff quarters, compound wall and internal pathways.

Separately, development activities for tourism promotion have been proposed. These include eco-tourism, convention centre, cafeteria, viewing tower, cycle tracks, and an international standard museum building as well as a memorial structure.

The need for protection

The works proposed fall in sensitive coastal habitats, which are protected under the Island Coastal Regulation Zone Notification, 2019. So, it needs prior approval from the UT’s Coastal Zone Management Authority and the Environment Ministry. The notification provides a regulatory framework for protection of coastal stretches, marine habitats and livelihoods of fisher and other coastal communities across the group of islands.

The lighthouse structure has faced weathering. The structural issues it faces can also be attributed to the changes it faced during the December 2004 earth-

quake and tsunami. The 2004 natural calamity had a huge impact on the entire island group, causing uplift in some areas and land sinking in others.

The site where Indira Point is situated, specifically, faced permanent land subsidence at the time. Originally, the site of the lighthouse and associated structures was at a height of 3.5 m above mean sea level. When the earthquake and tsunami struck the island, the land sinking and the inland ingress of the sea engulfed the lighthouse tower while destroying quarters and huts around it. Scientists and authorities have estimated that the Nicobar islands sunk 2.04 m, thus submerging the lighthouse base and foundation in sea.

The geological and shoreline changes have exposed the foundation to seawater since 2004, extreme wave conditions during high tide, as per the IIT Madras assessment. The lighthouse also shows a 3.86° inclination or tilt, which was, however, not considered as a risk to its structural stability or safety.



Deepening India-Japan partnership offers a powerful, constructive model



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

WHEN JAPANESE Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi was in Delhi last week, I was in Japan. There was no connection between the two trips, but we both had a common message: A stronger India-Japan relationship is imperative for both countries at this time of global turbulence.

The first official three-day visit of PM Takaichi for the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit (July 1 to 3) marked a major turning point for Indo-Pacific diplomacy, injecting a massive \$12.5 billion in fresh Japanese investment into infrastructure and manufacturing sectors, effectively transforming the alliance into an economic powerhouse. Takaichi's milestone visit yielded 129 MoUs, primarily driven by the India-Japan Joint Economic Forum, which hosted over 150 leading Japanese corporations looking to anchor their capital in India's expanding ecosystem. By establishing a comprehensive roadmap for resilient supply chains in critical technology sectors, including semiconductors, telecommunications, and critical minerals, the partnership actively seeks to reduce vulnerability to single-source global networks and external market disruptions.

The summit solidified deep defence co-operation by committing to joint manufacturing of advanced military hardware, introducing the first military hardware co-development project focussing on cutting-edge naval technology like the Unified Complex Radio Antenna masts, alongside advanced bilateral deliberations regarding the future co-production of *Mogami*-class stealth frigates. Coupled with wide-ranging agreements on high-level AI safety standards, digital development frameworks, and a clean energy initiative spanning proposals for large-scale green ammonia and a rollout plan for 1,000 regional biogas plants, the summit positioned the partnership as a significant, multifaceted geopolitical counterweight in the region.



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

The structural alignment underscores that beyond trade and investment, the contemporary geopolitical reality demands that India and Japan build Asia's most trusted civilisational partnership, one rooted in shared history, values, and democratic systems. At a historical moment when democracies worldwide are under stress, India and Japan stand as unique anchors of stable democratic governance in Asia, collectively representing one-fifth of humanity living under the rule of law. The strategic alignment formalised via the Quad is not a military alliance but a civilisational commitment to a free, open, and rules-based Indo-Pacific that respects national sovereignty and institutional resilience. By combining their voices, both nations are building an alternative blueprint for global governance, proving that technological progress, environmental sustainability, and commitment to human values can coexist within a fractured global order.

This civilisational cohesion finds an immediate practical application when addressing the stark demographic contrasts that define both societies. While their demographic trajectories appear diametrically opposed, they present an opportunity for complementarity. Japan faces an unprecedented demographic contraction, marked by a shrinking labour force and an ageing society that places severe stress on healthcare systems, hospitality, and technological management. Conversely, India continues to experience expansive demographic growth, with millions of young, technically literate citizens entering the workforce annually but facing unemployment. A hol-

The true measure of the India-Japan partnership will be its capacity to foster an inclusive economic paradigm that prioritises the expansion of a stable middle class

istic, long-term talent and mobility collaboration can transform this contrast into shared economic benefits. By pairing Japan's acute labour shortages with structured, multidisciplinary talent-acquisition frameworks, Indian professionals can contribute substantively to Japan's socio-economic security. This arrangement must transcend short-term, myopic migration; it demands an immigration policy framework that prioritises cultural orientation, and robust institutional support to protect workers while delivering highly specialised care and management to Japan's silver economy.

This demographic synergy forms the cornerstone of what must become a joint India-Japan care economy. As Japan navigates its post-industrial demographic transition, it has pioneered sophisticated models of elder-care, rehabilitative robotics, and age-appropriate infrastructure. In the coming decades, India will paradoxically house one of the world's largest elderly populations alongside its youthful workforce, rendering Japan's current domestic challenges an essential preview for our future. Through joint venture initiatives, research-based collaborations, and knowledge transfers, India can proactively draw inspiration from Japanese models to develop a sustainable care economy before ageing becomes an acute national crisis.

An equally transformative dimension of this partnership lies in expanding female labour force participation. By designing structured pathways for Indian women to access certified training and employment in Japan (under guaranteed conditions of safe housing,

career progression, and harassment-free workplace protocols), both nations can simultaneously address Japan's care vacuum and advance female inclusion within India's domestic workforce.

The bridge between these demographic initiatives and industrial durability lies in the integration of Japanese hardware excellence with Indian digital innovation. Celebrated for its peerless precision engineering, robotics, and advanced manufacturing, Japan possesses the material solutions to the physical supply-chain problems of the 21st century. India, conversely, has demonstrated global leadership in developing expansive digital public infrastructure, scalable software architectures, and highly adaptable AI applications. The two nations can co-develop next-generation assistive technologies, smart medical devices, and automated logistics networks. This synthesis ensures that economic growth remains anchored in real-world productivity, creating resilient industrial clusters that can insulate both nations from external supply shocks.

The true measure of the India-Japan partnership will be its capacity to foster an inclusive economic paradigm that prioritises the expansion of a stable middle class. India's developmental vision cannot be measured solely by GDP; true prosperity requires an egalitarian framework where the benefits of growth are democratised. In this pursuit, Japan's post-war economic miracle serves as the ultimate inspiration, demonstrating that enduring national stability and prosperity emerge when economic policies strengthen ordinary citizens. By shifting the focus of economic cooperation towards manufacturing hubs, logistics networks, and technological infrastructure in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, India can replicate Japan's success in driving regional balance and upward social mobility.

As India and Japan step forward into an era defined by global uncertainty, my visit convinced me that our deepening alliance offers a powerful, constructive model for the world: Proof that two great civilisations can align their economic security, demographic strategies, and technological futures to build a more stable, equitable, and democratic Indo-Pacific.

The writer is a fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram and chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs



PRADEEP BHANDARI

LET US be honest from the very first sentence. Yogendra Yadav's article ('Some democratic lessons from Global South that our Opposition needs', *IE*, July 7) is a pre-packaged alibi for political defeat — penned well before the ballot boxes are sealed so that an inevitable political surrender can be retroactively branded as a grand strategy.

Yadav asks, "Why bother with elections?" and flirts openly with the idea of a comprehensive opposition boycott. He calls it a "good question but a bad answer". The truth is, it is neither. It is the ultimate coping mechanism for a fragmented Opposition that has lost its connection to the Indian grassroots and now seeks refuge in the lexicon of institutional victimisation. Yadav claims that "uncertainty has disappeared from elections". Translated from academic to political reality, this means: "Our side cannot win, so the entire system must be fraudulent."

The core argument driving the Opposition's current grievance narrative is that the political dominance of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) under Prime Minister Narendra Modi represents an unprecedented, structural death blow to competitive politics. This entire argument is questionable under the weight of empirical historical data.

In 1957, when the Congress party was at its peak under Jawaharlal Nehru, it held power in 12 out of 13 states — a staggering 92 per cent of all state governments — and commanded 371 out of 494 Lok Sabha seats (71 per cent). By comparison, the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) holds approximately 55 per cent of the seats in the Lok Sabha and leads state governments in 18 out of the 31 states and Union Territories with legislative bodies, roughly 58 per cent. Further, let us look at the evolution of political choices and systemic competitiveness. In the 1957 general election, a mere 49 political parties participated. Now, the Election Commission of India (ECI) registers over 740 political parties fielding candidates.

To legitimise his narrative, Yadav selectively cites Adam Przeworski's *Why Bother With Elections?*, as if an academic smoking gun is uncovered. Yet, he gives little attention to Przeworski's core assertion: Elections are the most successful mechanism for resolving deep societal conflicts peacefully and remain the single least-bad way of choosing rulers. More importantly, Przeworski's theoretical framework was explicitly designed around the transition of volatile Latin American autocracies — not a mature republic like India. Similarly, Yadav parades Pippa Norris's 11 dimensions of electoral integrity as an absolute gospel of Indian decline. But Norris's papers have never classified India as a "failed" or "fixed" electoral system, and she has frequently noted the resilience of India's voting mechanics.

If the ECI is merely a "fixed authority", why does the international community view it as a global benchmark? For seven decades under Congress, the Election Commission was appointed solely by executive choice. This government has reformed this, establishing a statutory selection panel that explicitly includes consultation with the Leader of the Opposition. The structural integrity of our process is why international bodies look to New Delhi for guidance. Just recently, Indonesia — the world's third-largest democracy, with over 200 million voters — formally sought to partner with India to develop and import customised Indian electronic voting machines (EVMs) and adopt our election management model.

The noise surrounding the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voters' lists follows the same pattern. An accurate, duplicate-free voter roll is the foundation of a clean election. When the Opposition approached the Supreme Court alleging institutional "vote *chori*" during voter list revisions, the apex court thoroughly evaluated and dismissed the alarmist petitions. Chief Justice Surya Kant explicitly validated the field verification process.

Yadav's central thesis completely disintegrates when confronted with the reality of the ballot box. If the system is an airtight, rigged autocracy, how did the opposition coalition expand its footprint so dramatically to secure 234 seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections? Look at the most recent, concrete evidence from the 2026 assembly elections. Five major states went to the polls. If the electoral machinery were under the absolute administrative thumb of the ruling dispensation, the outcomes would be uniform. Instead, two out of those five states went directly to the Congress-led opposition. In Kerala, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) swept to power with 97 out of 140 seats. Did the EVMs suddenly function perfectly and the SIR exercise become satisfactory in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, only to be "rigged" in states where the BJP or its allies triumphed?

Yadav's entire argument is also a profound insult to the 642 million citizens who cast their ballots in the recent general elections. With a staggering overall turnout even crossing 90 per cent (as in West Bengal), and women outvoting men in higher proportions than ever before, the Indian electorate proved they are active stakeholders. The current Opposition does not need tactical lessons imported from authoritarian regimes. It needs a basic lesson in political humility.

The writer is national spokesperson, Bharatiya Janata Party

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Need for discipline

SANJAY KUMAR JHA'S piece on India-Japan ties and the opening for Bihar gets the civilisational case right ('In growing India-Japan ties, an opportunity for Bihar', *IE*, July). Rajgir, Nalanda, Vaishali, the Xuanzang trail — all of it is capital sitting unused. But reading it as someone from Patna, I found myself waiting for a paragraph that never came. Say the investment comes tomorrow. What happens next? I have watched Patna's own flyovers turn into garbage dumps within a year of inauguration. The new double-decker flyover on Ashok Rajpath had barely opened before the potted plants on its pillars started disappearing. Infrastructure was never the missing part. What is missing is the discipline to keep it working.

Pawan Raj, Patna

Risky business

THE AUTHOR correctly points out that walking has become a dangerous activity, supported by the alarming figure of 36,000 pedestrian deaths in 2024 ('Our right to walk is broken — just like our footpaths', *IE*, July 8). In my view, the Supreme Court's recent acknowledgment of safe footpaths as a basic constitutional right is an important step. However, policies on paper mean little without strict enforcement. Until city officials start penalising two-wheelers on sidewalks and removing unplanned structures, our cities will remain unfriendly to walkers.

Khyati Singh Shekhawat, Barmer

PEDESTRIANS FINDING little space in the agenda of modern policymakers, who plan urban spaces primarily for drivers of motor vehicles, is a bitter reality ('Our right to walk is broken — just like our footpaths', *IE*, July 8). Walking spaces need to be restored to pedestrians, to whom they rightfully belong. There is a great need to change the mindset of drivers viewing pedestrians as a nuisance.

SH Quadri, Bikaner



NISHANT SHAH AND
MAYA INDIRA GANESH

WHEN THE first *Toy Story* came out in 1995, it was embraced as a story of friendship between Andy and his toys. Underneath that warmth, it was also a story about technologies: What they promise, threaten, and how they become toys. Woody, the pull-string cowboy, fears being replaced by Buzz Lightyear, the techno-gizmo spaceman who arrives with lights, wings, buttons, and a full mythology built in. Buzz is a toy that does not know he is a toy. He gains that wisdom only when the film returns him to play.

Toys are technologies in the most expansive sense of the word. They extend a child's imagination, but only after the child takes hold of them. The child makes the toy speak differently, bends it into a story it was not designed to tell.

Toy Story 5 returns to that first drama of replacement. Bonnie gets a tablet — Lilypad — and the older toys again face a newer technology. Bonnie is smitten by the shiny thing that listens, remembers, and responds. Lilypad is not Buzz in a new avatar. Lilypad comes pre-wired, connected to corporations and systems that give it meaning, purpose, and script far beyond Bonnie's room. It does not wait for Bonnie's imagination. It imagines

Banning social media or choosing 'good AI' over 'bad AI' will not settle this. The world has changed the terms of play, and children will change as players too

Bonnie back: Reading her moods, anticipating her preferences, rewarding her return, placing the next thing in front of her before she has a chance to wait or choose.

Bonnie's toys become alive because she plays with them. Lilypad comes pre-animated, trying to shape Bonnie's life. That reversal is *Toy Story 5*'s deeper question. Technologies become toys when they invite children to imagine themselves, the world, and their futures through them. They become devices when they imagine the child first and return that child as a profile. *The Toy Story* films have always worried over play under attack. The toys survive because the relationship returns to play.

Lilypad refuses that relation. It collapses companionships that used to be spread across toys, people, books, classrooms, and screens into one device. It renders Bonnie back to herself, not as what she can become, but as the version the device likes best. That rendering makes the child smaller in the guise of knowing her better.

Just as Lilypad is not Buzz, Bonnie is not Andy. Bonnie, like children today, is an AI-native child whose sense of self is being shaped beyond social media, beyond screen time, beyond parental controls. In true Disney style, Bonnie finds a balance between toys, de-

vices, and friends. Our children cannot carry that burden. Lilypad is not merely a device in a room but a networked intelligence that carries the child into an unsupervised outside without consent. At a recent workshop in Los Angeles, where we worked with writers from Hollywood to deepen our thinking on portraying issues of digital tech on screen, one thing was very clear: Banning social media or choosing "good AI" over "bad AI" will not settle this. The world has changed the terms of play, and children will change as players too.

Toys, in our romantic imagination, are things to be played with. AI companions introduce a perverse reversal, where the child becomes the object of play. When children stop being the ones who imagine the world and become imagined by the devices around them, the problem is no longer what happens to toys. It is what happens to the child. Bonnie's future will not be found in choosing toys over AI, but in building worlds where children, toys, and intelligent systems leave room for independence, discovery, imagination, and agency.

That is not Pixar's story alone. It is ours.

Shah is associate professor and director of Digital Narratives Studio, Chinese University of Hong Kong. Ganesh is associate director, Leverhulme Centre for the Future of Intelligence, University of Cambridge

Food is the tuberculosis vaccine we already have



URVASHI B SINGH

EVERY YEAR, more than 26 lakh Indians are diagnosed with TB. The conversation that follows is almost always about which drugs, for how long, and whether the strain is resistant. I have witnessed patients with an accurate diagnosis and drugs lose ground, week by week, because a body without adequate nutrition cannot fight this disease. We have shortened treatment regimens, extended social support to patients on treatment and tracked the treatment journey in real time digitally. In the Indian context, research shows that a severely undernourished TB patient is four times more likely to die during treatment.

India has not ignored this critical overlap. The TB Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan has made a meaningful conceptual shift: Individuals with a BMI below 18.5 are identified as vulnerable and prioritised for TB screening and offered X-rays — even for those without symptoms. Once a person is diagnosed with TB, tailored and individualised care is built into the treatment pathway.

Since 2018, the Nikshay Poshan Yojana has provided direct cash transfers to every notified TB patient, a benefit doubled to Rs. 1,000 per month two years ago, with over Rs. 4,590 crore disbursed to 1.39 crore patients till March. Over 7.16 lakh Nikshay Mitras, including citizens, corporates, and community organisations, have stepped forward with food baskets (for both the patient and the family) and psychosocial support for patients. On this count, India is

ahead of most countries. The government has also committed to providing energy-dense nutritional supplements (EDNS) to undernourished patients. A trial conducted in Faridabad found that TB patients who received energy-dense nutritional supplements were twice as likely to gain the weight they needed in the first two months of treatment, and patients who do not gain that weight are far more likely to face treatment failure and death. Providing nutrition support to patients with a BMI of less than 18.5

In the Indian context, research shows that a severely undernourished TB patient is four times more likely to die during treatment

could benefit nearly half of all diagnosed TB patients in India each year.

The next frontier is addressing the condition that makes people vulnerable to TB in the first place. According to the WHO, undernutrition is the single largest risk factor for TB globally. The evidence now is asking us to look at nutrition as a critical preventive strategy. A modelling study in *The Lancet Global Health* this year found that eliminating undernutrition could prevent one in four adult TB cases globally, with India standing to gain the most. The authors argue that current estimates of undernutrition's role in driving TB have been underestimated. The findings are a challenge to how we prioritise our TB prevention response.

The new evidence also validates what we have known by instinct, and an argument for scaling nutrition as a preventive

strategy with greater urgency: Find people who are undernourished and at elevated TB risk, provide meaningful nutrition support and counselling. The benefits extend beyond TB and reduce vulnerability to a wide range of infectious and non-infectious diseases, making the case for nutrition as a foundational public health infrastructure.

TB is a disease of circumstance as much as infection — that includes what and how much people eat. The commitment to nutritional supplementation during treatment is already on the books; the evidence for prevention is now impossible to ignore. A commentary in *The Lancet* put it aptly: Food is the tuberculosis vaccine we already have.

The writer is professor & in-charge, Tuberculosis Division, Department of Microbiology, AIIMS Delhi

IRAN SAYS IT TARGETED U.S. MILITARY SITES IN BAHRAIN, KUWAIT; VOWS RETALIATION IF ATTACKED AGAIN

After lashing allies, Trump says ‘a lot of unity’ in NATO

Reuters
Ankara, July 8

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump threw a summit of NATO leaders into disarray on Wednesday as he demanded the United States cut trade ties with Spain and made renewed claims on Greenland, but later changed tack and said there had been love and “a lot of unity”.

Speaking in the Turkish capital Ankara, Trump had called Madrid a “terrible partner” in NATO as he railed against allies for not supporting the war on Iran and ordered Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent to halt all trade with Spain.

Trump’s remarks, also declaring the fragile ceasefire with Iran to be over, roiled a summit that European leaders hoped would look past a series of rows that have threatened to tear the military alliance apart.

“Spain is a wasted cause. We don’t want to do any trade business with Spain anymore,” Trump said. “By the way, I’d like to cut it off. Spain is a terrible partner in NATO. They don’t participate, they don’t pay. I don’t want anything to do with Spain. Cut off all trade with Spain, including visits.”

Emerging from a closed-door meeting of NATO leaders, Trump said, “There was a lot of love in that room, a lot of unity.”

He also spoke more warmly of Volodymyr Zelenskyy when he met the Ukrainian president.

Trump says interim accord to end war is ‘over’, warns of new strikes

‘I don’t want to deal with them... They’re scum’

Reuters
Ankara, Dubai, July 8

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump said an interim agreement to end war with Iran was “over” and the United States was likely to launch new strikes on Wednesday night following Iranian attacks on US bases in the Gulf.

In a flare-up of hostilities that pushed up oil prices, Iran said on Wednesday it had targeted US military sites in Bahrain and Kuwait after US forces struck Iranian targets in response to attacks on tankers in the Strait of Hormuz.

The attacks further undermined a shaky ceasefire agreement and dented hopes of turning the memorandum of understanding signed on June 17 into a permanent peace deal to end the war, which began with US-Israeli airstrikes on Iran on February 28. “If we make a deal with Iran I’m not sure that will stick,” Trump said, “because I found them to be very dishonest people.”

But Trump did not explicitly say Washington would return to full-fledged war and it was not immediately clear whether or not the negotiations



US President Donald Trump and NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte hold a bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the NATO leaders summit at Bastepe Presidential Compound in Ankara on Wednesday. AP

on reaching a permanent deal would continue.

Asked before a NATO summit in Turkey whether the memorandum of understanding was over, Trump said: “It’s a very interesting question. To me, I think it’s over. I don’t want to deal with them.”

“They’re scum. They’re sick people. They’re led by sick people,” he told reporters in Ankara. “As far as I’m concerned, it’s just a waste of time dealing with them,” he said, before adding: “Now, I’ll let our wonderful negotiators keep talking if they want, but I don’t see it. I don’t like

these people, you know that.”

A source familiar with the Ankara talks said Trump did not repeat his comments about the interim deal being over when NATO leaders met at the summit, but he later warned of new strikes before a meeting with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

“I’ll give a little warning: We’re going to hit them hard tonight,” Trump told reporters.

The latest attacks have heightened safety and security concerns around the Strait of Hormuz, with shipping data showing at least four oil and gas

tankers had turned back rather than try to transit the waterway, a vital supply route.

Trump has at times stepped back from threats he has made against Iran, but oil prices jumped and global bond markets tumbled. Brent crude futures leapt more than 5%, the most in a day since late May, to \$78.48 a barrel.

While that was far below the peaks above \$120 seen during the height of the fighting, it was enough to inject some fresh inflation risk into the bond market, particularly since months of conflict have drawn down

global oil inventories.

Iran’s Revolutionary Guards (IRGC) said they had targeted US military sites in Bahrain and Kuwait and that they had shot down a US MQ-9 drone attempting to interfere in the operation.

Bahrain’s army later said it had thwarted Iranian attacks.

The US had earlier unleashed new military strikes and revoked a licence allowing Iran to sell oil in response to attacks on three tankers in the strait.

The US Central Command said more than 60 small boats used by the IRGC were among the targets hit in an operation it said was intended to impose a heavy cost on Iran for strikes on shipping in violation of truce. Trump said US had “knocked out 28 boats last night” and would probably hit more later.

He confirmed the U.S. had attacked Iran’s main oil hub of Kharg Island in its latest strikes and, repeating a warning that US forces could take over the island, said: “They may hit it again tonight.”

NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte told reporters before the NATO summit that the new attacks by the US on Iran were “absolutely necessary”.

EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas later said on X the exchanges of fire “complicate already fraught talks to end the war. Iran’s attacks on Bahrain and Kuwait are unacceptable.”

Damaged Qatari LNG tanker awaits salvage as risks in Hormuz Strait rise

Reuters
London, Doha, July 8

A QATARI LNG tanker was still stuck off Oman on Wednesday awaiting salvage operations, shipping data showed, a day after it was hit by a projectile, while the US military said two other tankers had been targeted by Iran in recent days.

At least four oil and gas tankers have turned back from trying to transit the strait, ship-tracking data showed on Wednesday. LNG tankers are among the highest-risk ships in the region due to the high value of the vessels and their cargoes.

Qatari LNG tanker Al Reikayyat, loaded with liquefied natural gas, was hit on its port side overnight on Tuesday, one source said, while another said the vessel was at risk of exploding due to a fire in engine room.

Efforts are continuing to extinguish the fire, an industry source told Reuters. All the crew have been safely evacuated. The LNG stored in the tanker’s tanks remains intact and there is no breach of tanks, the source said.

Another source assessed that as long as the vessel was not subject to any further attack, it was likely to remain in its current state and not explode. “Breaching a main tank would be catastrophic,” the source added.

Two vessels, a tug boat and a separate service ship, are currently near the tanker, which is located near the entrance of the Strait and close to Oman’s coast, the LSEG and MarineTraffic ship tracking data showed.

• BRIEFLY

SPAIN

Cardinal suspends himself after sexual assault allegations



Cardinal Cristobal Lopez Romero. FILE

SPANISH CARDINAL Cristobal Lopez Romero, who is also the Archbishop of Rabat, Morocco, has suspended himself after being accused of molesting women, the Vatican said on its own news site. “I am accused of inappropriate behaviour toward adult women,” Lopez Romero said in a statement published by Vatican News on Tuesday, adding that the situation had prompted the Catholic Church to open a preliminary investigation. REUTERS

UGANDA

14 dead, 28 hurt after bus collides with truck

AT LEAST 14 people have died and 28 others were injured after a bus collided with a truck in Uganda, police said on Wednesday. The incident happened late Tuesday along a highway in Gulu city, police said. “Preliminary reports indicate that the driver of the bus, who was allegedly speeding, attempted to avoid a pedestrian crossing the road lost control and collided head-on with the oncoming trailer,” police said. AP

CONGO

Health workers strike over pay as toll near 600

THE HEALTHCARE workers at the epicenter of Congo’s Ebola outbreak are walking off their jobs to protest delays in their payments, threatening efforts to slow the outbreak that officials said continues to spread faster than the response. The latest government data shows 1,708 recorded cases, including 580 deaths, and that the first month of this Ebola outbreak was already the worst on record, health authorities said. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

BANGLADESH

8 children killed in landslide at refugee camp

HEAVY MONSOON rains triggered a landslide at a madrasa in a Rohingya refugee camp in southeastern Bangladesh on Wednesday, killing eight children and injuring five others, officials said. The landslide buried the madrasa under mud and debris after days of heavy rain. Rescuers recovered 13 children from the madrasa, eight of whom died, while the rest were admitted to hospitals for treatment. REUTERS

SRI LANKA

New prison planned after riot leaves 28 dead

SRI LANKA has initiated steps to establish a new prison complex at an abandoned hospital near the southern port city of Galle following a two-day riot at the Negombo prison that left 28 people dead, officials said on Wednesday. The violence at the Negombo prison on July 5 and 6 that killed 28 people, including eight prison officials, was triggered by a dispute between rival groups of inmates over drugs. PTI

Cargo plane wreckage found off Karachi coast, search on for crew

Associated Press
Karachi, July 8

CIVILIAN AND navy searchers off Pakistan’s coast Wednesday located and recovered wreckage of a cargo plane that disappeared while approaching the southern port of Karachi while the search continues for five missing crew members, officials said.

The aircraft operated by the private carrier K2 Airways had departed from Sharjah in the United Arab Emirates and reported a navigational system problem before losing contact with air traffic control Tuesday.

The Pakistani navy and civilian teams in planes and ships found the plane debris after about 12 hours of searching in the Arabian Sea, Pakistan’s Airports Authority said in a post on X.

Retired Rear Adm. Faisal Shah said searchers were dealing with rough seas and that they were still looking for the main wreckage of the plane, which could prove much more



Pakistan Navy personnel recover the wreckage of K2 Airways cargo plane in the Arabian Sea. AP

difficult to find because the area is believed to be about 3,000 meters deep, requiring specialized equipment.

In a statement, K2 Airways identified the missing crew as Capt. Muhammad Rizwan Idris, First Officer Faisal Jatoti, flight engineers Muhammad Hamid and Muhammad Arif Siddiqui, and aircraft loader Muhammad Taufiq Khan. “We continue to pray earnestly for the safety of our colleagues,” it said.

• WHILE FANS FOCUS ON PLAYERS CHASING GOALS, REFEREES ARE SPRINTING JUST AS HARD, COVERING 12 TO 13 KMs PER MATCH ACCORDING TO FIFA — A DISTANCE COMPARABLE TO MANY OUTFIELD PLAYERS

World Cup’s hidden runners: How referees keep pace with players and pressure

Lori Ewing
Kansas City, July 8

WHEN A World Cup match turns on a split-second decision in the dying moments, the referee is expected to be in the right place at the right time — no small ask when battling everything from Miami humidity to Mexico City’s lung-busting altitude.

While fans focus on players chasing goals, referees are sprinting just as hard, typically covering 12 to 13 kilometres per match according to FIFA — a distance comparable to many outfield players.

That reality has transformed how football’s governing body

prepares officials for the sport’s biggest stage. “Referee preparation for the 2026 World Cup began almost four years ago,” FIFA told Reuters.

The build-up has resembled that of elite athletes. Officials have undergone repeated physical assessments, with training ramping up sharply in the six months before the tournament.

The challenge extends far beyond distance. A referee may spend one match battling humidity in Miami and another chasing play at more than 2,200 metres above sea level in Mexico City, with long flights, changing time zones and unforgiving temperatures creating demands that resemble an endurance event.

FIFA said lessons from the 2025 Club World Cup in the US proved invaluable in preparing officials for “heat, humidity and also different time zones”.

Officials train endurance, strength, speed, agility and acceleration, often through game-like simulations while performance experts scrutinise every sprint, heartbeat and recovery cycle. The objective is simple: arrive at every decisive moment before the controversy does.

Research has linked fatigue to poorer positioning, narrower viewing angles and slower reactions — all ingredients for the kind of mistake that can live forever in World Cup folklore.

That is why FIFA now treats



Referee Francois Letexier (center) and his assistants warm up before the match between Argentina and Egypt in Atlanta, on Tuesday. AP

referees much like players.

The World Cup officiating team consists of 52 referees, 88 assistant referees and 30 video

match officials from 50 member associations.

Based in Miami, they live in an environment built around

training, nutrition, recovery and technical preparation, with 12 medical specialists and 10 physiotherapists, plus a chef trained in sports nutrition.

GPS devices monitor workload, heart-rate sensors gauge exertion and blood-lactate testing helps staff determine how the body is coping. Training loads are then adjusted with scientific precision. “We use data trackers at the same level as players,” FIFA said.

The three days prior to matches feature simulated match sessions, along with short, explosive acceleration and speed work.

Afterwards, recovery takes centre stage. “(The two days fol-

lowing games) are dedicated to active recovery training, along with massages and cryotherapy, which help achieve a faster and more effective recovery,” FIFA said.

FIFA has also introduced hydration supplements and redesigned training schedules to limit exposure to direct sunlight.

The demands are easy to miss because referees rarely feature on highlight reels. Yet studies have found that high-intensity running can account for more than a third of their movement during elite matches, with heart rates often climbing to between 80% and 100% of maximum levels.

All the while, officials are

tracking player movements, spotting potential fouls, anticipating tactical patterns and hunting for the best possible viewing angle — often at full sprint.

In the US 2-0 victory over Australian in the group stage, German referee Felix Zwayer collapsed with cramping in stoppage time, requiring players from both teams plus an assistant referee to help stretch his leg so he could finish the match.

As the tournament’s quarter-finals approach, the spotlight remains on players — but behind every defining moment is a referee racing to keep pace, knowing one whistle can change everything. REUTERS

REVAMPED SYSTEM TO ENABLE CENTRALISED DATABASE MERGING DATA FROM REGIONAL CENTRES

New EPFO portal to automate interest credit, streamline claims

Ravi Dutta Mishra & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 8

THE EMPLOYEES’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) has launched a revamped portal with a centralised database by merging information across all regional offices. The portal enables automated processes, including crediting of interest, claim verification and informing members about the amount they are eligible to withdraw, aimed at reducing claim rejection rates.

Labour and Employment Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Wednesday said the interest of Rs 1.44 lakh crore for financial year 2025-26 will be auto-processed on the new portal and verified by field authorities before being credited to 34 crore EPF accounts by July 15.

“Field verification is currently ongoing to ensure that any account does not receive incorrect interest. After the process is over, over 34 crore EPF accounts will receive interest worth over Rs 1.44 lakh crore by July 15. Earlier, interest credit used to happen in October or November after the rates were

announced,” Mandavyya said at a press briefing.

This comes after the Ministry of Labour and Employment implemented the CITES (Centralised IT Enabled Services) project, an initiative to modernise EPFO’s service delivery through automation and rule-based processing. The ministry said the project is designed to improve EPFO’s operational efficiency.

“Before CITES, EPFO had a decentralised architecture with separate databases at each field office. CITES has now enabled a single centralised architecture with one national database. EPFO has completed the process of migrating its entire database of member records to the new centralised database. Earlier, the services were tied to a particular regional office. Now, a member’s service request can be processed from any authorised location across the country,” Mandavyya said.

This centralised database will be helpful for employees who move across cities during their employment. For instance, if an employee has worked in Chennai and moves back to their hometown in West Bengal,

• SMART PROCESSING

THE INTEREST of Rs 1.44 lakh crore for FY2025-26 will be auto-processed on the new portal and verified by field authorities before being credited to 34 crore EPF accounts by July 15.

THE CENTRALISED database will be helpful for employees who move across cities during their employment.

THE PORTAL will show the eligible amount for withdrawals to members under the different claim categories. Member claims



will undergo automated pre-validation before processing at EPFO offices, and any deficiencies or discrepancies will be identified and communicated to members through SMS and the portal.

they will be able to access their records and resolve any issues at the EPFO office in West Bengal instead of travelling to the Chennai regional office.

The ministry said claim payments will be processed through a centralised payment architecture and routed through faster electronic payment channels, ensuring secure, efficient and timely credit of settlement amounts directly into members’ bank accounts on the day of settlement.

“Under the revised system, interest on final PF settlements will now be calculated up to the date of payment authorisation. Earlier, interest was calculated only up to the last day of the previous month. This ensures that members receive the benefit of additional interest for the intervening period,” a statement said. The EPFO’s Central Board of Trustees had recommended an interest rate of 8.25% for financial year 2025-26 in March, which was ratified by the Ministry of Finance last month.

istry of Finance last month.

In the new portal, members will be able to view their membership details, provident fund balances, claim status, pensionable service records and benefits availed. This, the ministry said, will ensure transparency and provide access to information about their PF accounts and claim submissions. “Earlier, members’ information was not available on a unified portal and remained scattered across different systems,” the ministry said.

Member claims will undergo automated pre-validation before processing at EPFO offices, and any deficiencies or discrepancies will be identified upfront and communicated to members through SMS and the portal, helping reduce claim rejections and improve first-time acceptance rates. “Members will also be able to know what the eligible amount is, which they can apply for withdrawal from their PF account under the different types of withdrawals permitted and can make informed choices,” the statement said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

SENSEX CRASHES BY 1,680 POINTS

Markets sink over 2% as Trump says Iran truce deal ‘over’

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 8

THE INDIAN stock markets fell over 2% on Wednesday after US President Donald Trump said that the peace deal with Iran was “over”, erasing around Rs 10 lakh crore in market capitalisation.

It comes on the back of stock markets registering 2.4% gain over the last week due to the hope generated by the peace deal in the West Asia region.

The fresh escalation pushed crude oil prices by 6% to \$79-\$80 a barrel. The rupee too weakened by 59 paise against the dollar, ending the session at 95.56. Meanwhile, yields on the 10-year benchmark government bond hit a 3-week high as higher crude prices escalated inflationary fears, which may lead to the central bank raising interest rates.

The Sensex index closed the session down 1,677.12 points or 2.2% at 76,503.60. The National Stock Exchange’s benchmark Nifty 50 index lost 2.1% to end at 23,882.05. Both indices had opened the session around 1% lower but fell sharply more in afternoon trade after Trump’s announcement.

“Indian equities are expected to remain volatile in the near term as global risk sentiment has deteriorated following US President Donald Trump’s comments on ending the ceasefire with Iran and withdrawing from the MoU,” said Siddharth Khemka, head of research for wealth management at Motilal Oswal. The situation in West Asia escalated after Iranian authorities attacked three commercial tankers in the Strait of Hormuz overnight. This led to

Iran and the US trading blows before Trump announced on Wednesday morning that the interim peace deal between the two countries signed in Islamabad last month was over.

“To me, I think it’s over. I don’t want to deal with them. As far as I’m concerned, it’s just a waste of time dealing with them,” *Reuters* reported Trump as saying in Ankara, Turkey.

Some stability in West Asia post the peace pact had led to a recovery in Indian markets, with early signs of foreign investors returning to the capital markets.

Following a \$5.2 billion sell-off by foreign institutional investors (FIIs) in the Indian stock markets last month, they had bought \$401 million in shares so far this month as of Tuesday. However, they are expected to have heavily sold during the sell-off on Wednesday.

A host of sectors such as banking and financial services, FMCG, automobiles, and oil and gas lost over 2%. The India VIX index, which indicates market volatility, skyrocketed 26% to 14.68. Investors now await earnings for the first quarter of FY27, which will be kick-started by TCS’ results on Thursday. Experts expect earnings growth to remain soft due to high crude prices and geopolitical uncertainties that persisted during the quarter. “On an overall basis, we expect net income of the KIE (Kotak) universe to decline 8.7% yoy in 1QFY27 due to a sharp decline in the profits of OMCs from marketing and inventory losses amid crude price volatility,” a report by Kotak said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

IMF lowers global growth forecast to 3%, India’s to 6.4%

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 8

THE INTERNATIONAL Monetary Fund (IMF) on Wednesday lowered its global growth forecast for 2026 by a marginal 10 basis points (bps) to 3% on the assumption that the Strait of Hormuz begins re-opening in mid-July and the situation broadly returns to prewar state by March 2027 — even as US President Donald Trump said he thinks the ceasefire with Iran is over.

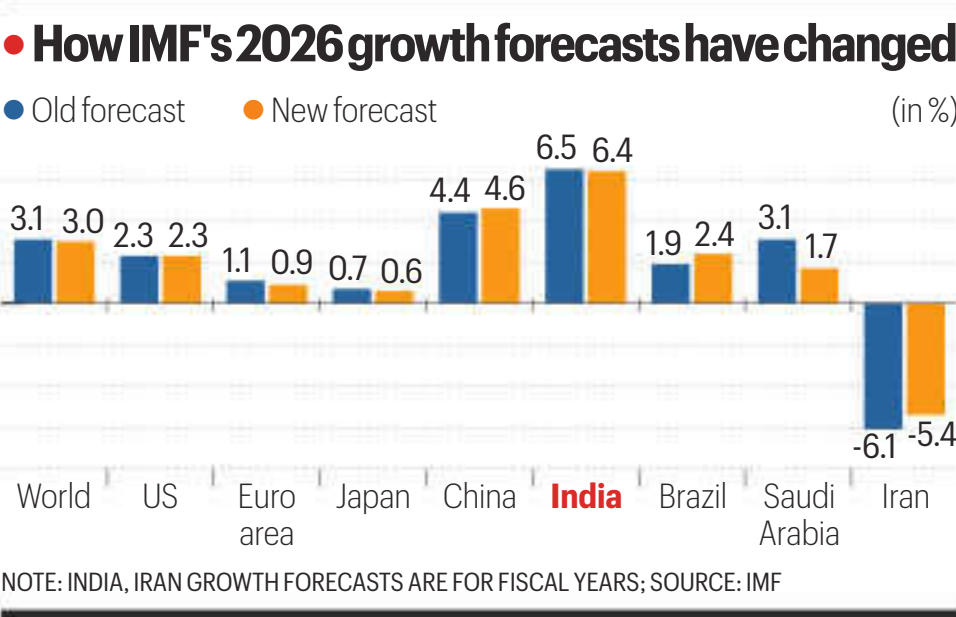
On Wednesday, Trump said the ceasefire was a “just a waste of time”. Hours earlier, the US hit over 80 Iranian military targets after merchant ships were attacked in the Strait of Hormuz, with Washington also revoking a license that authorized the sale of Iranian oil.

While released on Wednesday at 6:30pm India time, the IMF’s economic projections were prepared earlier.

“The most imminent risk to the baseline forecast stems from developments in the Middle East,” the IMF said in a quarterly update to its World Economic Outlook report.

“Renewed conflict would propagate through a further increase in commodity prices and extended volatility, supply shortages, and exchange rate pressures. The muted increase in oil prices and their contained impact on activity owe to the release of inventories, which are now getting closer to multi-year lows and could reach stress levels should supply disruptions persist or hoarding gather steam,” the multilateral agency added.

The tentative ceasefire helped placate markets across the world after the start of the conflict on February 27 led to a sharp rise in global energy prices



NOTE: INDIA, IRAN GROWTH FORECASTS ARE FOR FISCAL YEARS; SOURCE: IMF

following the closure of the key waterway, Strait of Hormuz. The price of India’s crude oil basket, which had surged 66% from February to \$114.48 per barrel in April, has cooled sharply to \$68.62 so far in July, according to petroleum ministry data.

However, the renewal of hostilities by the US has already begun to weigh heavy on financial markets and investors, with benchmark Indian equity indices slumping more than 2% on Wednesday. In line with the trimming of the global growth forecast, the IMF on Wednesday slightly lowered its projection for India’s GDP growth in 2026-27 — also by 10 bps — to 6.4%. This is lower than the Reserve Bank of India’s forecast of 6.6%.

“India remains among the fastest growing major economies, with growth projected at 6.4%, supported by strong momentum in private consumption and services activity,” the agency said, even as it raised the forecast for 2027-28 by 20 bps from April to 6.7%. In calendar year 2026, the IMF sees India’s GDP growing 7%, before cooling to 6.4% in 2027.

China, meanwhile, got a 20-bps bump-up to 4.6% for 2026 and 10 bps for 2027 to 4.1%. Brazil, meanwhile, is seen growing half-a-percentage point faster

than previously thought this year at 2.4%. In the West Asia region, the IMF expects Saudi Arabia’s economy to expand by 1.7% in 2026, down from its forecast of 3.1% in April.

“Iraq, Kuwait, and Qatar — commodity producers most affected by disruptions to energy output and transport — are projected to experience sharp contractions of their economies in 2026, followed by double-digit expansions in 2027.”

Iran’s economy is expected to shrink by 5.4% in its 2026 fiscal year.

According to the IMF, the world economy has, so far, weathered the shock from the US-Israel-Iran war “better than feared”. Global growth is seen slowing only modestly from 3.5% in 2024-2025 due to the hit from the conflict being “partly offset by accelerated demand-driven momentum in the global technology cycle thanks to advances in artificial intelligence (AI) and its adoption”.

Commodity prices, however, remain elevated, the IMF said, with energy prices around 25% higher than prewar levels. This, along with higher inflation numbers, have raised inflation expectations.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Hormuz flare-up exposes fragility of US-Iran MoU, keeps oil market on edge

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 8

WITH A few energy tankers coming under attack near the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, cracks have appeared in the fragile ceasefire that took effect about three weeks ago with the signing of the US-Iran MoU. The US responded to the Iranian attacks on the tankers by striking over 80 Iranian military targets, including air defence systems, command and control networks, coastal radar sites, anti-ship missile capabilities, and more than 60 Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) small boats. Iran then claimed that it launched retaliatory strikes against US assets in countries like Bahrain and Kuwait.

The global energy market, which had just started to breathe easy over the past few weeks as maritime traffic via the Strait of Hormuz showed clear signs of recovery, is on the edge again. Oil prices shot up amid the renewed tensions. As of Wednesday evening, Brent futures were nearing \$80 per barrel, up over 7%. The stress is understandable, as the West Asia war and the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which usually sees the transit of a fifth of global oil and LNG flows, led to one of the worst energy supply crises ever.

Will the recent flare-up be contained, or will it again expand into a wider conflict, and what will be the fate of oil and gas flows through the Strait of Hormuz — these are the key questions on everyone’s mind. How the situation evolves hereon will be a major factor in the oil price trajectory; prices had touched multi-year highs of well over \$100 per barrel amid the supply disruption. The crisis was particularly trying for large Asian importers of energy, in-

• STRAIT TENSIONS

BRENT FUTURES rose to \$78 per barrel, up nearly 6%, on Wednesday afternoon.

THE US has revoked its sanctions waiver for Iranian oil, which would effectively make Tehran’s crude unpalatable for most of the world, except for perhaps China.

cluding India, as a bulk of the oil and gas flows that transit the strait are consumed by Asian economies.

Meanwhile, US President Donald Trump said that he thinks that the US-Iran MoU is “over”, even as peace talks between Washington and Tehran continue. The US has also revoked its sanctions waiver for Iranian oil, which would effectively make Tehran’s crude unpalatable for most of the world, except for perhaps China — a regular buyer of Iranian oil. While it may be too early to expect definitive answers to these questions, industry insiders and experts expect both the US as well as Iran to de-escalate and

avoid a return to the full-scale confrontation.

“Despite this being the worst exchange of fire between the US and Iran since the June 17 MoU and Trump’s subsequent claims, the tentative ceasefire might still hold. Neither country would want to go back to full-scale conflict. Iran’s targeting of the three ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz was perhaps to try to force vessels to use its new designated route. The strikes on Iranian coastal positions by the US were a warning of sorts. Iran’s response, though, of loosening fire at Bahrain and Kuwait could signal that Tehran is willing to push the envelope more and embroil the region in tur-

• BRIEFLY

Meta’s new Muse AI sparks privacy concerns

New Delhi: Meta has announced the launch of Muse Image, touted as its most advanced AI image generator and the first media generation model by Meta Superintelligence Labs, but the move drew criticism and user concerns around data privacy, image-scraping and consent. Worry lines have started to emerge over a feature that allows users to create AI images by clawing photos from public Instagram accounts. PTI

• MARKETS

 Sensex 76,503.60 -1,677.12 -2.15%	 NIFTY 23,882.05 -516.65 -2.12%	 Gold ▼ ₹1,42,350	 US Dollar ▲ ₹95.56
		 Silver ▼ ₹2,21,550	 Oil ▲ \$70.76

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION & JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 7, 2026

moil again,” an international energy and shipping expert told *The Indian Express*.

All eyes on Hormuz

The critical maritime choke-point of the Strait of Hormuz lies at the centre of the latest flare-up, as well as the resurfaced worries around the trade flows. The critical energy trade artery had been free for navigation prior to the war that began late February, but since then, Iran has been claiming sovereignty over parts of the narrow waterway between the country and Oman. During the war, Iran actively regulated the flow of vessels through the strait, allowing only a handful to pass, that too using routings dictated by it.

Following the June MoU with the US, Iran continues to insist that vessels should cross the strait only through the routings designated by it, and that too after seeking its permission. Tehran also plans to impose a service fee for transits, but at a later date. Iranian state television reported that the ships that came under attack on Tuesday were sailing outside the shipping lanes authorised by Tehran.

On the other hand, the US and its allies have been encouraging vessels to use the strait’s waters hugging Oman as an alternative to Tehran-designated lanes. The stark differences in the MoU’s interpretation and the vagueness in its terms have now emerged as the flashpoints in the uneasy ceasefire, as per market watchers.

“At the heart of the matter is that the MoU between the US and Iran included provisions aimed at reopening the Strait of Hormuz to commercial shipping, but it left important details on control and traffic management deliberately ambiguous,” Tony Sycamore, market analyst at IG Australia, said in note.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Maruti installs 1 MWh battery energy storage

Kharkhoda/New Delhi: Maruti Suzuki India has commissioned a 1 MWh battery energy storage system at its Kharkhoda manufacturing plant, the firm announced on Wednesday. During facility holidays, the solar power plant continues to generate electricity, but it cannot be utilised. A battery energy storage system addresses this challenge by storing excess electricity generated during low-demand periods or facility holidays. ENS

• DELINQUENCIES IN 180 DAYS-PAST-DUE CATEGORY HAS RISEN TO 8.1% FROM 5.8% FOUR YEARS AGO

Credit card boom accompanied by delinquencies, borrower stress: CIBIL

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 8

INDIA’S DECADE-LONG credit card boom is beginning to enter a more challenging phase. As millions of consumers embrace easy access to unsecured credit, rising delinquencies, increased borrowing across multiple loan products and emerging “pockets of stress” are pointing to evolving challenges for lenders and borrowers alike, according to a TransUnion CIBIL report.

While the industry has celebrated a sharp rise in credit card issuances — from 1.4 crore to 5.2 crore in ten years — and spending, the report says consumers are likely to hold multiple credit

cards and multiple unsecured products in their wallet, creating “distinct growth and risk opportunities for card issuers to manage effectively”.

This is at a time when consumers juggle multiple card and credit products and younger borrowers enter the market with more aggressive borrowing habits. Outstanding credit card balances have surged more than eight-fold over the past decade to Rs 3.1 lakh crore, but the rapid expansion has also coincided with a deterioration in asset quality since 2022.

RISING DELINQUENCIES

After a period of improving repayment behaviour before the pandemic (2016 to 2020), delin-



CIBIL said the share of consumers with three or more cards in their wallet has increased from 12% to 22%. REUTERS

quency levels have begun rising again. “Since 2022, as growth resumed, the system witnessed a rise in delinquencies alongside

stabilisation in balances, indicating ‘pockets of stress’ emerging within a rapidly expanding unsecured ecosystem,” said CIBIL,

a credit information company registered with the RBI, in its white paper on credit cards.

Delinquency level in 180 dpd (days past due) category since 2022 has gone up from 5.8% to 8.1% in March 2026.

A significant shift is that credit cards no longer operate in isolation. “Cards are now part of a broader unsecured credit landscape. The share of open credit cards within unsecured credit products has declined over time, from 56% in 2016 to 38% in 2026,” said CIBIL.

Card issuers are now “increasingly competing with small-ticket personal loans — loans below Rs 50,000 — and consumer durable loans for life-

style financing by consumers.”

Consumers are increasingly using several credit products simultaneously rather than relying primarily on credit cards.

“Credit card consumers are more likely to hold multiple credit cards and multiple unsecured products in their wallet as compared to the last decade. The share of consumers holding other consumption-led credit in their wallet has doubled from 16% to 32% in the last decade,” CIBIL said. It said the share of consumers with three or more cards in their wallet has increased from 12% to 22% during the same period. This growing overlap of products creates competing repayment obligations

and makes it harder for lenders to assess borrower risk using a single product in isolation.

HIGH EXPOSURE USERS

Another worry is the emergence of “high exposure users,” who account for around 10% of cardholders. High exposure users are known for high utilisation, use multiple unsecured credit products and have higher exposure to risk across wallets, it said. Consumers in this segment who missed two or more repayments across products were substantially more likely to become seriously delinquent on their credit cards than other customer groups. Delinquency worsens as highly leveraged borrowers gain more credit experience.

“Diversified credit users with 4 plus years of card experience have 40 to 60 bps higher delinquencies than the overall delinquency for the persona,” CIBIL said. Borrowers with multiple personal loans accumulated over recent years are particularly vulnerable.

“22% of consumers with 4 years plus card experience have opened more than three personal loans in the last 24 months and have delinquency of 8.7%,” CIBIL said. Meanwhile, Gen Z consumers opened new unsecured loans post first card at a higher rate compared to millennials (those born between 1980 and 1994), it said. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

epaper.indianexpress.com

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I,**Kashish Zaidi, W/O**-Shadab Mohd Abidi, R/O-77,kh no.132,3rd floor Gali no.9,near Hanuman-Chowk Wazirabad-village north-Delhi,110084,have changed my name to Kashish for all purposes. 0040864843-3

I,**Jyotsna Wankhede W/o**-Milind Mahadu Dongardive R/o-C2/201, Housing Block, South Asian University, Rajpur Road, Maidan Garhi, New Delhi-110068 have changed my name to Jyotsna M Dongardive for all purpose. 0040864795-1

I,**KUNTI DEVI, W/o**-Late Narinder Kumar Jauhar, R/o/A-225,Meera-Bagh New-Delhi-110087, have changed my name to KUNTI DEVI JOHAR (Both- names belong to one and same-person i.e.myself) 0040864827-9

I,**hitherto** known as Ankush Malhotra, S/O-Vinod Kumar Malhotra R/O,160,Block-A,Shastri Nagar,North West Delhi,Delhi-110052,have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Ankussh Kaushal. 0040864825-3

I, **Mandeep Kaur Nanda W/o** Surinder Pal Singh Nanda R/o-C3207, Greenfield Colony, NHPG Colony, Faridabad have changed my name to Mandeep Kaur. 0071046423-1

I,**Mihir S/o**-Raj Singh, R/o-1920, Gali Ahiran, Malka Ganj, Delhi-7, declares that I,Mihir also known as Meer and both the names belongs to me. In future I will use my name as MIHIR for all purpose. 0040864765-1

I,**RAVI KUMAR JAISAWAL,S/O** LALLAN KUMAR JAISAWAL,R/O A-7/35 S/F SECTOR-16 ROHINI DELHI-110089,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAVI KUMAR JAISWAL. 0040864827-2

I, **Shiban Krishna Raina S/O** Prem Nath Raina R/O Flat No 8-B, GH-10, Hydell Apartment Sec-46, Faridabad, Haryana 121001 have changed my name to Shiban Krishen Raina 0040864824-7

I,**Mohammad Yasseen** (DOB-02-07-1953) S/o Mustak R/O-H.No.X-36,X-Block, Seelampur-3, Bhajanpura,North-East Delhi-110053,have changed my name to Mohd.Yaseen (DOB-01-01-1951) for all purposes. 0040864832-8

I,**Hitherto** Known as Yachna,W/O-Raj Kumar,R/O H.No-262, Sector-14,Rohatk, Haryana-124001, Have Changed My Name and Shall Hereafter Be Known as Yachna Kaushik Jaiwal. 0040864827-11

I,**PARVEEN KUMAR GARG,S/O** Janashwar Prashad,R/O H.No.E-233 Vijay Nagar, Sector-9 Ghaziabad U/P.201001,Have changed my name to PRAVEEN KUMAR GARG 0040864832-1

I, **Abdul Kalam S/o** 41/2, gafoor Nagar, Okhla, New friends Colony, Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Abul Kalam for all future Purposes. 0071046427-1

I, **Tincy Kaur W/o** Gaurav Gilbert Pinto, R/O 10 E, Block-K, Malviya Nagar, South Saket, NCT of Delhi-110017, have changed my name to Tincy Pinto. 0071046449-1

I,**Tania Bhatia, D/o**-Rajesh Kumar Bhatia, R/O-A/1,Vasant Vihar,New Delhi-110057,have changed my name to Tania Nijhawani,after marriage. Henceforth, I shall be known as Tania Nijhawan, for all future purposes. 0040864827-4

I,**ASHA DEVI, W/o** Sh.PARVEEN KUMAR,R/O L-130,OLD RANGPUR ROAD,OPPOSITE STREET.No.12,NEAR EASY DAY,MAHIPALPUR,SOUTH WEST DELHI,DELHI-110037, have changed my name from ASHA DEVI to ASHA SHARMA, for all,future purposes.My correct date-of-birth is 06/03/1969. 0040864824-9

I **Vivek Kumar S/o** Dhruva Kumar Sadrh R/O 14A/84, W.E.A. Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005 have Changed my name from Vivek Kumar to Vivekanand Sadrh. Hence further I would be known by the Name of Vivekanand Sadrh for all future purposes. 0071046383-1

I,**PURNAKAMA PRABUDDHA PUDGAL,S/O**-SHEO KUMAR SHARMA,R/O-Flat No.A-1, Plot No.34, Sec-2A,Vaishali, Ghaziabad(UP)-201010, declare that my name is mentioned as P.P.PUDGAL in my DL No.UP14-20160017332 issued from RTO Ghaziabad.That the actual name of mine is PURNAKAMA PRABUDDHA PUDGAL,which may be amended accordingly. 0040864832-10

I, **Sandeep Kumar S/O** . Ashok Kumar Deo R/O. Tata New Haven Tower-12, Flat No. 303, Jhajar Road, Sector-37, Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana have changed my name to Sandeep Kumar Deo 0040864827-1

I,**VAIBHAV VATS,S/O**-RAJEEV KUMAR,R/O-FLAT.No.E-1903, SECTOR-1, APEX GOLF-AVENUE, SPORTS CITY, GREATER-NOIDA WEST, GAUTAM BUDDHA-NAGAR,UTTAR PRADESH-201009,have changed my name to VAIBHAV SINHA for all,purposes. 0040864824-6

I,**Mohit Jaidev Khatri S/O** Late Shri Jaidev Khatri R/O 5 Block,H.No.122,Second floor,Subhash Nagar,Delhi-110027,have changed my name to Mohit Khatri. 0040864825-1

I, **Satya Arya S/O** Narendra Kumar Arora R/O 1103, Gold Palm A, Omaxe Palm Greens Sector Mu, Noida Gautam Budh Nagar, UP hereby declare that Narendra Kumar Arora and NK Arya are one and the same person for all purposes. 0071046395-1

I **Rishit S/o** Sh. Vikas Kumar R/o 503, Rosewood Apartment, Sector-13A, DDA MIG Flats, Dwarka, New Delhi-110078 have changed my name to Rishit Dhiman for all purposes. 0040864714-5

I, **Munnawar Begum, W/o**- Abdul Salim, R/o- 3113, Shri Sayyed Ahmed Road, Darya Ganj, Delhi-110002, have changed my name to Munnawar permanently. 0040864832-3

I, **Tara Shnakr Gupta, S/o** Jamuna Prasad Gupta R/o Flat No. A 1401, ACE Platinum Apartment, Sector Zeta-1, Geater Noida, District G.B Nagar U.P. have changed my daughter name from ANANYA GUPTA to ANANYA SHANKAR GUPTA for all future purposes. 0071046444-1

I,**Aijaz Ul Haque, S/o**-Ziaul Haque,R/o-2204,Gali Dakotan Turkman Gate,Delhi-110006,have changed my name to Mohd Aijaz Ul Haque,for all future purposes. 0040864827-6

I, **Km Rekha W/o** Narendra Singh Bisht, R/o W No.6 Kaladhungi, Nainital, have changed my name to Rekha Bisht 0050292769-1

I,**No 13774910P Rank-Hav** Clk(DS) Name-Bhosale Anil Dattatray,Unit-AGI Dte,IHQ of Mod(Army) Camp/Vill & Post Office-Devadi,Teh-Mohol, Distt-Solapur-413324(Maharashtra),inform that in my.service records my,dauhter's name Payal Bhosale wrongly-written instead of correct name of my daughter's Payal Anil Bhosale amendment accordingly. 0040864824-11

I, **Shilpi Pandey W/o** Vishal Pandey R/o Flat No-B-504, Tower-B, Irish Pearl, Sector-1, Greater Noida West, UP-201318, have changed my name to SHILPI SHUKLA for all future purposes. 0071046385-1

I, **NIKHAT NASREEN W/o** Mohd Umar, C-17/E, Block-C, Okhla Vihar, Jamia Nagar, Delhi-25 have changed my name to NIKHAT NASRIN. 0071046441-1

I,**Sarla Samer Singh, D/o**-Raghbhir Singh,W/o Samer Singh,R/o H.No.2053-A,4th Floor, Block-C,Vyapar Kendra, Sushant-Lok Phase-1,Gurugram,Haryana-122009,have changed my name to Sarla Samersingh. 0040864824-4

I **Priyanka W/o** Shri Arpeet Rai R/o H.No.1916/A, Street Ahiran, Malka Ganj, Delhi-110077 have changed my name to Priyanka Rai for all purposes. 0040864714-7

I,**Asmati Khatoon, W/o** Mohammad Hira,R/O-VIII, Patnauna, P.O.Parohi, PS Bisfi, Madhubani, Bihar-847122, declare- that Asmati Khatoon and Ismat Khatun are one and same person name and belong to me. 0040864832-5

I, **Krishan Kishor R/o**-101, Opp. Malviya nagar, Begumpur, Delhi-110017 have changed my daughter name from Pearl to Pearl Kishor. 0071046431-1

I,**H K TANEJA S/O**-VED PRAKASH TANEJA, R/O B-3/72 SECTOR-16 ROHINI DELHI 110089, have changed my name to HEMANT KUMAR TANEJA. 0040864843-2

I, **Sweta Kumari W/o** Sandeep Kumar Deo R/o. Tata New Haven Tower-12, Flat No.303, Jhajar Road, Sector-37, Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana have changed my name to Shweta Deo 0040864773-1

I, **Lata Singh W/o** Krishan Pal R/o 10-B/93, Kh.No.225,Shiv Mandir,Gali No.10,Maujpur, Delhi-110053 have changed my name to Lata. 0040864827-8

I, **Sumaira Begum W/o** Mr. Vaseem Mirza, R/o 336, Third Floor, Street-20, Zakir Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Sumera Begum. 0071046382-1

I,**Shivam Pratap Singh S/O**,Gyanendra Pal Singh R/O A-1/L,GF,Alok Kunj, Sector-15,Rohini,Delhi-110089,have Changed my minor daughter name from Pukka to Prisha Singh. 0040864825-2

I, **Ashraf S/o** Matiullah R/o 180/B-14, HIMGIRI APARTMENT, SECTOR-34 NOIDA UP, have changed my name to Mohd Ashraf for all future Purposes 0071046420-1

I, **Tara Shnakr Gupta, S/o** Jamuna Prasad Gupta R/o Flat No. A 1401, ACE Platinum Apartment, Sector Zeta-1, Geater Noida, District G.B Nagar U.P. have changed my daughter name from ANUSHKA GUPTA to ANUSHKA SHANKAR GUPTA for all future purposes. 0071046445-1

I,**RAJINDER SONI,S/O** OM PRAKASH SONI,R/O B-2/39 SHIV MAIN MARKET VIJAY ENCLAVE,DELHI-110045,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAJENDER PRASAD SONI. 0040864827-1

I,**VAIBHAV VATS,S/O**-RAJEEV KUMAR,R/O-FLAT.No.E-1903, SECTOR-1, APEX GOLF-AVENUE, SPORTS CITY, GREATER-NOIDA WEST, GAUTAM BUDDHA-NAGAR,UTTAR PRADESH-201009,have changed my name to VAIBHAV SINHA for all,purposes. 0040864824-6

I,**Mohit Jaidev Khatri S/O** Late Shri Jaidev Khatri R/O 5 Block,H.No.122,Second floor,Subhash Nagar,Delhi-110027,have changed my name to Mohit Khatri. 0040864825-1

I, **Zeenat Gulzar Bhat D/o** Ali Mohammad Chilloo, G-5/14, 1st-Floor, Malviya Nagar, Delhi-17 have changed my name to Zeenat Ali. 0071046442-1

I,**SEEMA JOSHI,W/O**-DEEPAK SHARMA,R/o-Plot.No.79, Sector-1,Vaishali, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201010,have changed my name from SEEMA JOSHI to SEEMA SHARMA,Henceforth I would be known by the name SEEMA SHARMA,for all future purposes. 0040864832-7

I,**Gulo Begum,W/O**-Jabbar Ali,R/O C-160,street no.7,Raza masjid chauhani Bangar seelampur north-east delhi,110053,have changed my name to Gullo,for all purposes 0040864843-4

I **Milind Dongardive S/o**-Mahadu Bhikaji Dongardive R/o-C2/201, Housing Block, South Asian University, Rajpur Road, Maidan Garhi, New Delhi-110068 have changed my name to Milind Mahadu Dongardive for all purpose. 0040864797-1

I,**MOON MOON DUTTA MAZUMDAR**,wife of,Arun Dutta mazumdar, presently,residing at,village-chaliha gaon,P.O-chaliha,Dist-Jorhat, Assam-785004,have changed my name,from MOON MOON DUTTA MAZUMDAR to MOON MOON SAKIA,vide-Affidavit date-08/07/2026. 0040864827-10

I,**No-12984743L,NK** Surjeet Singh Low,R/O-Chandsuma Kanispora, Tehsil/District-Baramulla. In my service records the name of my daughter has been wrongly mentioned as Novjot Kaur instead of Novjot Kour as mentioned in education certificates. It needs correction. Objections to be filled 163 INF BN TA (H&H) Sikhli within seven days. 0020516233-1

I, **Parvez Ahmad S/o** Mohammad Atiq Ullah R/o-175, Gali-1/2, Sadarpur, Sector-45, Noida, G.B.Nagar have changed my name to Parvez Ahmad Siddiqui. 0071046424-1

I,**SIMRAN KAUR,W/O**-GURUBACHAN SINGH,R/O-HNO-5,UPPER FIRST-FLOOR FRONT-SIDE BHARAT-VIHAR BLOCK-B,NILOTHI EXTENSION, DELHI-110041,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SIMRAN KOUR. 0040864827-3

I,**Ambika @ Amitrika @** Ambika Devi,W/o Durganand Kamat, R/o H.No.-600, W.No.2, Gali No.-7,Linepar, Bahadurgarh Distt Jhajjar (Haryana)-124507, have changed my name to Ambika 004086484-1

I,**Fardana W/o** Mohd.Yaseen R/o-X-36, X-Block, Seelampur-3, Bhajanpura, North-East Delhi-110053 have changed my name to Farzana Parveen,for all purposes. 0040864832-9

I,MAHIMA D/O GAGAN BHOLA R/O- H.N.- 63 SHOP BLOCK GALI NO.-1 PANDAV NAGAR DELHI-110092 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MAHIMA BHOLA 0040864720-1

I,**PRIYANKA GOYAL W/O** SH.MUKESH GOYAL,R/O H.No.2089/162,Ganesh Pura,Tri Nagar,Delhi-110035,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO PRIYANKA GOEL, for all future purposes 0040864824-1

I,**Ayasha Abdul Mazid,W/o** Anis,R/o/F-154/28,Gali no.8,Bhagirathi-Vihar Phase-1,Delhi-110094,Have Changed My Name To Ayasha for all future purpose 0040864832-2

I, **Mohd Ikhlak S/o** Nanu Malik R/o-Mohammadiganj, jalalabad, Shamli, UP have changed my name to Ikhlak Malik. 0071046429-1

I, **ANJANA VIKRAM JAGTAP**, Mother of No.1464945W(HAV) JAGTAP NANA VIKRAM, resident of H.No.-511, Karanjagavhan, Tehsil-Malegaon, Distt.-Nashik, Maharashtra-423203, have changed my name from ANJANA VIKRAM JAGTAP to ANJNABAI VIKRAM JAGTAP, vide affidavit IN-DL47793711237757Y, dated: 07/07/2026, before Notary, Advocate: Ajay Massey, Regd.No.-54075, New Delhi. 0071046379-1

I,**Nitin Thakur, S/o**-Jagdish R/o-44, Gali No.1,Chander Lok Colony,Mandoli Road, Shahdara, Delhi-110093,have changed my minor son name Ojash Thakur and Ojash to Ojas Thakur. 0040864827-5

I, **SUNIL KUMAR JAIN, S/O** ASHOK KUMAR JAIN R/O 4/2582, GALI PEEPAL WALI, DHARAMPURA, DARIBA KALAN DELHI-110006 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SUNIL JAIN 0050292768-1

I,**BALBIR SINGH MINHAS,S/O**-RASIL SINGH MINHAS,R/O-FLAT-NO-A1/902, TOWER-NO-6,PURVANCHAL-ROYAL CITY,PLOT.NO-GH.05,SECTOR-CHI-V, GREATER-NOIDA KASNA GAUTHAM-BUDH NAGAR, UTTAR PRADESH-201310, Inform that BALBIR MINHAS and BALBIR SINGH MINHAS, both are one & the same person. 0040864824-10

I,**MUZASSIM ANSARI,S/O**-HASRAT ALI,R/o-Gadal, Begrajpur,Nehtaur,Bijnor,UP-246733,have changed my name to MUZASSIM ZAVIAN ABRAM legally for all future intents and purposes 0040864832-11

I,**Kapil S/o** Phool Singh,R/o Sun 5-204,Migsun Rofr,Sikrod, Rajnagar-Extension, Ghaziabad, U.P.201003,have changed my name from Kapil to Kapil Rajora for all purposes. 0040864824-5

I **Rakesh Kumar Gupta S/o** Late Sh. Om Prakash Gupta R/o J-2783, 7th Avenue, Gaur City-1, Greater Noida West, Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P.-201318 have changed my name to Rakesh Kumar for all purposes. 0040864714-8

I, **Shreya Pandey D/o** Shri Pankaj Pandey R/o/House No.79, Block-H, Jai Vihar, Phase-1, Najafgarh, South west, New Delhi-110043 Estate, my Correct Name is SHREYA PANDEY mention in my school document 10th & 12th Class CBSE Certificate. But in my AADHAR card, my name is mentioned as SHRIYA PANDAY, we have declared that my name is changed from SHRIYA PANDAY to SHREYA PANDEY for All future purposes with affidavit No.IN-DL48271922198688Y dated 7-July-2026 & SHREYA PANDEY and SHRIYA PANDAY is same person. 0040864793-1

I, **Rashmi Kumari, D/o** Tara Chand Prasad, W/O Tara Shankar Gupta, R/o Flat No. A 1401, ACE Platinum Apartment, Sector Zeta-1, Geater Noida, District G.B Nagar U.P. changed my name from RASHMI KUMARI to RASHMI GUPTA for all future purposes. 0071046440-1

I, **Ankoor B Sarkar, S/O**- Mr. Bhupendra Mohan Sarkar, R/O-I-1907, Logix Blossom County, Sector 137, NOIDA, have Changed my name from Ankoor B Sarkar to Ankur Sarkar 0040864758-1

I, **Bhanu Priya Gulati D/o** Jitender Gulati R/O H.No.17/827,Dharampura, Bahadurgarh Distt Jhajjar (Haryana)-124507,have changed my name to Bhanu Gulati 0040864824-3

I **Vikash Gola S/o** Sh. Suresh Chandra Gola R/o House No.1/7, Sanjay Enclave, Uttam Nagar, Delhi-110059 have changed the name of my minor son from Dux Gola alias Daksh Gola to Daksh Gola for all purposes. 0040864714-6

I, **Chetna Bhushan,W/O** Late Surjeet Bhasin,R/O 17/68-A,2nd Floor,Tilak-Nagar, New-Delhi-110018,have changed my name to Chetna 0040864832-4

I,**MATIN QURESHI,S/O**-ISLAMUDDIN QURESHI,R/O-T-8,NEAR KALI-MASJID, BASTI-HAZRAT NIZAMUDDIN,NEW DELHI-13,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHAMMAD MATEEN QURESHI,FOR ALL,FUTURE PURPOSES. 004086484-1

I, **Farzana Khatun W/o** Abul Kalam, Vill-Bardwidi Post-Pathalgada, Thana-Pathalgada, Barwadhi alias Nimekhap, PO-Pathalgada, Distt:Chatra, Jharkhand-825408 have changed my name to Farjana Khatun for all future Purposes. 0071046428-1

I, **Prerna D/o** Pritam Singh R/o H.No.Y-2274, Mangolpuri, Delhi-110083 have changed my name to Preksha. 0040864827-2

I, **Chander Kant Katyan Sharma S/o** Shyam Sundar Sharma, R/O C-4/4, Gali No. 7, Arjun Mohalla, Maujpur, Delhi-53, have changed my name to ChanderKant Katyayan . 0071046375-1

I,**hitherto** known as ABHISHEK SINGH alias ABHISHEK,S/O-Late R P SINGH,residing at-8/36,BLOCK-8,NEHRU NAGAR,DELHI-110065,have changed the name and shall hereafter be known as ABHISHEK SINGH. 0040864832-6

I, **Pratibha Jain W/o** Shri Pramod Kumar Jain R/o D-4, Lovely Apartments, Mayur Vihar Phase-1 Extn., Delhi-110091, have changed my name to Mukesh Jain for all purposes. 0040862015-3

I, **Amal Biswas, S/o** Bhim Biswas, R/o H.No.A-18, Shiv Mandir,Khadar, Sarita Vihar, New Delhi-110076, my name is wrongly mentioned in my Pan card, Aadhar card & Bank account as Amalendu Biswas, have changed my name to Amal Biswas for all future purposes. 0040864596-2

LOST & FOUND
Lost Original Property Document of F-20/15, Mandir Marg, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051. Founder May Inform, Baijrang Lal Gupta, S/O Hemraj Agarwal #921226550, 9211278367. 0040864832-12

I **Kavita Jain, W/o** Sh. Rajesh Jain, R/o H -12, 8, Chander Nagar, East Delhi-110051 have lost my Agreement to Sell and Payment Receipt executed on 23.05.1973 by Har Bhagwan in favour of Sunder Lal Kapur W.R.T. Plot No.3, New Gobind Pura, Delhi-110051. Finders may contact at above address. 0040864714-1

I **Uma Sharma, W/o** Sh. Sanjay Kumar Sharma, R/O C-90A, Street No.1, Jitar Nagar, East Delhi-110051 have lost my Agreement to Sell and Payment Receipt executed on 07.05.1973 by Siya Ram in favour of Har Bhagwan W.R.T. Plot No.3, New Gobind Pura, Delhi-110051. Finders may contact at above address. 0040864714-3

Lost Original Property Document of F-20/15, Mandir Marg, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051. Founder May Inform, Baijrang Lal Gupta, S/O Hemraj Agarwal #921226550, 9211278367. 0040864832-12

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I **Poonam Khurana, W/o** Sh. Harbans Lal R/o/House No.221, Block No.6, Geeta Colony, East Delhi-110031 have lost my Original Agreement to Sell dated 04.10.1973 executed by Jai Kishan in favour of Krishna Wanti W.R.T. Property No.10, Silver Park, Shri Puri, Delhi-110051. Finders may contact at above address. 0040864714-4

LOST: Property documents (allotment & possession letter, demand notice, challan receipt, NOC electric connection) of shop at Sector B-1, CSC Double Story, Block 2, Vasant Kunj, of Gayatri Panwar (W/o Late Shri R S Panwar), R/o H.No. 645, Sector A, Pocket C, Vasant Kunj. Contact: 9862909418. 0130066599-1

PUBLIC NOTICE
IT IS HEREBY INFORMED THAT SHRI SEEMANT DUA, HAS APPLIED FOR A LOAN FROM LICHLI IN RESPECT OF THE FREEHOLD BUILT-UP SFS FLAT NO. EA-310, GROUND FLOOR, C/AT ILLUSTATED BY RAJENDRA GARGES (NAYA ENCLAVE), HARI NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110064. THE BORROWER, SHRI SEEMANT DUA, DOES NOT HAVE THE ORIGINAL (1) ALLOTMENT LETTER, (2) HANDING OVER POSSESSION LETTER DATED 02.08.1983, (3) NOC (FOR WATER & ELECTRIC CONNECTION) DATED 02.08.1983, THE AFORESAID ORIGINAL DOCUMENTS HAVE BEEN LOST/IMPLOST, AND AN FIR IN THIS REGARD IS LOGGED ON 07.07.2026. IF ANY PERSON HAS ANY RIGHT, TITLE, INTEREST, OR CLAIM IN THE AFORESAID PROPERTY, HE/SHE SHOULD INFORM THE UNDERSIGNED WITHIN 15 DAYS FROM THE DATE OF PUBLICATION OF THIS NOTICE. Sd/- SUBHASH GUPTA (Advocate) Enrol. No. D-4462002 125, FIRST FLOOR, ANAND NAGAR, INDSTERLOK, DELHI-110085

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known to the general public that my client, Paveen Bhishni, has filed a suit (Suit No. CS D1 192/2026), which is currently pending before Sh. Vikram Balli, District Judge (North East), Rohini Courts, Delhi. The suit seeks a Declaration, Damages, and a Mandatory Injunction against Sh. Yipin Gool, Sh. Smit Gupta, and Sh. Poorva Rastogi, who are presently in use and occupation of the 3rd Floor of the property No. 330-A, Block-K, Malviya Nagar, Delhi-110099, exclusively owned by my client, and constitutes the subject matter of the pending litigation. Anyone dealing about this suit property with Sh. Smit Gupta, Sh. Poorva Rastogi shall do so at their own peril, cost, and consequences. My client, as the rightful owner, shall not be held responsible for any such unauthorized, false, or frivolous dealings. Sd/- MUKESH KUMAR Advocate Ch. No. 335, Chd Wazirpur, Taz Hazari Courts, Delhi-53

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that my client namely Mrs. Charu Nagpal, w/o Ravi Nagpal R/o K-12A, DDA SFS Flats, Saket, New Delhi-110017 intend to purchase property bearing no. DDA Bldg no-C-4/F, category-I, situated in block C, Saket, New Delhi from its owner Mr. Pradeep Kumar, S/o Late Ramkishan Lal Sarivastava, R/o 21E Habitate Court TPT, Main Road, Hoodi, Whitefield, Bangalore-560043. Any person/person having claim/claim on my right title, claim, benefit, demand or interest etc. with respect to the said property or having any objection to the same should inform and dispute herein below in writing within a period of 10days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which it shall be presumed that no adverse right, title, interest, share, claim or demand of any nature whatsoever exists in or upon or in respect of the said property. Sd/- KAPIL KAUSHIK Advocate Ch. No. 533, Lawyer's Chamber Block, Saket Court Complex, New Delhi-110019

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, **Indar Jit Chopra S/o** Sh. Prem Narayan Chopra, R/O A1/334, First Floor, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063 the original FRD issued by DDA in respect of plot No.153, Pocket-A-2, Sector-36, Rohini, Delhi, MIG, FRD No. 17468, dated 27/3/81 Priority No. 12299 Application No. 131228 has been lost/misplaced, LR No.424375/2026, may please contact at above address Cont# 9711323080

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known to all that our clients Mr Mohit Kumar & Mrs Sukhjit Kaur have shown their interest in purchasing Entire First Floor out of property bearing no.G-159-A, Plot no-A-9, Rajouri Garden, Village Basai Darapur, Delhi from its lawful owner Mrs Saroj Bala. Mrs Saroj Bala became the owner of the said property by virtue of a sale deed executed in her favour by Smt Saroj Agnesh, Shri Rajeev Rattan Agnesh, Shri Ashok Kumar Agnesh, Smt Neena Agnesh Bhabla & Shri Nandh Agnesh which was duly registered in the office of Sub-registrar-II, Basai Darapur, Delhi on 05-08-2023 vide regn. no. 10232 in Book no.1, Volume no.27305 on pages 18-27. There is exhibit/ Court marking of Aadi District Judge, Delhi on 21-10-1993 on the first conveyance deed duly regd on 16-07-1956 in favour of Mr B.R. Agnesh. The supporting record in respect of said exhibit/court marking is not traceable despite marking diligent effort and checking from the previous owner. The exact description, case reference number, docket number or other identifying particulars of the said document are also not traceable. An FIR dated 29-06-2026 has also been lodged by Smt Saroj Bala in this respect. If any person/institution has any claim, right, title, litigation or interest in the said property, he/she is requested to his/her claim along with relevant documents to the undersigned within 7 (seven) days otherwise it would be presumed that the said property is free from all sorts of encumbrances. Sd/- Ravi Chopra Advocate Enrol. No. 02152001 Office N-1, First Floor, DDA, Market, Mayur Vihar-III, Delhi-110096

PUBLIC NOTICE
General Public is hereby informed that My Client Amrit Kaur wife of Late Avtar Singh Sadgorya R/O C-11, Ranjeet Vihar, North Extn, Nargol West Delhi, Delhi-110018, severed all social relation with her Two Sons and One Daughter-in-law namely 1) Navdeep Sadgorya and his wife Smt. Poonam Kartar Singh Saini and 2) Amandeep Sadgorya. My clients have disowned and debarred from her all movable and immovable properties. Anybody dealing with them shall do so at his/their own risks and responsibilities for the same. Sd/- T.K. SHARMA (ADVOCATE) Ch.No. 201, SIB (Authority Building), Janak Puri, New Delhi-110058

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public at large that our clients' customer Sh. Manish Prasad, is intending to purchase built up Second Floor (Western Side), Property no. S-93-A, (old no. S-93), Kharsa no. 199, Ahead of School Block- Shakarpur, Village Shakarpur, Noida, Delhi-110092 from Smt Sushila Jomer. Acquired the Property Vide Relinquishment Deed Dated 15.05.2025 as Doc. no. 2025/54/4319. However, Original Sale Deed Dated 23.06.1972, as Doc. no. 84995 & Original Relinquishment Deed Dated 17.12.2014 as Doc. no. 6181 are not available for endorsement process as the said property being mortgage with I/s Shivakshi Finance Bank Ltd. Office at Panchsheel-2, 2nd floor, Rock Wazir Building, Sec-125, Noida-201303 after execution of sale deed in favour of client's customer. Hence this notice is hereby given that any person or legal heir, bank/s or financial institution/s, or any party/ies, any claim, charge, interest, title, demand, rights, of whatsoever nature in respect of or against the said property by way of inheritance, share, transfer, mortgage, possession, however nature, are hereby required to make the same known in writing with documentary support to the undersigned within 7 days from the date of publication, failing which the said claim of such person/s, if any will be considered as waived and settled. Mr. SAMIR KUMAR/ LALIT KUMAR ADVOCATE/ M/S. EXCEL LAW GROUP LLP, Office at Address: 87-D on 3rd Floor, Puchel-2, Sector-6, Dwarka, New Delhi; Mobile No.: 8130395390/91.

LOST & FOUND

LOST ORIGINAL SHARE CERTIFICATE OF NDSE CGHS LTD VASUNDHARA ENCLAVE DELHI 96 ALSO KNOWN AS SRINKETAN APARTMENT FOR FLAT NO 97 AGAINST MEMBERSHIP NO 226 IN THE NAME OF AMIT NEVATIA FLAT IS NOT MORTGAGED AND THERE IS NO DISPUTE FOUNDER INFORM MR AMIT 9560385403

COURT NOTICE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT (Order 5, Rule 20 of the Code of Civil Procedure) In The Court Of Dr. Ravinder Bedi District Judge (Commercial Court-01), South-East District, Room No.18, Saket Courts, New Delhi. Case No.: CS (COMM)861/2025 M/s AGNI HUNTEX PVT LTD ...Plaintiff V/S NAGESWARA RAO KANAPARTHI ...Defendant To, SHRI NAGESWARA RAO KANAPARTHI, PROP. OF GENIUS FIRE SAFETY & MEP SOLUTIONS, H. NO. 6-3-832, FIRST FLOOR, OPP. HCH CHICKEN MARKET, RBI QTR LANE, AMBERPET, TELANGANA - 500016, MOBILE NO: 9052060911 WHEREAS you are intentionally evading service of summons it is hereby notified that if you shall not defend the case on the 17th Day of July 2026 the case day fixed for the final disposal, it will be heard and determined ex-parte. Given under my hand and the seal of the Court, this 03rd day of June, 2026. Sd/- District Judge (Comm. Court-01), South East District, Saket New Delhi.

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER Open Tender Notice No.SRDEE-TRD-1ZN-2026-27-T10, Date- 08.07.2026 Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/ TRD, North Eastern Railway, Itanagar for and on behalf of President of India, invites sealed "OPEN" E-Tender for the following work: S.N.-: 1, Name of work:- TRD related work for provision of 3rd loop line at CHRU station. Tender reference no:- SRDEE-TRD-1ZN-2026-27-T10, Approx. Cost (In Rs.): - 1,17,60,653.32, Earnest money/Bid Security (in Rs):- 2,35,200.00, Cost of tender documents (in Rs):- 00, E-Tender closing date and Time:- 31.07.2026 11:00, Completion period:- 12 Month, E-Tender Online will be submitted upto 11:00 Hrs on date: 31.07.2026. For full details and submission of bid kindly visit the Official website if Indian railways i.e., www.irops.gov.in Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRD CPRO/Elect.-89 Ittanagar Do Not Smoke Bid/Cigarette in train

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice Dy. CME/Works for Chief Workshop Manager, N.E. Railway, Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur for and on behalf of President of India invites Open tender through on-line (E-Tendering) for the following work:- S.No. (1), E-Tender Notice No. & Name of the work: Tender No.- "12-GKP-MWS-2026-27" "Dismounting, Cleaning, Mounting and on spot testing of AC LHB/ICF and Non-AC LHB/ICF/MEMU coaches Under slung, auxiliary and overhead water tank in Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur for 02 years." Estimated cost (In Rs.): 13774494.96, Earnest Money (In Rs.): 2755000.00, Cost of the Tender forms: Zero, Last date of tender submission: Upto 11.00, Date: 29.07.2026 Period of Contract : 24 Months. The details of above tenders are also available on Indian Railway Website http://www.irops.gov.in Dy. CME/Works, Mechanical Workshop, CPROMech-51 N.E. Railway, Gorakhpur "Never travel on roof and foot boards"

Call or WhatsApp 9717006820

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The Indian EXPRESS JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA

HYDERABAD METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY & SEWERAGE BOARD

O/o Chief General Manager (Engg), PCC-1, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004, TG.

e-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

e-tender Notice No. and Date	Name of Work	Approximate Estimate Contract Value
EP-03/CGM (E)/PCC-1/ Malakpet-Trunk sewer/ 2026-27, Dated: 07-07-2026	Laying of RCC Trunk Sewer Mains at Malakpet Constituency Areas.	Rs.37.50 Crores

(1) The bid documents download starts online on or after: 13-07-2026. (2) Name and address of Chief General Manager (Engg), concerned- Chief General Manager (Engg), Project Construction Circle-I, HMWSSB, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004. (3) The contractors/firms are requested to upload the information in the 'ZIP' format preferably. (4) Further details can be seen @ <https://tender.telangana.gov.in> Sd/- Chief General Manager (Engg), PCC-1, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004, TG.

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. NIT/11/26/21 Dated: 01/07/2026 On behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Materials Manager/ South East Central Railway, Bilaspur Division, invites E-Tender for the following items:

Sr. No.	Tender Number	Due Date	Due Time	Tender Cost (Rs.)	EMD (Rs.)
1	11265618	22/07/2026	10:30	0.00	186280.00

 Description:- Supply, installation, commissioning and training of Hydraulic test bench (2 SSE/JE, 2 Technicians, 3 Helpers) will be trained by supplier for operation and maintenance at track machine satellite depot for on load testing of hydraulic pumps, motors, valves & cylinders with computer interface and data acquisition system as per specification attached. Warranty: As per IRS conditions of contract [Warranty Period: 30 Months after the date of delivery] Tender, please visit IREPS Website at <https://www.irops.gov.in> Note: In controversial condition regarding description, English text version will be considered certified. Sr. Divl. Materials Manager S.E.C. Railway/Bilaspur CPR/



BORDER SECURITY FORCE
SH VIJAY AHUA, ASSISTANT COMMANDANT, PMG
SHQ BSF KUPWARA
07.09.1967 - 09.07.1998
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant officer Sh Vijay Ahuja, Assistant Commandant on his Balidan Diwas On this day, he sustained fatal injuries while fighting militants in Gulgam area, Kupwara, J&K He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with PMG (Posthumously).



CONSTABLE
VJAYNAND NAYAK
121 BN BSF
12.02.1989 -
09.07.2018



CONSTABLE
SANTOSH
LAXMAN GAURAV
121 BN BSF
07.01.1991 -
09.07.2018

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan s Constables VJayanand Nayak and Santosh Laxman Gaurav on their Balidan Diwas On this day, t hey sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast, triggered by Naxals in Durg area, Chhattisgarh and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



CONSTABLE
SANTANU
CHAKRABORTY
109 BN BSF
15.01.1969 -
09.07.1992



CONSTABLE
TILESHWAR
RAJBANSHI
109 BN BSF
01.03.1966 -
09.07.1992

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Narendra Nath Barman on his Balidan Diwas.
On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty, while fighting enemy forces during 1971 Indo Pak war in area of BOP Gojandanga, Kolkata (West Bengal).



CONSTABLE KISHAN KUMAR DUBEY, PMG
119 BN BSF
MARTYRED ON 09.07.2015
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Kishan Kumar Dubey on his Balidan Diwas On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in Baramulla area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with PMG (Posthumously).



HARYANA REAL ESTATE
REGULATORY AUTHORITY
New Mini Secretariat, 2nd Floor, Sector-1, Panchkula.
E-mail: hrerapkl-hry@gov.in, officer.rera.hry@gmail.com
Website: www.haryanarera.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
For kind attention of allottees of the Real Estate Project namely “NV City” an Affordable Residential Plotted Colony (under DDJAY-2016) being developed on land measuring 26.3625 acres. 18.075 acres was registered vide Registration No. HRERA-PKL-ROH-436-2023 dated 17.04.2023 valid upto 31.03.2026 and 8.287 acres registered vide supplementary registration in view of the orders of the Authority dated 18.12.2024 situated in the Revenue Estate of Village Sunari Khurd, Sector-21 E, Rohtak, Haryana.

1. The promoter has requested the Authority that instead of revoking the registration on its expiry, the Authority may permit it to remain in force for one more year subject to such further terms and conditions as it thinks fit to impose in the interest of the allottees and any such terms and conditions so imposed shall be binding upon the promoter.

2. The Authority is considering the application of the promoter to permit continuation of registration under section 7(3) of the Act for this project. However, the first right of refusal for carrying out of the remaining development works is that of the association of allottees. Therefore, the Authority hereby invites objections from the association of allottees in particular and any other concerned persons in general.

3. The objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority before 21.07.2026 which will be considered by the Authority under section 7(3) of the Act.

Secretary (Acting)
HRERA Panchkula

No. 46964/HR/



बिहार शहरी आधारभूत संरचना विकास निगम लि
Bihar Urban Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd.
(बिहार सरकार का उपक्रम)
पता : पूरना हजत भवन / Old Hajat Building,
समाहरणालय परिसर मोतिहारी-845401 / Collectorate Campus, Motihari- 845401
ईमेल / E-mail: buidcomotihari@gmail.com, website: http://buidco.in
CIN – U45200BR2009SGC014600



निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना (ई-टेंडरिंग द्वारा (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in) संख्या– NIT NO. 04/2026-27

1. विज्ञापन दाता का पदनाम एवं पता
2. निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना निर्गत की तिथि
3. प्री बीड मीटिंग का समय/स्थान/तिथि
4. परिसमा विपत्र प्राप्त करने की तिथि एवं समय
5. संवेदक द्वारा निविदा अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि: दिनांक– 30.07.2026 के 15:00 बजे तक (on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
6. तकनीकी बीड खोलने की तिथि/समय
7. वित्तीय बीड खोलने की तिथि/समय
8. कार्य का विवरण:–

1. परियोजना निदेशक, बुडको, पूर्वी चम्पारण, मोतिहारी।
2. दिनांक–06.07.2026
3. समय 11:00 बजे स्थान– कार्यालय कक्ष, पूर्वी चम्पारण, बुडको, दिनांक– 23.07.2026
4. दिनांक–23.07.2026 से 30.07.2026 के 15:00 बजे तक । (on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
5. दिनांक– 30.07.2026 के 15:00 बजे तक (on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
6. दिनांक– 31.07.2026 के 15:30 बजे (on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
7. तकनीकी बीड के मूल्यांकन के बाद । (on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

क्र० सं०	निकाय का नाम	कार्य का नाम (मुख्यमंत्री समग्र शहरी विकास योजना)	प्राक्कलित राशि (₹0 में)	अग्रघन की राशि (Online के माध्यम से WWW.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in)	परिमाण विपत्र का (Online के माध्यम से WWW.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in)	Bid Processing Fee (Through online payment)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
1	पकडीया ल	वार्ड सं०-03 ब्रह्मस्थान से मुख्य मार्ग (मोतिहारी) बाघ पर सोलिंग सह पीसीसीड सड़क का निर्माण कार्य।	42,25,300.00	84,600.00	11,800.00	As per Eproc2	तीन माह।
2	पकडीया ल	वार्ड सं०-10 में कुमारवामा में स्थित सामुदायिक भवन में खेल मैदान का विकास एवं सीढ़ीकरण कार्य।	42,41,600.00	84,900.00	11,800.00	As per Eproc2	तीन माह।
3	पकडीया ल	वार्ड सं०-13 में रामचंद्र राय के घर से अनुसूचित जाति के टोला होते हुए नहर तक नाला नाला पीसीसीड निर्माण कार्य।	1,45,23,000.00	2,90,500.00	17,700.00	As per Eproc2	चार माह।
4	मोतिहारी	वार्ड सं० 33 में राजा बाजार पीडब्ल्यू डी रोड रोड अग्रवाल के घर से होते हुए पडित चन्द्रकिशोर मिश्रा के घर होते हुए दीपक श्रीवास्तव से भरत सिंह से मुन्ना मिश्रा के घर होते हुए मोलानाथ तिवारी के घर होते हुए राजीव रंजन जी के घर तक पीसीसीड सड़क एवं आर०सी०सी नाला का निर्माण कार्य।	2,26,29,000.00	4,52,600.00	17,700.00	As per Eproc2	छः माह।
5	मोतिहारी	वार्ड सं०-45 में बड़ा बरियारपुर पीडब्ल्यूडी रोड श्री रामकुमार पांडेय के घर से हनुमान मंदिर होते हुए एन०एच०28 तक नाला निर्माण कार्य।	1,15,22,600.00	2,30,500.00	17,700.00	As per Eproc2	चार माह।
6	मोतिहारी	वार्ड सं०-16 में ठाकुरवाडी बनियापट्टी में श्री विनोद जी के एस०बी०आई० ए०टी०एम० से श्री रमण दूबे के दुकान होते हुए स्व० रामजी प्रसाद वकील के घर होते श्री पुनित साह के घर धनकी धाया से श्री रामनाथ ठाकुर के घर तक नाला एवं पीसीसीड निर्माण कार्य।	2,14,14,700.00	4,28,300.00	17,700.00	As per Eproc2	छः माह।
7	मोतिहारी	वार्ड सं०-17 में हनुमान गढ़ी सरकारी भूमी पर का पाक का निर्माण कार्य (24-25)। पुनर्निविदा	1,49,14,757.00	2,98,300.00	17,800.00	As per Eproc2	छः माह।
8	मोतिहारी	वार्ड सं०-17 में हनुमान गढ़ी सरकारी भूमी पर का पाक का निर्माण कार्य (24-25)। पुनर्निविदा	1,49,14,757.00	2,98,300.00	17,800.00	As per Eproc2	छः माह।

नोट:- 1. Bidders should submit Bid Processing fee through on line payment as per amount generated on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

08. संवेदक का राज्य सरकार के किसी कार्य विभाग में उकेदार निबंधन नियमावली के अधीन समुचित श्रेणी में निबंधन होना चाहिए।

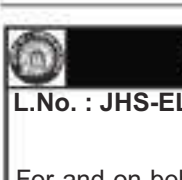
09. विस्तृत निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना विभागीय वेबसाइट state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar एवं www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

10. दो करोड़ से ऊपर की राशि का निविदा SBD के माध्यम से होगी।

परियोजना निदेशक,
बुडको, पूर्वी चम्पारण, मोतिहारी।

PR- 007198 (B & C) 2026-27

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
L.No. : JHS-ELG-W-T-05-2026-27 Date: 05.07.2026
TENDER NOTICE

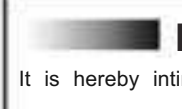
For and on behalf of President of India, the Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (Gen) North Central Railway, Jhansi invites open tenders through online (E-Tendering) for the following work:-
Tender No. : JHS-ELG-W-T-05-2026-27
Description of work:- Electrical/G work for **Part-A :** Jhansi Division: Provision of 03 Nos FOBs (LAR, ORAI & DAA) with 12.0 M wide of Jhansi division under Amrit Bharat station scheme. **Part-B :** Jhansi division: Provision of 02 Nos FOBs (TKMG & MCSC) with 12.0 M wide of Jhansi division under Amrit Bharat station scheme.
Tender Value : Rs. 46,63,365/- only **Bid Security:** Rs. 93,300/- only
Completion Period: 06 month **Closing date of tender:** 27.07.2026 (upto 15:00 Hrs.)
Tenderer will submit the tender online upto **27.07.2026 (upto 15:00 Hrs.)** Complete details & for submission of tenders can be seen in Indian Railway website <http://www.irops.gov.in>. **1550/26 (PH)**
 North central railways  @CPRONCR  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No.:- DRMC/AGRA/PARKING/E-AUCTION/2026 Dated: 07.07.2026
E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager -North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-
Category: Parking **Auction Catalogue No.:** PARKING-26-02
Asset Details: Bhuteshwar Railway Station, Circulating Area - Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers Parking.
E-Auction Start Date and Time: Date: 27.07.2026 Time: 12:15
E-Auction End Date and Time: Date: 27.07.2026 Time: 12:45
Asset Details: Idgah Jn. Railway Station, IDH Station PF-1, Circulating Area - Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers Parking.
E-Auction Start Date and Time: Date: 27.07.2026 Time: 12:15
E-Auction End Date and Time: Date: 27.07.2026 Time: 12:55
Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.irops.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. **1558/26 (PH)**
 North central railways  @CPRONCR  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in



NOTICE

It is hereby intimated that with effect from 08-10-2026 MFI Operations of Asirvad Micro Finance Limited MAKSI Ground Floor, Khasar no. 1098/1, front of Bharat petrol pump, Main Road Maksi, Dist-Shajapur 465106 M.P., will be shifted to Asirvad Micro Finance Limited, MAKSI TARANA TOBRAI KHEDA ROAD TARANA, UJJAIN, MADHYA PRADESH 456668 for the better convenience in infrastructure. Customers may kindly note that all efforts have been taken to avoid inconvenience to the customers and still any difficulties are faced, all are requested to contact in the following numbers for further guidance.

Branch Head No: 9691103639
Area Head No: HO: 9025401720

Asirvad Micro Finance Ltd.
(Subsidiary of Manappuram Finance Limited)
Registered Office: Ceebra Marjala, 3rd Floor, Office No-1, New No. 39, Old No. 45, North Road, Egnore, Opp : Indian Red Cross Society, Chennai-600 002.Tamilnadu, India
Corporate Office: Building NO-485 B, C & D, Chanthappadi, Valagod, Thrissur, Kerala, India-680567



ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्लॉट सं. 01, नालेज पार्क-IV, ग्रेटर नौएडा, गौतमबुद्ध नगर, उत्तर प्रदेश-201308
वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in ई-मेल: authority@gnida.in

पत्रांक: वरि० प्र०(ई-निविदा सेल)/ 2026 / 1192 दिनांक: 08/07/2026
आर.ए.पी./ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (वर्क सर्किल-7), ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नौएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-वरि० प्र० निविदा सेल/2026/1191, दिनांक 08/07/2026 के माध्यम से उल्लेखित कम संख्या-03 पर अंकित कार्य की ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा की समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नौएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etender.uptn.ic.in> पर उपलब्ध हैं। किसी पर्यवेक्षक, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम / वर्क सर्किल	अनुमानित लागत
1.	Short-term gap arrangements for Hiring of 09 Mechanical Road Sweeping Machines on Rent for a period of 180 days for roads under the jurisdiction of Greater Noida West	₹0 3.21 करोड़
2.	Short-term gap arrangements for Hiring of 07 Mechanical Road Sweeping Machines on Rent for a period of 180 days for roads under the jurisdiction of Greater Noida Central	₹0 2.49 करोड़
3.	Short-term gap arrangements for Hiring of 06 Mechanical Road Sweeping Machines on Rent for a period of 180 days for roads under the jurisdiction of Greater Noida East	₹0 2.14 करोड़

कम सं०01 से 03 तक किर्ते दिनांक 08/07/2026 से 22/07/2026 को 17:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है, एवं प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 24/07/2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी।
वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (वर्क सर्किल-7)
Follow Us On     /OfficialGNIDA



HUBLI ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly Owned Govt. of Karnataka Undertaking)
Corporate Office, Gopankoppa, Hubballi-580023
Website : www.hesc.com.gov.in
E-mail ID: seepmc.hescom@gmail.com, eepmc2.hescom@gmail.com

Corporate Identity Number (CIN) : U31401KA2002SGC030437
No: HESCOM/SEE(PMC)/EE-P2/AEE-2/2026-27/cys-3471
Date : 08-07-2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPPP Portal Only)
Superintending Engineer (Ele), Projects Monitoring Cell, Corporate Office, HESCOM, Hubballi invites tenders for “Selection of Solar Power Generators (SPGs) on the basis of Build Own & Operate (BOO) for Design, Survey, Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning, Operation & Maintenance of grid connected distributed solar power plants for solarization of selected Agriculture (EIP) feeders at Sub-Station (SS) level, its associated 11kV line to connect the plant with concerned SS and Remote Monitoring System (RMS) of solar power plants through RESCO mode, for 25 years under CM-SKY Scheme in HESCOM jurisdiction” vide Indent No: HESCOM/2026-27/SE0746 Dt. 08.07.2026.
The detailed notification regarding the bid enquiry can be obtained by logging in to the website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> on or after **08.07.2026**.
Sd/- Superintending Engineer, (Ele), Project Monitoring Cell, DIPR/DHARWAD/388/KSMCA/2026-27 HESCOM, Hubli

NORTHERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM
Ref:- i) Tender Notice No.19/2026-2027 Dated 12.06.2026 S.N.-02
ii) Tender No.07261857 due on 06.07.2026.
In reference to above tender, the following corrigendums have been issued.
(1) The tender opening date extended from 06.07.2026 to **21.07.26**.
(2) Specification modify from RDSO Spec. No. RDSO/2013/CG-01 (Rev. 01) to RDSO Spec. No. RDSO/2013/CG-01 (Rev. 03).
(3) Modify UVAM RDSO sub Item ID from 3100337001/3100337003 of Item ID 3100337 to UVAM RDSO Sub Item ID 3100337003 of Item ID 3100337.
All other terms and condition remain unchanged.
The corrigendum has been published on website www.irops.gov.in

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2349/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	09262567	KIT FOR CONSTANT CONTACT POLYURETHANE SIDE BEARER PAD	1511 SET	03.08.2026
02	09262551	POLY RING FOR CCPU SB PAD	14023 NOS	03.08.2026
03	09260092	ADAPTER NARROW JAW WITH LUG CLASS K (6 1/2" X 9")	14398 NOS	03.08.2026
04	19260803	SET OF SINGLE DUCT LEATHER BELLOW	150 NOS	03.08.2026
05	08265202	6 CORE X 1.5 SQ. MM SIGNALING CABLE	1429.14 KM	04.08.2026
06	19260680	SET OF WIPER ARM	744 SET	05.08.2026
07	19260610	SET OF CRU BEARING	163 SET	05.08.2026
08	19264469	SET OF CYLINDRICAL ROLLER BEARING	115 SET	05.08.2026
09	07261024	HIGH CAPACITY THERMOPLASTIC POLYESTER ELASTOMER	32296 NOS	06.08.2026

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e www.irops.gov.in for details.
2. No manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No.: 25/2026-2027 Dated: 08.07.2026 2358/2026 

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय
सारण नहर प्रमंडल, भोरे
(email – scdbhore@gmail.com) (Mobile No. – 7463889597)
निविदा रद्द सूचना

इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 460 दिनांक 24.03.2026 द्वारा अल्पकालीन निविदा (Tender ID-129042) आमंत्रण सूचना सं० 03/2025-26 की निविदा आमंत्रित की गयी थी। इस निविदा का शुद्धि पत्र इस कार्यालय का पत्रांक 511 दिनांक 06.04.2026 द्वारा निर्गत किया गया, जिसका पी० आर नं० 000391 (WRD) 2026-27 है। इस निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना की कंडिका-35 के अनुरूप प्रशासनिक स्वीकृति वर्तमान तिथि तक अप्राप्त रहने के कारण उक्त अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना की कंडिका- 16 में निहित अधिकार का प्रयोग करते हुए इस वर्ष 2026 मानक संचालन प्रक्रिया के अनुरूप कार्य कराया जाना संभव नहीं होने के कारण रद्द किया जाता है।
सुनील कुमार (ID-5446)
कार्यपालक अभियंता
सारण नहर प्रमंडल, भोरे
PR-007307 (WRD) 2026-27
उक्त सूचना state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।



समाहरणालय, कैमूर
(मद्यनिषेध एवं उत्पाद शाखा)
वाहन नीलामी हेतु अति अल्पकालीन आम सूचना
(बिहार मद्यनिषेध एवं उत्पाद अधिनियम 2016 एवं संशोधित अधिनियम 2018 के सुसंगत प्रावधानों के तहत राज्यसात किये गये वाहनों की (अल्पकालीन सार्वजनिक नीलामी सूचना)

एतद् द्वारा सर्व साधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि कैमूर जिलान्तर्गत विभिन्न थाना कार्षाँ/ उत्पाद वादों में निम्न वाहनों का बिहार मद्यनिषेध एवं उत्पाद अधिनियम 2016 एवं संशोधित अधिनियम 2018 के सुसंगत प्रावधानों के तहत विभिन्न अधिहरण वादों में न्यायालय समाहर्ता-सह-जिला दण्डाधिकारी, कैमूर (भमुआ) एवं उनके द्वारा प्राधिकृत न्यायालयों द्वारा राज्यसात (Confiscate) किये गये वाहनों की सार्वजनिक नीलामी (Public Auction) जारी है, जैसे है: के रूप में समाहर्ता, कैमूर द्वारा गठित नीलामी समिति के द्वारा 11.00 बजे पूर्वाह्न से समाहरणालय स्थित सभाकक्ष, कैमूर (भमुआ) में निम्न प्रकार से की जायेगी।

आवेदन प्राप्त करने की तिथि	वाहन नीलामी की तिथि	आवेदन प्राप्त करने का स्थान
17.07.2026	नीलामी की पहली तिथि	20.07.2026
22.07.2026	नीलामी की दूसरी तिथि	24.07.2026
27.07.2026	नीलामी की तीसरी तिथि	29.07.2026

महाराष्ट्र राज्य अतर्गत प्रेस विज्ञापित हेतु वाहनों की विवरणी

क्र०	थाना	वाहन का प्रकार	वाहन प्रकार	निबन्धन सं०	वाहन स्वामी का नाम	अधिहरण एवं पता	मुल्यांकित राशि	SOP के आलोक में दायी नीलामी का 10% कम राशि	SOP के आलोक में ग्यारह नीलामी का 10% कम राशि	अवधन राशि	SOP के आलोक में बारहवी नीलामी का 10% कम राशि	SOP के आलोक में तेरहवी नीलामी का 10% कम राशि	SOP के आलोक में दसवी नीलामी का 10% कम राशि
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GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
CORRIGENDUM

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD CORP./AUTH	OLD REFERENCE/INT NO.	NATURE OF CORRIGENDUM	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HYPNL	NIET/01/7/PRD/2025-26 DATED-26.12.2025 (REFERENCE NO. 2025080908/2025-26) FOR REPLACEMENT OF 2 NOS. 220KV OLD, OBSOLETE AND MANUAL OPERATED AND 7 NOS. OLD, OBSOLETE AND MANUAL OPERATED 66 KV ISOLATORS WITH NEW HYDROTECH 220KV AND 66 KV ISOLATORS INSTALLED AT 230 KV SUTR BEHNS BALLABHAGH (TENDER ID- 2025, HMC- 493148, 13) (ENIT NO.989893) DISTRICT- FARIDABAD	THE DATE OF ONLINE BID SUBMISSION IS EXTENDED UPTO 16.08.2026	www.hypnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRODHYPNL.ORG.IN
2	HYPNL	NIET/07/7/PRD/2025-26 DATED-26.12.2025 (REFERENCE NO. 202508048312 ENIC 4276 8002 7935084C8779796H9P) FOR AUGMENTATION OF 220KV SUBSTATION SECTION 56 FARIDABAD FROM 220/220KV, 220/66KV PLUS 2X 25/31.5 MVA 66/11 KV TIPS TO (2X160/3MVA, 220/66KV PLUS 2X 25/31.5 MVA 66/11 KV TIPS ALONG WITH EXTENSION OF CONTROL ROOM AND PROVIDING NEW 11KV PANEL SET BY HVNL (TENDER ID. 1- 2025, HMC- 493153, 13) (ENITNO.- 136953) DISTRICT- FARIDABAD	THE DATE OF ONLINE BID SUBMISSION IS EXTENDED UPTO 16.08.2026	www.hypnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRODHYPNL.ORG.IN
3	HYPNL	NIET/08/7/PRD/2025-26 DATED-26.12.2025 (REFERENCE NO. 2025080584312 ENIC 4276 8002 7935084C8779796H9P) FOR AUGMENTATION OF 66KV SUBSTATION BADIOLA FROM (2X25/31.5) MVA TO (2X25/31.5) MVA, 66/11 KV TIPS(TIP T-1) ALONG WITH EXTENSION OF CONTROL ROOM BUILDING BY HVNL (TENDER ID. 1- 2025, HMC- 493153, 13) (ENITNO.- 136955) DISTRICT- FARIDABAD	THE DATE OF ONLINE BID SUBMISSION IS EXTENDED UPTO 16.08.2026	www.hypnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRODHYPNL.ORG.IN
4	HYPNL	NIET/09/7/PRD/2025-26 DATED-26.12.2025 (REFERENCE NO. 2025080584312 ENIC 4276 8002 7935084C8779796H9P) FOR AUGMENTATION OF 66KV SUBSTATION DHAULI FROM (2X12.5/16) MVA TO (2X25/31.5) MVA, 66/11 KV TIPS(TIP T-1) ALONG WITH EXTENSION OF CONTROL ROOM BUILDING BY HVNL (TENDER ID. 1- 2025, HMC- 493153, 13) (ENITNO.- 136955) DISTRICT- FARIDABAD	THE DATE OF ONLINE BID SUBMISSION IS EXTENDED UPTO 16.08.2026	www.hypnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRODHYPNL.ORG.IN
5	HYPNL	NIET/10/7/PRD/2025-26 DATED-26.12.2025 (REFERENCE NO. 2025080584312 ENIC 4276 8002 7935084C8779796H9P) FOR AUGMENTATION OF 66KV SUBSTATION DHAULI FROM (2X12.5/16) MVA TO (2X25/31.5) MVA, 66/11 KV TIPS (TIP T-2) ALONG WITH EXTENSION OF CONTROL ROOM BUILDING BY HVNL (TENDER ID. 1- 2025, HMC- 493154, 13) (ENITNO.- 136955) DISTRICT- FARIDABAD	THE DATE OF ONLINE BID SUBMISSION IS EXTENDED UPTO 16.08.2026	www.hypnl.org.in	0172-2583789 PRODH

Switzerland's long wait ends after stalemate

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 8

SWITZERLAND VS Colombia. Round of 16. Vancouver. A 0-0 stalemate after 120 minutes. Switzerland prevailed 4-3 on penalties, reaching their first World Cup quarterfinal since 1954. There is little to recall from the match, but a lot of context.

Before the caravan rolled into Canada, the previous seven Round of 16 matches had produced 21 goals, three a game. There was action at the Azteca, where England beat Mexico 3-2. A spectacle at Seattle, where Belgium put four past co-hosts USA, then did the Donald Trump YMCA shimmy. How can one not mention Cristiano Ronaldo's agony at Arlington, or Erling Haaland's euphoria at East Rutherford?

The world was yet to recover from the adrenaline of Atlanta, still debating every second of Argentina's win over Egypt. It is in this setting that we arrive in Vancouver. Two of the tournament's most stubborn defences arrived having conceded only four goals between them in almost 1,000 minutes of football. One every four hours. Colombia shoot from everywhere, but predominantly shoot blanks. In their last five matches, including this one, they scored only twice from 79 shots. A success rate of 2.5%.

The effort deserves credit, since from the Swiss team, there barely was any. Murat Yakin dresses like a marksman hired to eliminate James Bond, but his team possesses a curious aversion to pulling the trigger. Their last attempt on target came in the 32nd minute. There was not a one attempt, from either side, in the last 30 minutes, as if a truce had been signed. Regulation time yielded 0.7 expected goals, lowest in this World Cup.



Rubén Vargas scored the winning penalty vs Colombia. AP

The initial 90 did not produce an opportunity that could be classified as blue-chip. Extra time, however, did. Had Jhon Lucumi's header not struck the crossbar, or had Jaminton Campaz not skied a one-on-one opportunity, Colombia would have been preparing for a quarterfinal against Argentina. Switzerland won because of a stunning save from Gregor Kobel to deny Cucho Hernández in the shootout, and a Davinson Sánchez attempt that was too high.

The Swiss had not reached the quarterfinals in seven decades, but had come close, most painfully in 1994, another World Cup in North America. Roy Hodgson's Swiss side had already secured their place in the knockout rounds when Andrés Escobar's Colombia, already eliminated, beat them 2-0 in their final group match. It was the last match Escobar would play, falling to gangsters' bullets on his return home. Switzerland went on to lose 3-0 to Spain in the Round of 16.

MASTERMINDS ON THE SIDELINES



The other Lionel

Diego Maradona once said he couldn't control traffic. Nine years, two Copa titles, and a World Cup later, Lionel Scaloni rebuilt Messi and Argentina



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 8

THE MAN that cannot control a traffic. It was Diego Maradona's brutal assessment of Lionel Scaloni when he was appointed the full-time manager of Argentina in 2018. Argentina had a plethora of glittering names to choose from: the cult figure Marcelo Bielsa, the new-age revolutionary Mauricio Pochettino, the angel of dark arts in black suits, Diego Simeone.

Yet, to resurrect from the post-Moscow World Cup catastrophe, they turned to a largely unknown and unglamorous man. His club journey was scattered in the mid-table clubs of Italy and Spain. He wore his national stripes only seven times. He briefly managed Sevilla and Argentina's U-20 squad, before joining the backroom staff of Jorge Sampaoli during his catastrophic reign. The federation chose him, reportedly, because he came cheap, and because he was not egoistic; the simplicity of his upbringing in a farming household in Pujato, Santa Fe, showed.



He was in the hotel gym with the U-20 squad when the phone buzzed. Shocked, but prepared. The conversation ended with the first brief: to pick the nucleus of the side for the Copa America they had not won in 26 years. But before he drew the list, he knew his foremost mission. To cajole Messi, who was disillusioned with the national team, back to the side. He had not retired yet, but his commitment to the national side was waning.

Later that night, Scaloni and his assistant Pablo Aimar, the silver-footed forward Messi idolised, texted Messi. The content was simple: "Hi, Leo, it's Scaloni. Pablo and I want to talk to you." Messi was then in Barcelona's pre-season conditioning camp.

In the morning, Messi video-called them back and after the conversation ended, Messi swore his allegiance to Project Scaloneta.

Messi time-travelled to his debut, against Hungary in 2005 when he was red-carded 45 seconds into the game. "I was in tears, but I remember Leo (Scaloni) and Juan (Pablo Sorin) protesting, pleading with the referee. After the game, I was still crying but Leo would comfort me. I found the eyes of a brother," he told *Canal TV*.

Messi would say after the Qatar triumph: "Subconsciously, you feel like you owe him something, because he was the one who brought me in. I am not going to let him down." The emotion is perhaps the foundation of Argentina's golden run in the Scaloni era: two Copa titles, a World Cup, and a potential defence.

The manager's biggest challenge was not tactics or stringing together a strong side. There was no shortage of gifted footballers. But to knit together a group that fought and functioned, that gelled and blended. After the Qatar World Cup triumph, he explained: "Tactics come second, first you need the right men." By the right men, he meant not those who suited his structure, but those with the character to carry Messi's burden rather than add to it.

The 2022 squad was not the best in the tournament; the 2026 side is not the most dazzling either. Messi and best friend Rodrigo de Paul turn up for Inter Miami; one was plucked from the Brazilian league. All four regulars from the English Premier League were returning from horrible seasons. Seven of the squad were 30-plus. Argentina were doomed to fail this tournament; there were moments it seemed they might. But every time Scaloni's men seemed to be drifting toward the exit, they produced a rousing comeback. Two goals

down against Egypt till the 79th minute, 2-2 in extra time against Cape Verde, Argentina found a way back. Not through radical tactics or jaw-shuddering moves. But through the dint of the will.

That spirit, in essence, is Scaloneta. The zeal to not yield or surrender, the courage to keep fighting until the last drop of blood. "Football is this, not just tactics and strategies," he said after the Egypt comeback. "Those things are important, no doubt, but if we hadn't had the heart we had, we would've been out," he added.

Scaloni achieves this without elaborate tactical discussions in the boardroom, or theatrical gesticulation on the touchline. He is in firm control of his emotions, unless he endures a match of assaulting drama like the one against Egypt. Scaloni cried; as did Messi and his men.



Scaloni is not merely a vibes manager. He used a different formation almost every match

“Football is this, not just tactics and strategies. Those things are important, no doubt, but if we hadn't had the heart we had, we would've been out.”

SCALONI, AFTER THE EGYPT GAME



Egyptian twins: Brothers up in arms

Coach Hossam Hassan and his sibling are tough nuts, their resentment about the refereeing just their latest battle

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, July 8

HOSSAM HASSAN says he's done watching this World Cup. "I told the referee that what was happening wasn't fair," the Egypt head coach said after his team's 3-2 collapse against Argentina. "It's an undeserved victory for Argentina... I'll never watch the World Cup again, because there's no justice in this competition." Egypt had led 2-0 with 11 minutes of normal time left before Argentina scored three times to complete one of the tournament's most dramatic comebacks.

Hassan's grievances ran farther than the scoreline: earlier in the match, with Egypt already 1-0 up, a goal was disallowed on VAR review; late on, he felt a foul in the Argentina box went unreviewed. He had also objected to the referee's identity before a ball was kicked, telling Francois Letexier that his background was the issue, and later that the Frenchman seemed to be "carrying a scar," that he had "something to hide." He was booked for that observation.

That was the 98th minute. The referee had already shown Hassan a yellow when his twin brother, Ibrahim, Egypt's team director, came out of the technical area to restrain him. Hossam had crossed his arms at Letexier, the gesture FIFA uses to flag racist abuse, and for a moment it looked like it might escalate. Ibrahim tried to pacify the situation, then gave the referee a thumbs up. Crisis, for now, defused. It's the kind of moment that makes for a nice story about brotherly devotion: twin coaches, one calming the other under the brightest lights in football. It's also, if one knows the history of the Hassans, a considerably more complicated one.

Born five minutes apart in 1966 in Helwan, south of Cairo, they joined Al Ahly's academy together at 13. Hossam became a striker; Ibrahim a right-back good enough to be picked for FIFA's World XI three times, the only Egyptian ever selected.

When a European club came calling for Hossam alone in the early 1990s, he turned it down. "I refuse to go anywhere without him... We are one soul and we are inseparable."

In 2000, when Al Ahly declined to renew Ibrahim's contract, Hossam walked out with him, both defecting to Zamalek, the club they had spent their careers beating. Three league titles and a CAF Champions League followed.

That devotion has a harder edge that rarely makes the highlight reel. In a brawl with a Lebanese side serious enough for the



Hossam Hassan instructing his team (top). The Egypt coach next to his twin brother Ibrahim Hassan (R) before the Argentina match. AP

army to intervene, Ibrahim saw a soldier moving to strike his brother and wrestled the rifle out of his hands. A decade later, coaching Al Masry, he assaulted a referee and insulted the home crowd in a match against MO Bejaia in Algeria. A five-year FIFA ban ensued.

The same instinct showed up in Dallas, days before the Letexier gesture. Fans, including a young child, had gathered in the team hotel's lobby hoping for pictures with the players when Ibrahim objected to how hotel security and police were handling the crowd. It became a shoving match, caught on camera. Police described the matter as resolved on the spot; Hossam later said he considered it settled.

Role reversal

Watching the two incidents side by side, one can see a role reversal. In Dallas, Ibrahim wouldn't stand down. Against Argentina, he was the one pulling his brother back.

It isn't that one twin escalates and the other calms, it's that whichever Hassan perceives an injustice first is the one who moves, and the other follows to manage what happens next. They've been doing this since Beirut. Move first, defend what's yours.

It's just found a newer target. After Egypt qualified for this World Cup, Hassan said, per *The Guardian*, that "success begins from the top of the pyramid and the officials of the state," and that meeting the president was the reward he wanted most. A presidential message, he's said, would be "a medal on my chest." He's appointed a cassation court lawyer as his official legal spokesperson, with authority to pursue "those who spread rumours... anyone who seeks to sow discord."

That mandate has already been used against a TV presenter and a pundit. Complaints have also gone to Egypt's Supreme Council for Media Regulation against broadcasters who criticised the brothers, one arguing that the criticism undermined Egypt's "official national mission." Even Egypt's sports minister, Ashraf Sobhy, weighed in, telling journalists to back the coaching staff the way they'd back the country's military and political leadership.

The brothers who once wrestled a rifle from a soldier to protect each other now have the machinery of a state doing it for them. Same instinct, different tools. And on Tuesday in Atlanta, it found a new target: the referee.

INDUSTRIOUS LIONS

Morocco's answer to Mbappe's talent are the tireless legs forged in France

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 8

NO TEAM has scored more goals at the 2026 FIFA World Cup than France. No team has had more attempts on target either. There is no subjective statistic to corroborate this, but eye test suggests no team has a more intimidating attacking quartet than France's. Kylian Mbappe. Ousmane Dembele. Michael Olise. Desire Doue. How could Morocco relent the unrelenting in the impending quarter-final?

Turns out, Morocco's greatest weapon against France is...France. They will be relying on three footballers shaped by the French system, each of whom either wore France's colours, or harboured a desire to do so. At the heart of the defence is Issa Diop. At only 21, barely weeks after moving to

England, he repelled every attack in a game against Manchester United. Jose Mourinho could barely believe what he saw. "Congratulations to whoever scouted him. The kid is a monster!"

Diop was scouted by West Ham United after standout performances for France at the 2016 U-21 Euros — the very tournament that also offered the first glimpses of the brilliance of Kylian Mbappe. He had suitors — none more unrelenting than Senegal. A nation his father hailed from, and his grandfather had coached.

Diop was asked whether the suitors interested him. The reply was firm: "I will only play for France and for no one else. I was born in France, I owe everything to France, so why play for another country? Even if I am never selected, I will never play for another country."



(L-R) Neil El Aynaoui, Ayyoub Bouaddi and Issa Diop were all born in France. AP/REUTERS

Nine years later, another U-21 Euros. Gérald Baticle's squad, however, was missing the player he had earmarked for captaincy. Ayyoub Bouaddi. Lille refused to release their teenage prodigy. Asked about his allegiance, Bouaddi had said, "At the moment, I am in the French youth team. I feel good playing for France."

Walid Regragui, the former Morocco coach, was on the brink of losing his patience. Neil El Aynaoui, son of former world No. 14 tennis player Younes El Aynaoui, delayed Morocco's advances, reluctant to close any doors. "Neil has still asked for some time. But we will have to make a decision. If he doesn't make it, I will be the

one to make it for him. We won't wait long," said Regragui. Toulouse. Senlis. Nancy. Three French cities. Three footballers, who now stand in the way of France's third consecutive FIFA World Cup semi-final.

Loaded with runners

Morocco advancing to the quarter-final is barely a surprise

Morocco have not out-dazzled teams in this competition, but outrun them. Mohamed Ouahbi's men have covered 597.2 kilometres so far, in comparison to their opponents' 578.7

now. Their performance, however, has been at times. Canada — ranked 24 places behind — outshot Morocco, generated the better chances and, according to coach Jesse Marsch, deserved to win. The Atlas Lions were not convincing against the Dutch either. In fact, without Diop's 91st-minute equaliser, they would have lost.

But his influence extends

far beyond that goal. At 6'4", he wins aerial duels, and is equally adept with ground tackles. Diop is the point of origin of Morocco's attacks. Against Brazil and Canada, he attempted more line breaks than anyone else in the squad. Against Canada, he attempted 42 forward passes.

Morocco have not out-dazzled teams in this competition, but outrun them. Mohamed Ouahbi's men have covered 597.2 kilometres so far, in comparison to their opponents' 578.7. A delta of 3.7 km per game — enough to separate a winner from a loser at this level.

At the heart of their lungs lie the pivot of Neil El Aynaoui and Ayyoub Bouaddi. Together, they have done 99.68 kilometres of running — one-sixth of the team's total. It was the same formula for their 2022

World Cup run, and now threatens to topple the French. Brazil were handed that hard lesson. El Aynaoui and Bouaddi finished first and second for distance covered in that game. Similar script against Scotland. First and second, again. While El Aynaoui's stamina puts the opposition under pressure, Bouaddi capitalises on it with his intelligence in positional awareness.

At the back, an enforcer who is as good with his feet as he is with his head. Ahead of him, a runner who never stops running. Alongside him, a teenage prodigy with a mind so unusually sharp for someone his age that he solves problems in midfield as effortlessly as differentiating a polynomial. This is the Moroccan spine.

QF 1: France vs Morocco, 1.30am (Friday), Live on Zee5OTT & United8 Channels

Clubs to take call on Indian strikers: AIFF

ALL VAR DECISIONS ARE EQUAL, SOME MORE EQUAL THAN OTHERS



AIFF general secretary M Satyanarayan (L), AIFF
Rohit Mundayur
New Delhi, July 8

THE ALL India Football Federation (AIFF) said on Wednesday it will not force clubs in the Indian Super League (ISL) and Indian Football League (IFL) to keep an Indian striker on the field for the entire match, reversing what it stated after its June 20 Special General Body Meeting. "We are leaving it to the clubs," said AIFF general secretary M Satyanarayan in a press conference where the AIFF announced an agreement to hand over the ISL's commercial rights to the 14 clubs that play in the league.

"The stronger the league, the better the Indian team. The clubs are also aware that one of our Achilles' heels has been the lack of a good striker. Hopefully, they will help in that."

"But this is not something we can implement. We cannot tell (the clubs) to play a No. 9 because, ultimately, it is for the coach (to decide). Every match, the coach's tactics may differ; in some, (the striker) may remain for the entire match, in some they won't. So it is very difficult for us to implement it. We are not insisting on it, but broadly, they know that we have to focus on getting some good strikers, so we will work on that," he added.

This marked a sharp contrast with the definitive tone of the directive the AIFF laid out in its June 20 statement. "Additionally, to ensure adequate match exposure and development opportunities for Indian forwards, one Indian striker must remain on the field for the entire 90 minutes of the match," the AIFF had said in its statement. Finding a dependable striker has long been India's biggest weakness, with successive coaches struggling to identify Sunil Chhetri's successor.

OCI clarity

Satyanarayan has also clarified that players holding an Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) card will be counted as foreigners at least for the upcoming 2026/27 season.

"As of now, we are telling the clubs that we encourage you, if you want, please enlist OCI card-holders to play in the league. Other than that, there is no change in the way they get their players. AIFF doesn't interfere and tell the clubs what to do (with their squads). We just set out the broad outlines," he said.

FORA few moments, Egypt thought they had one foot in the quarterfinals. Mostafa Ziko wheeled away in celebration, shirt off, after putting Egypt 2-0 ahead against Argentina, only for play to be halted. 17 seconds before the goal was scored, Marwan Attia appeared to stand on Lisandro Martinez's foot. The incident took place on the other end of the pitch. But VAR sent the referee to the pitch-side monitor. Seconds later, the goal was ruled out. The decision immediately reignited debate over the scope of VAR reviews. The protocol permits officials to examine offences committed in the immediate attacking phase leading to a goal. However, many questioned whether an incident remained justifiably connected to the finish to justify overturning it, given the time elapsed since the tackle and the fact that it happened almost 100 yards away.



Ghana 0-0 England, 79th min
INCIDENT: England's Ezri Konsa catches Prince Kwabena Adu inside the box.
DECISION: No penalty. VAR does not intervene.

Carlo Queiroz fumed after Ghana were denied what they believed was a match-winning penalty. Adu appeared to be clipped by Konsa while attempting to reach a loose ball, but the referee waved play on, and VAR found no "clear and obvious" error. Under protocol, VAR is meant to correct only obvious mistakes rather than re-referee subjective calls.



Argentina 3-0 Algeria, 32'
INCIDENT: Lionel Messi catches Aissa Mandi on the calf with his studs.
DECISION: No card. No VAR review.

Overshadowed by Messi's hat-trick at the time, the challenge took on greater significance after Balogun's dismissal. Replays showed Messi's studs making contact with the back of Mandi's calf, yet neither the referee nor VAR intervened. Algeria's federation later lodged a complaint, while former referees argued the challenge met a similar threshold to Balogun's.



Belgium 3-2 Senegal, 118'-125'
INCIDENT: Belgium's Youri Tielemans goes down under Lamine Camara's challenge in extra time.
DECISION: Penalty. VAR intervenes after 7 minutes.

Having lost a 2-0 lead, play was halted for a VAR review with penalties looming. After studying multiple angles, the referee awarded Belgium a penalty, which Tielemans converted to complete the comeback. Critics argued that a 7-minute review over the incident suggested the decision had drifted beyond correcting a mistake into re-refereeing the game.



Brazil 3-0 Scotland, 22'
INCIDENT: Vinicius Jr scores after dispossessing Jack Hendry.
DECISION: Goal disallowed after VAR review for a foul in the build-up.

Vinicius thought he had doubled Brazil's lead after nicking the ball from Hendry. Instead, VAR recommended an on-field review, with the referee ruling that Hendry had been fouled. Replays showed only slight contact, prompting Brazil to argue that similar physical duels had gone unpunished elsewhere in the tournament. The debate centred less on the foul itself than on the threshold for intervention.



Ecuador 2-1 Germany, 2'
INCIDENT: Germany's Aleksandar Pavlovic catches Pedro Vite with a high boot before Leroy Sané scores.
DECISION: No foul. Goal stands.

If Brazil felt punished for contact, Ecuador believed Germany escaped punishment for something serious. Pavlovic's boot appeared to catch Vite before Germany's opener, but VAR saw no reason to intervene. Viewed alongside Brazil's disallowed goal, the incident fuelled criticism that similar challenges in the attacking phase were being judged differently.



USA 2-0 Bosnia and Herzegovina, 64'
INCIDENT: USA's Folarin Balogun steps on Tarik Muharemovic's calf while both players fall.
DECISION: Straight red card after VAR review.

The referee had not even awarded a foul before VAR advised an on-field review. Slow-motion footage showed studs landing on Muharemovic's calf, although Balogun appeared to lose his balance rather than lunge deliberately. The decision, however, would later become the benchmark against which other incidents were judged.

AFTER REVIEW...

Conspiracy, controversy and the Cup

Argentina's win has coaches, presidents, and chess GM crying foul, the latest twist where subplots outnumber goals



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 8

LIONEL MESSI might be the World Cup's overwhelming protagonist, shaping moments and defining games. But a back-ground crew — Gianni Infantino, Donald Trump, enraged managers, referees — is putting in heavy shifts as support cast. Add conspiracy theories, corruption and rigging allegations, and the World Cup has the intrigue of a spy movie.

The background score intensified when Egypt manager Hosam Hassan remarked, after Argentina's controversial 3-2 turnaround, that officials had been pressured to keep Messi in the tournament. "Perhaps they wanted Messi to stay in the running," Hassan said after the match. "In football, there are sometimes external factors that go beyond the technical aspects. The world champions received support at every level."

He was referring to two incidents: Mostafa Zico's goal scrapped for a foul on Lisandro Martinez, and Alexis Mac Allister pulling Mohammed Salah



Egypt players argue with the referee after their goal was disallowed on Tuesday. AP

inside the box.

Going strictly by the book, the VAR's judgement cannot be argued: protocol requires VAR to check the attacking phase before every goal, and only a "clear and obvious" foul sends the referee to the pitch-side monitor.

Whether Marwan Attia's foul on Martinez's foot was clear and obvious is as debatable as the foul on Salah, both soft offences lost in the grey shades of a referee's perception. Hassan, Egypt's all-time highest goal scorer, said: "Life is unfair. The world is unfair. I'm not convinced by this outcome and by the way things unfolded in this match." He paused: "The referee is unfair, God is sufficient for me. He's wasting the effort of an entire

nation. The cup is directed towards Argentina."

History of scandals

The decisions divided the football world. "Sometimes, even warriors lose because the devils decide the story should end differently," Real Madrid's Jose Mourinho quipped. Even chess legend Garry Kasparov weighed in, calling FIFA "a corrupt joke" over the disallowed goal and invoking Croatia's earlier complaints: "Croatia robbed, now Egypt. But you cannot shame the shameless."

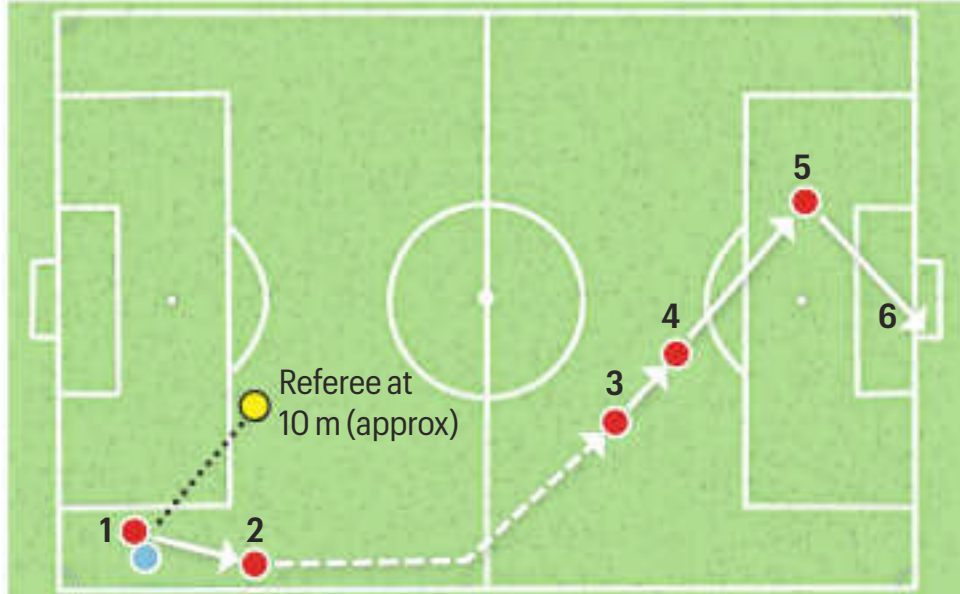
To bolster the theory of FIFA staging an Argentina triumph, social media dug up prior decisions favouring Argentina, foremost, Messi catching Algeria captain Aissa Mandi's calf with

his studs up in the opener.

Algeria complained, the decision stood. "It's pointless commenting on hypothetical situations, but everyone saw it, including me," Algeria head coach Vladimir Petkovic said. World Cups have a long history of scandals: dodgy refereeing that eased co-hosts South Korea into the 2002 semifinals, two presidents shaking hands to spare Brazilian legend Garrincha a suspension, Argentina dictator General Jorge Videla's visit to Peru's dressing room — allegedly to enable the four-goal win Argentina needed to reach the 1978 final.

But seldom has an edition carried this many subplots, political, sporting, ethical. It started with Iran: based in

17 seconds and 85 metres later... Egypt robbed?



1 Egyptian midfielder Marwan Attia gets the ball off Argentina's Lisandro Martinez. This would later be adjudged a foul by VAR.

2 Attia cushions the ball into the path of winger Haissem Hassan.

3 Hassan carries the ball 29 metres towards the Argentine

goal, dribbling past multiple players in the process.

4 The ball is released onto Mohamed Salah's path.

5 Egypt's captain splits the Argentine defence with a precise ball for Mostafa Zico.

6 Zico thunders his shot into the back of the net.

E. EXPLAINED

How does the VAR follow a game?

Unlike the referee on the pitch, the Video Assistant Referee (VAR) operates from a dedicated video operations room, where a team of officials monitors every angle of the match in real time. There are up to five officials who preside over the operations room and make calls that referees are unable make.

What is their scope, and how do they communicate with the referee?

If they identify a potential "clear and obvious error" or a serious missed incident in one of VAR's four reviewable categories — goals, penalties, direct red cards and mistaken identity — they communicate with the referee through an earpiece. Depending on the nature of the incident, the referee may either accept the information directly or be advised to conduct an on-field review by watching replays on the pitchside monitor.

Who takes the final decision?

The final decision always rests with the referee. The VAR, in theory, is intended to correct only clear mistakes rather than re-referee subjective decisions.

Gambhir on Samson drop: 'No hard, fast rule'

Express News Service
Chennai, July 8

ON ANY other day, a 125-run defeat would have dominated a post-match press conference. Yet, when Gautam Gambhir addressed the media after India's crushing loss to England in the third T20I in Nottingham on Tuesday, the first talking point was Sanju Samson's omission rather than the collapse.

Samson's absence from India's T20I squad for the three-match Zimbabwe tour later this month had become a talking point ahead of the match and Gambhir revealed that the wicketkeeper-batter had already been given clarity.

"The first thing is that regarding the clarity Sanju Samson needed, he has been given that from my side. That's a conversation strictly between the player and the head coach. That conversation is not going to come outside," he said after the loss. "Regarding Sanju, we are very clear what he has done for India has been phenomenal, and sometimes you just have to look at the form of a certain player. There is no hard and fast rule that he cannot make a comeback in this series," he added.

India's four-match winless run comes four months after lifting the T20 World Cup, but



Gautam Gambhir said that Sanju Samson was given clarity over his absence from the T20I series in Zimbabwe. CREIMAS/BCCI

Gambhir insisted the team had not suddenly become a poor side. "I think we just haven't played well. As simple as it can get. You don't become a bad team after four games, do you? Absolutely not. You don't become a bad team if the opposition plays better than you. We haven't assessed the conditions better. We haven't read the conditions better."

"Sometimes reading the game is equally important as well. We haven't done that since Ireland. That's why we've got these results. If you don't read the conditions and don't play them better, you'll end up on the losing side," he said.



The India coach also urged patience, pointing to the significant changes made since the World Cup triumph. "If you see, there have also been a lot of changes in this T20 side. Whenever you reset a T20 team, performances like this can happen. Compare the XI that played the World Cup final with today's XI."

"There are a lot of changes. There's a new captain. A new opening combination. No Hardik Pandya. No Jasprit Bumrah. A 15-year-old is opening. Prince Yadav is playing only his second T20I. Harshit Rana is coming back after injury. It's easy to judge because ultimately we only see the result. Yes, re-

sults matter in international cricket. But it's also important to be practical."

"Sometimes you need to give players time to grow and develop. Especially against a high-quality side like England. Once you give them opportunities, they'll develop. After a reset, these things take time. We'll be fine again," Gambhir said.

Despite India's heavy defeat, Prince Yadav's performance where he claimed 2/30 was one of the few positives. Gambhir praised the young pacer for delivering in difficult phases of the innings but cautioned against reading too much into his encouraging start. "He was playing only his second T20I. It's easy to look at the analysis afterwards. But look at the overs he bowled. Whether it was inside the Powerplay, at the death or the 19th over, those are difficult overs. To perform like that in only your second T20I shows the boy has a bright future."

"It's just two games. Don't jump the gun. He's still got a lot to improve. That's where we also need to get better. He has started his T20I career really well. Especially today, in these conditions, against a batting line-up like England's, he put his hand up and performed really well. But again, he's got plenty to improve," he added.

Djokovic's greatest rival may be time, but he keeps winning battles

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, July 8

WHY DOES Novak Djokovic still put his body through a mythical grind? Is it the quest for Major No. 25, the drive to retire on a high or something else altogether? Four hours and forty-one minutes into his 2026 Wimbledon quarter-final classic against Felix Auger-Aliassime, the Serbian gave a clue.

Auger-Aliassime was serving at 15-30 in Game 8 of the fifth set. Djokovic, despite his return, was pushed onto the backfoot by a deep forehand from the Canadian. He slugged it back, scrambled to meet a crosscourt stroke and unfurled a stunning backhand down the line.

It was the shot which the very best admire, the one that's built an empire. The crowd roared in delight at having witnessed the epitome of vintage Djokovic, and the 39-year-old was perhaps referring to it (besides the eventual super tiebreak) when he said post-match, "These are the kind of moments that I still play tennis for."

After his straight-sets capitulation to Jannik Sinner last year, Djokovic had publicly come to terms with his career's



Novak Djokovic. AP

ephemerality. The wear and tear of being a pro for 22 years had perhaps left him knackered, and he found his tank was "half empty" even before the Italian challenge.

That ought to have worsened over the next 12 months, but the seven-time champion returned anyway. This time, the body wasn't the problem. At least that's what Djokovic said.

"It wasn't physical — physical was kind of okay. Just game-wise, I didn't enjoy my tennis," was his verdict after an "ugly" fourth-round win over world No. 132 Roman Safiullin. The match had frayed Djokovic's temper; he smashed a ball in

anger and mouthed a cuss word for which he apologised in the on-court interview.

Vintage Novak

All that frustration evaporated once the men's singles G.O.A.T returned to the peak of his powers, two days hence. He got better and better as the longest Wimbledon last-eight clash in history wore on. That Auger-Aliassime, playing only his second match on SW19's Centre Court, put up a show for the ages only elevated Djokovic's gameplay.

"Just one of the best matches I was honestly part of in Wimbledon," the seventh seed later told the press. "I don't recall playing this long in any match. Maybe the Roger (Federer) final in 2019 comes close in terms of the time and length. But it was really super even. Anyone's game. Felix really played at a high level."

The five-hour, fifteen-minute epic finished just six minutes short of the 11pm curfew. Just how much such a draining contest had taken out of him will remain to be seen when faces Sinner in a re-match from Wimbledon 2025. "I wish it (the match against Auger-Aliassime)

was the final, so I didn't need to worry about how the body will feel tomorrow. But I am happy, I am happy that I won."

Many would argue that entering his 55th Slam semi-final, and an eighth successive one at the grass-court Major, is an achievement enough at this stage of his journey. Not for Djokovic, though. "It's just another semi-final for me. I am going to look at all the numbers when I retire. Right now it's all business, I still have to recover, and I have the best player in the world in a few days' time."

Zverev cracks Fritz

London: Alexander Zverev cleared one of the biggest hurdles in his bid for the Wimbledon title by snapping a lengthy losing run against Taylor Fritz with a 6-4 6-4 6-2 win to make the semi-finals and stay on track for back-to-back Grand Slam triumphs. Having come up short in his last seven clashes with Fritz, including at the All England Club in 2024, French Open champion Zverev finally turned the tables with an assured display for a last-four meeting with Arthur Fery, who beat Flavio Cobolli.